▶ Notebook

Lecture 1 at a glance: five parts, twenty-two sections

Part 1 · Bayes' rule for a neural network

1.1 Bayes' rule ▶
1.2 A tiny network and its prior ▶
1.3 Likelihood and training ▶
1.4 The evidence is intractable ▶
1.5 Approximating the posterior ▶
- 1.5.1 Laplace ▶
- 1.5.2 MCMC ▶
- 1.5.3 VI ▶

Part 2 · How far apart are two distributions?

2.1 Surprise ▶
2.2 Entropy: average surprise ▶
2.3 Codes: entropy in bits ▶
2.4 Cross-entropy and KL ▶
2.5 KL at work ▶
- 2.5.1 Classification ▶
- 2.5.2 Maximum likelihood ▶
- 2.5.3 Knowledge distillation ▶

2.6 Closed forms and PyTorch ▶
2.7 KL by sampling ▶

Part 3 · Find the closest q

3.1 Search a grid ▶
3.2 Gradient descent ▶
3.3 Covariance in 2-D ▶
3.4 Mixtures: no formula ▶
3.5 The reparameterisation trick ▶
3.6 Which direction of KL? ▶

Part 4 · Back to Bayes: the ELBO

4.1 Deriving the ELBO ▶
4.2 Checking it on a coin ▶

Part 5 · Implement it

5.1 VI for the tiny network ▶
5.2 Wrap-up ▶

> Five parts, twenty-two numbered sections. The notebook uses the same numbers: the ▶ Notebook link at the top right of every slide opens its section in Colab.

▶ Notebook 1.1

Bayes' rule: update what you believe, using data

$$p(A \mid B) = \frac{p(B \mid A)\, p(A)}{p(B)}$$

$$\underbrace{p(A \mid B)}_{\text{posterior}} = \frac{\overbrace{p(B \mid A)}^{\text{likelihood}}\ \overbrace{p(A)}^{\text{prior}}}{\underbrace{p(B)}_{\text{evidence}}}$$

> Four names for the whole lecture: posterior, likelihood, prior and evidence.

▶ Notebook 1.1

In machine learning, the unknown is the parameters

$$p(\theta \mid \mathcal{D}) = \frac{p(\mathcal{D} \mid \theta)\, p(\theta)}{p(\mathcal{D})}$$

Usual training

keeps one θ: the best fit to the data $\mathcal{D}$.

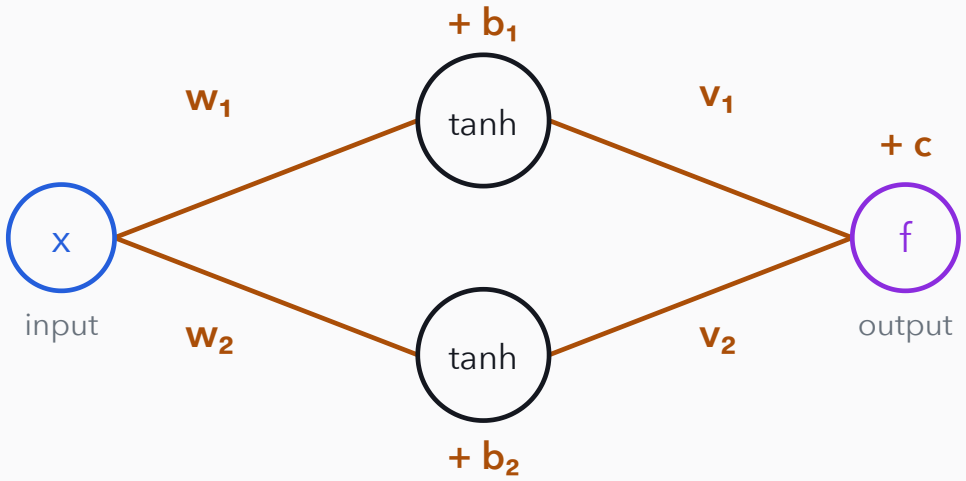
Bayesian learning

keeps every θ, weighted by $p(\theta \mid \mathcal{D})$.

> Usual training keeps one θ. The Bayesian answer keeps a whole distribution over θ.

▶ Notebook 1.2

A tiny network: one input, two hidden units, one output



$$f_\theta(x) = v_1 \tanh(w_1 x + b_1) + v_2 \tanh(w_2 x + b_2) + c$$

$$\theta = (w_1, w_2, b_1, b_2, v_1, v_2, c) \in \mathbb{R}^7$$

Seven unknown numbers: four weights and three biases.

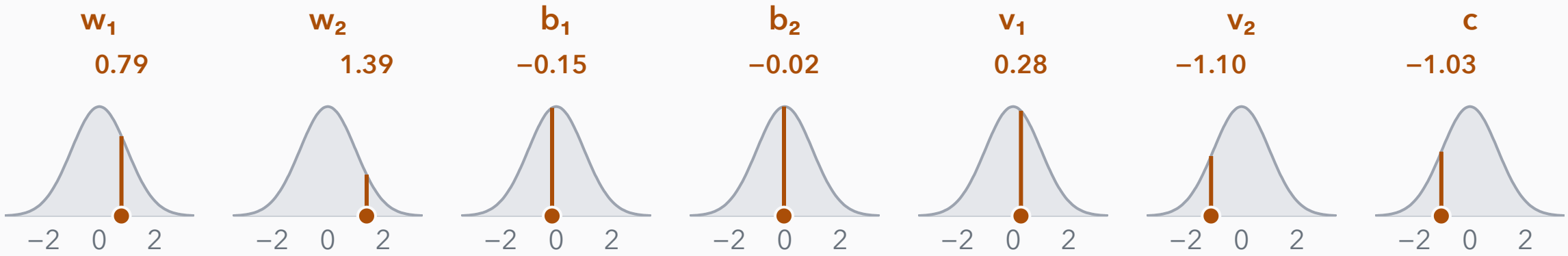
Every weight and bias is unknown, so θ is seven numbers.

▶ Notebook 1.2

A prior on every parameter

$$\theta_j \sim \mathcal{N}(0, 1), \quad j = 1, \ldots, 7$$

$$p(\theta) = \prod_{j=1}^{7} \mathcal{N}(\theta_j;\, 0,\, 1)$$



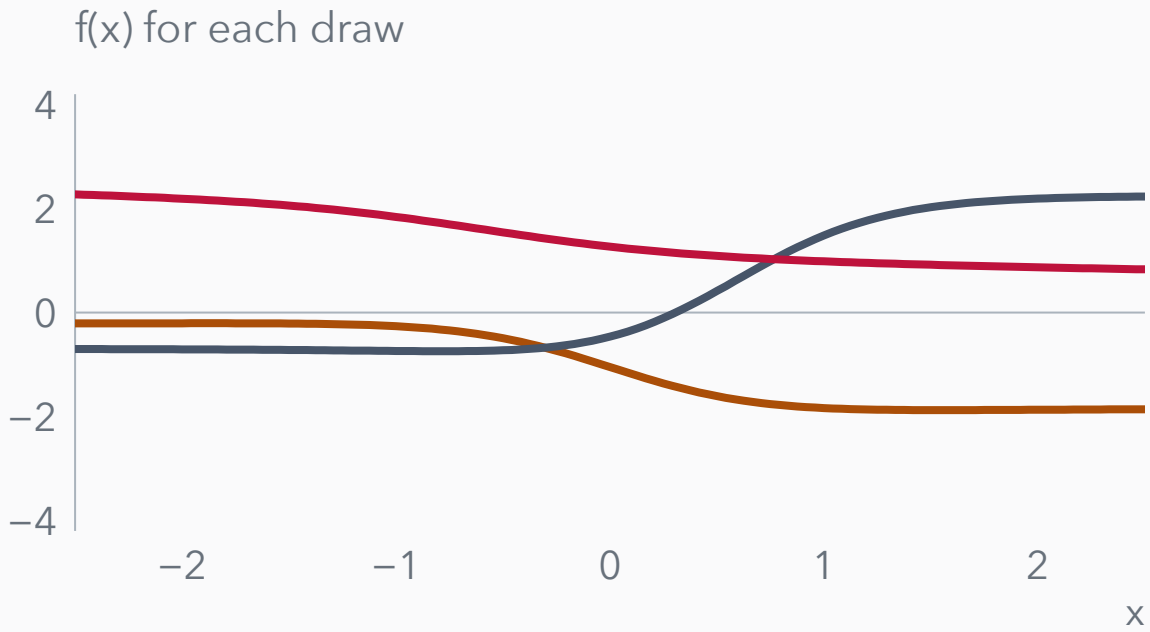
One draw from the prior is seven numbers, one from each bell: a single point θ in $\mathbb{R}^7$.

▶ Notebook 1.2

One draw of θ is one whole function

	w_1	w_2	b_1	b_2	v_1	v_2	c
$\theta^{(1)}$	0.79	1.39	−0.15	−0.02	0.28	−1.10	−1.03
$\theta^{(2)}$	−1.07	−1.40	0.04	0.78	0.45	−1.93	0.77
$\theta^{(3)}$	−1.06	0.20	−0.63	0.22	0.48	−0.56	1.66

Each row, put through the network, is one curve.

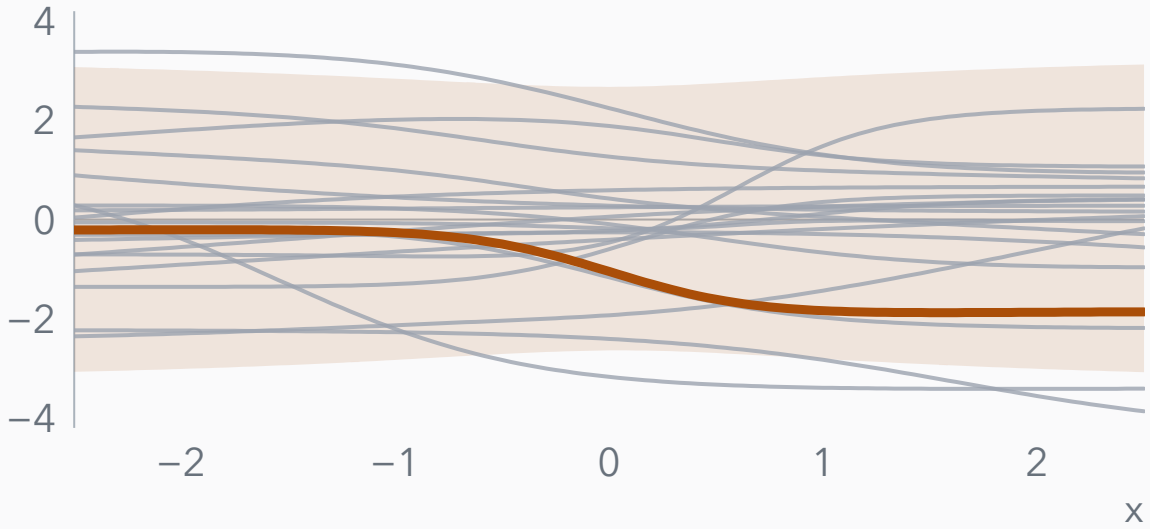


> Every point of $\mathbb{R}^7$ is a whole function. Drawing θ from the prior draws functions.

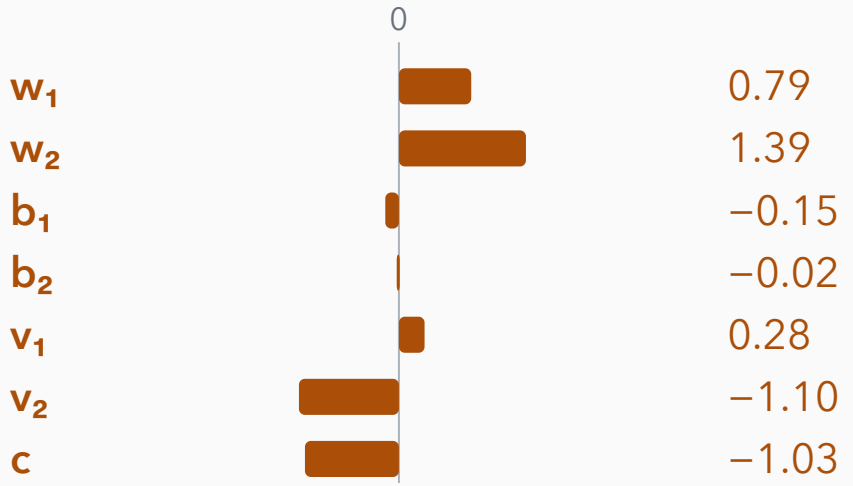
▶ Notebook 1.2

Twenty draws, and the prior predictive

20 draws, and the prior predictive: mean ± 2 sd



draw 1 of 20: $\theta^{(1)} \in \mathbb{R}^7$

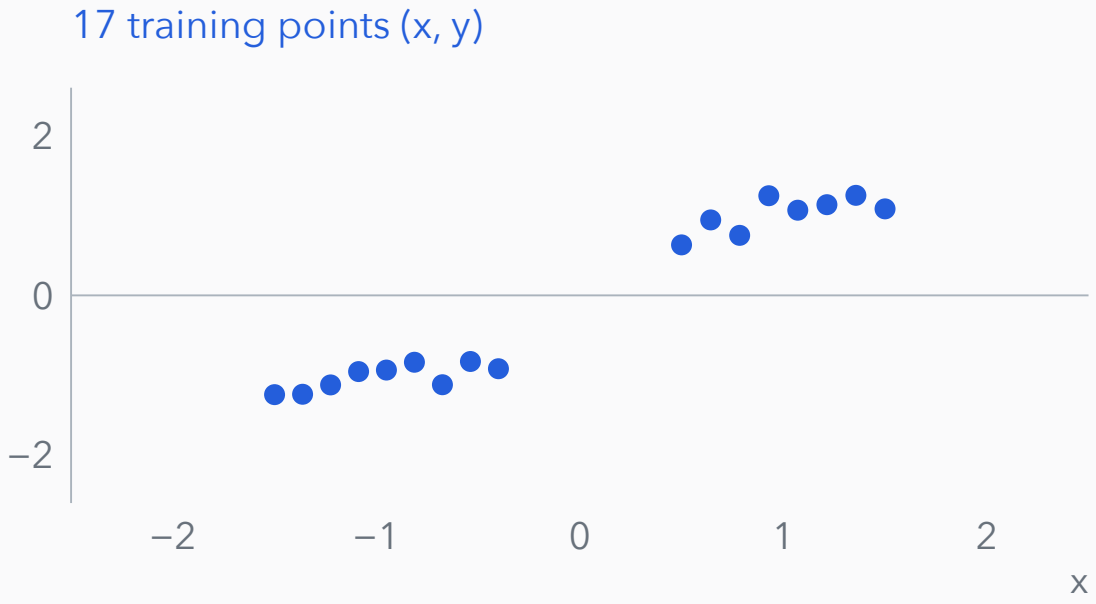


Hover over a line, or step through the draws.

> Average over every θ and add the 0.1 noise: the prior predictive, $p(y \mid x) = \int p(y \mid x, \theta)\, p(\theta)\, d\theta$. What the model expects before any data.

▶ Notebook 1.3

The data, and how well one θ explains them



$$y_i \mid x_i, \theta \sim \mathcal{N}\big(f_\theta(x_i),\, 0.1^2\big)$$

$$p(\mathcal{D} \mid \theta) = \prod_{i=1}^{17} \mathcal{N}\big(y_i;\, f_\theta(x_i),\, 0.1^2\big)$$

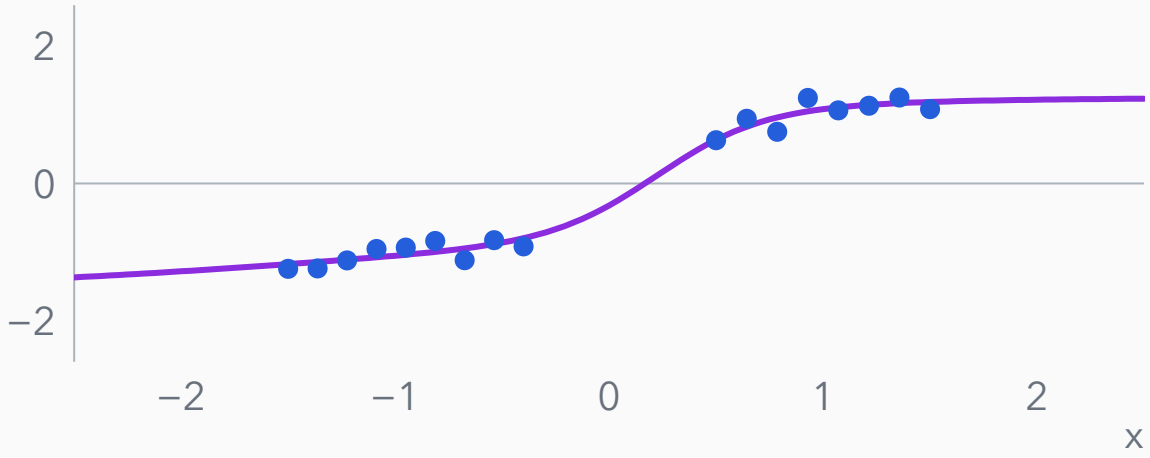
> The likelihood of θ multiplies all seventeen densities: how well this one θ explains the whole dataset.

▶ Notebook 1.3

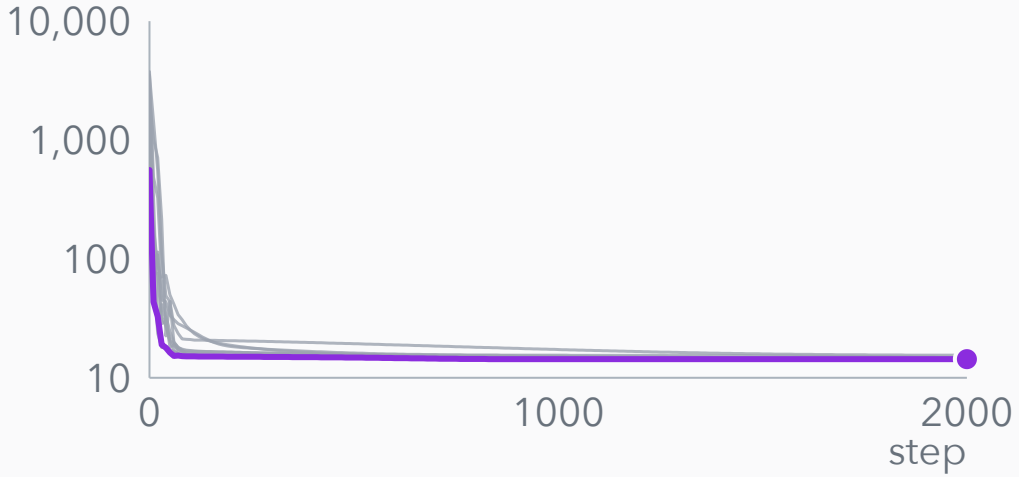
Finding a good θ: train the network

$$\theta_A = \arg\max_{\theta} \left[\log p(\mathcal{D} \mid \theta) + \log p(\theta) \right]$$

the network during training



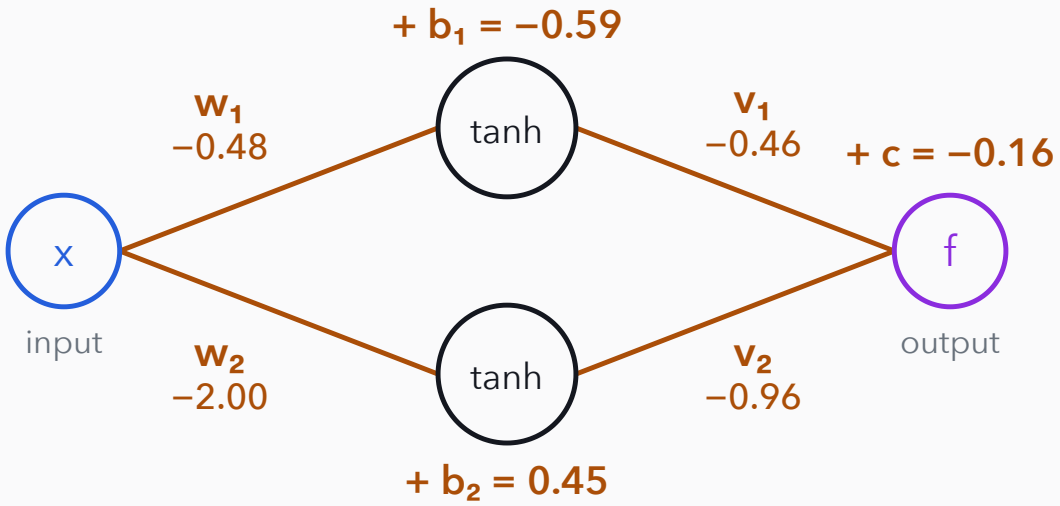
loss 14.3 · grey: the other nine starts

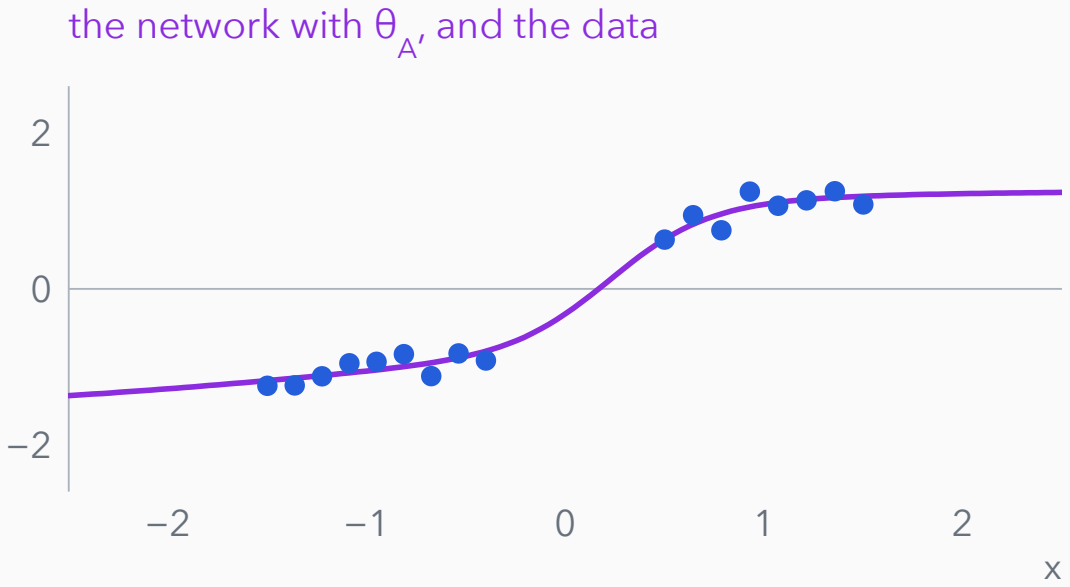


From a random start, gradient descent bends the curve onto the data. Ten starts finish at slightly different losses; the best finish is θ_A.

▶ Notebook 1.3

Meet θ_A: the network with its trained numbers





With these numbers the network's curve follows the data. Next, score θ_A with the likelihood and the prior.

▶ Notebook 1.3

The likelihood of θ_A: formula, then value

$$p(\mathcal{D} \mid \theta_A) = \prod_{i=1}^{17} \mathcal{N}\left(y_i;\, f_{\theta_A}(x_i),\, 0.1^2\right)$$

$$\log p(\mathcal{D} \mid \theta_A) = -\frac{1}{2 \cdot 0.1^2} \sum_{i=1}^{17} \left(y_i - f_{\theta_A}(x_i)\right)^2 - \frac{17}{2} \log\left(2\pi \cdot 0.1^2\right)$$

$$\log p(\mathcal{D} \mid \theta_A) = 12.17$$

Put in θ_A's curve and the seventeen points: log p($\mathcal{D}$ | θ_A) = 12.17.

▶ Notebook 1.3

The prior of θ_A, then the evidence

$$p(\theta_A) = \prod_{j=1}^{7} \mathcal{N}(\theta_j;\, 0,\, 1)$$

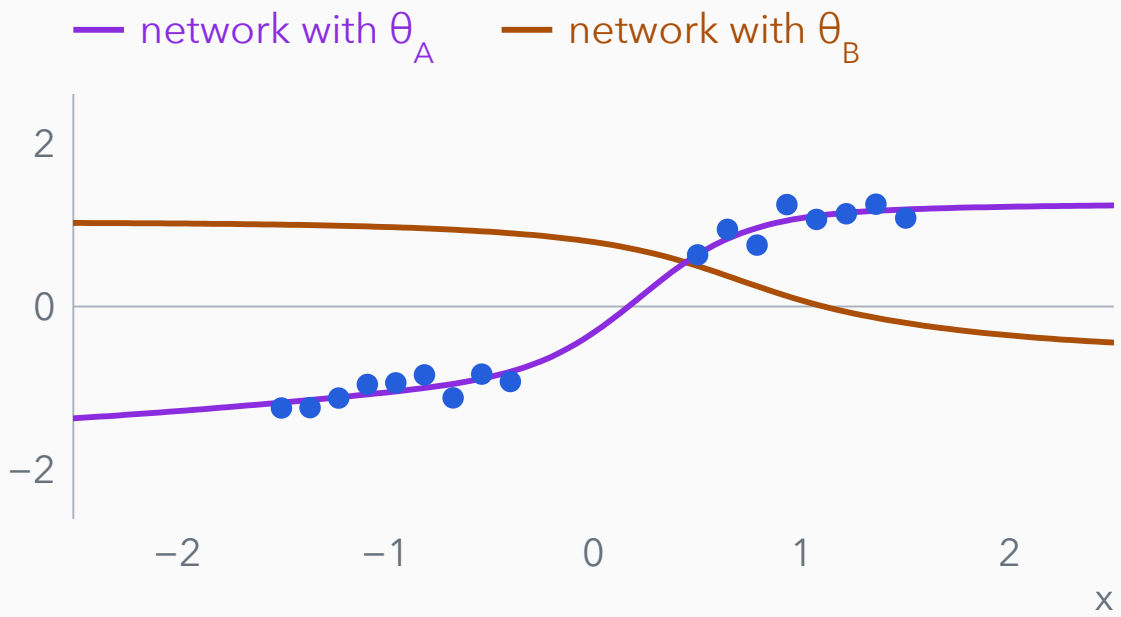
$$\log p(\theta_A) = -\frac{1}{2}\sum_{j=1}^{7} \theta_j^2 - \frac{7}{2}\log 2\pi = -9.41$$

$$p(\mathcal{D}) = \int p(\mathcal{D} \mid \theta)\, p(\theta)\, d\theta = \ \mathbf{?}$$

> The third term, the evidence, is not about θ_A: it needs every θ at once.

▶ Notebook 1.3

Two settings of θ, side by side

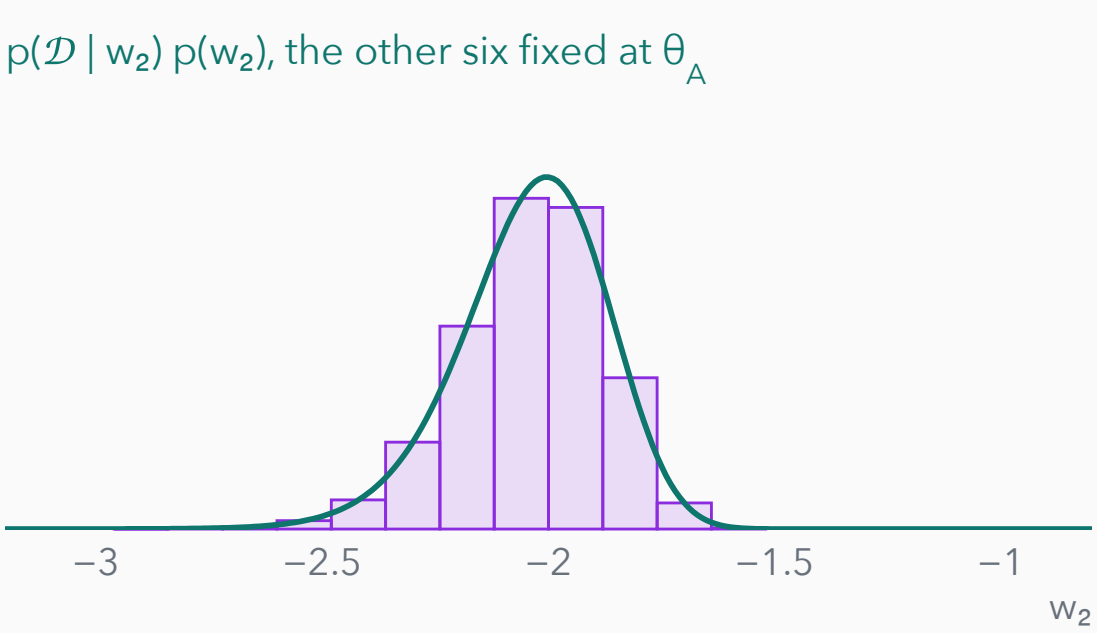


	θ_A	θ_B, a prior draw
$\log p(\mathcal{D} \mid \theta)$	12.2	−2,157.5
$\log p(\theta)$	−9.4	−9.9
sum of the two	2.8	−2,167.4

> Their priors are similar; their likelihoods differ by over 2,000 nats. A ratio of two posteriors does not even need p($\mathcal{D}$).

▶ Notebook 1.4

The evidence is an area: add up thin rectangles



Suppose only w_2 were unknown, with the other six numbers fixed at θ_A:

$$p(\mathcal{D}) = \int p(\mathcal{D} \mid w_2)\, p(w_2)\, dw_2$$

$$\approx \sum_{k=1}^{20} p(\mathcal{D} \mid w_{2,k})\, p(w_{2,k})\, \Delta w$$

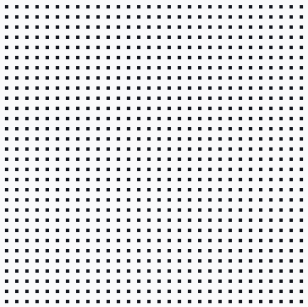
> Chop the area into thin rectangles and add them up. Twenty rectangles already match a much finer grid to three decimals.

▶ Notebook 1.4

Intractable: why the rectangles do not scale

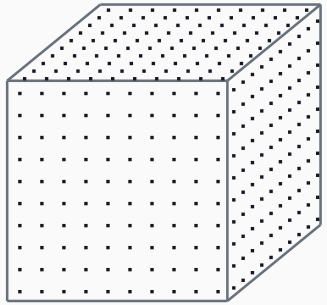
1 unknown: 100 points

2 unknowns



$100 \times 100 = 10^4$

3 unknowns



$100 \times 100 \times 100 = 10^6$

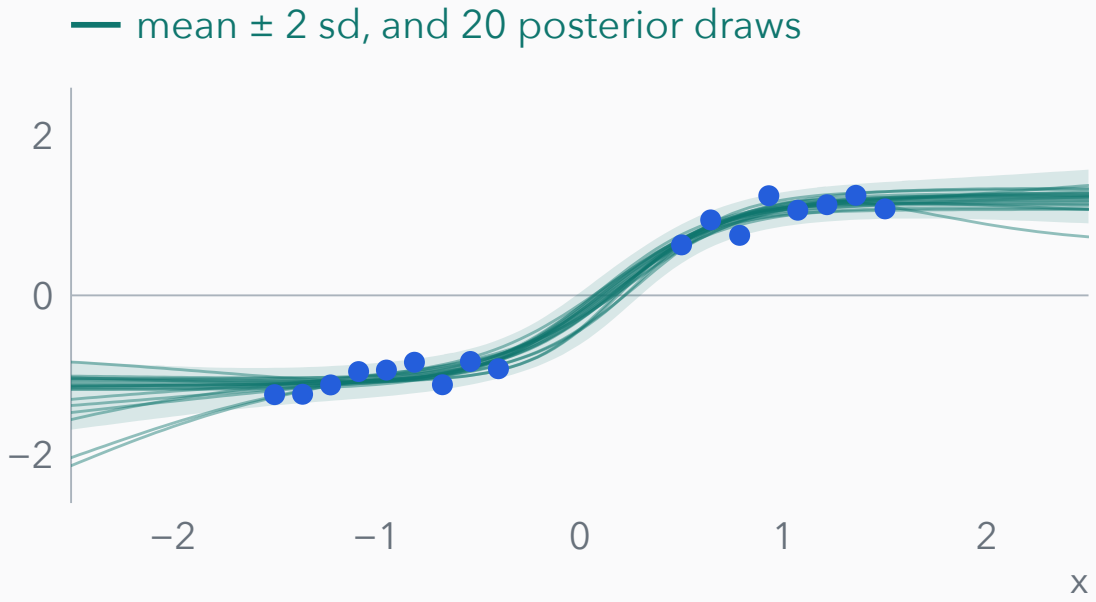
d unknowns: $100 \times 100 \times \cdots \times 100 = 100^d$ points

unknowns	grid points	at 10^9 a second
1	100	instant
2	$100^2 = 10^4$	instant
3	$100^3 = 10^6$	a millisecond
7 (our network)	$100^7 = 10^{14}$	≈ 28 hours
10^6 (a real one)	$10^{2,000,000}$	never

> Our seven: $100^7 = 10^{14}$, about 28 hours at a billion a second. A real network: $10^{2,000,000}$, never. That is what intractable means.

▶ Notebook 1.5

What we want in the end: predictions with error bars



$$p(y^* \mid x^*, \mathcal{D}) = \int p(y^* \mid x^*, \theta) \times p(\theta \mid \mathcal{D})\, d\theta$$

Average every network's prediction, weighted by the posterior. The band widens where there are no data.

> Here it comes from a long MCMC run, used only as a reference. The band widens beyond the data and in the gap.

▶ Notebook 1.5

The core problem of probabilistic machine learning

$$p(\theta \mid \mathcal{D}) = \frac{\overbrace{p(\mathcal{D} \mid \theta)}^{\text{easy}} \overbrace{p(\theta)}^{\text{easy}}}{\underbrace{p(\mathcal{D})}_{\text{intractable}}}$$

How do we compute, or approximate, the posterior $p(\theta \mid \mathcal{D})$?

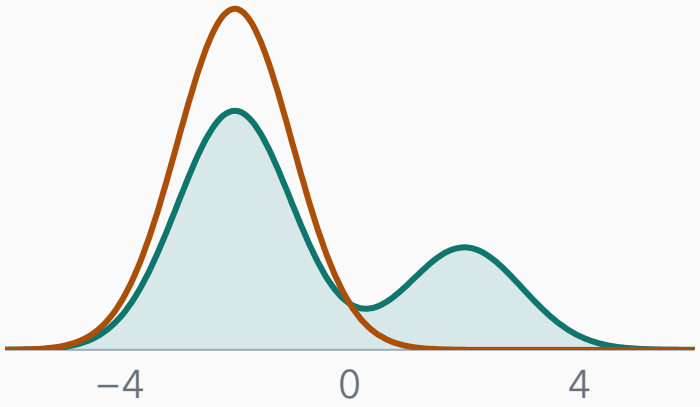
Bayesian neural networks, VAEs, mixture models and topic models all meet this same question.

> So the central question of probabilistic machine learning: how do we compute, or approximate, the posterior?

▶ Notebook 1.5

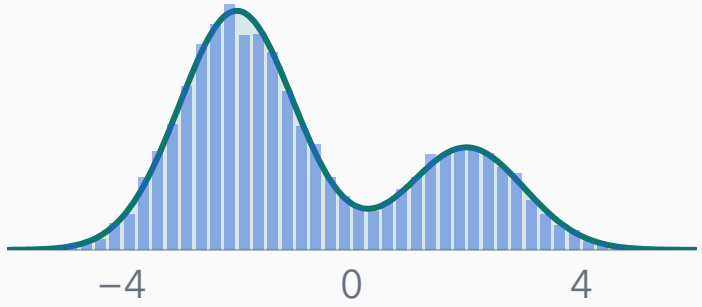
Three ways to approximate the posterior; we take the third

Laplace



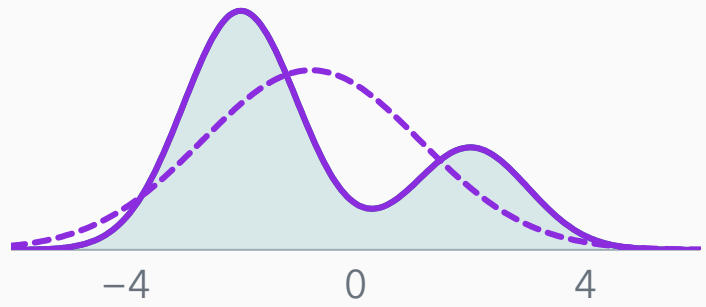
Climb to the highest peak, then fit a Gaussian there: N(−2.0, 1.0²). It never sees the second bump.

MCMC



A random walk, 20,000 steps. The visits follow the target: mean −0.80, true −0.80.

Variational inference



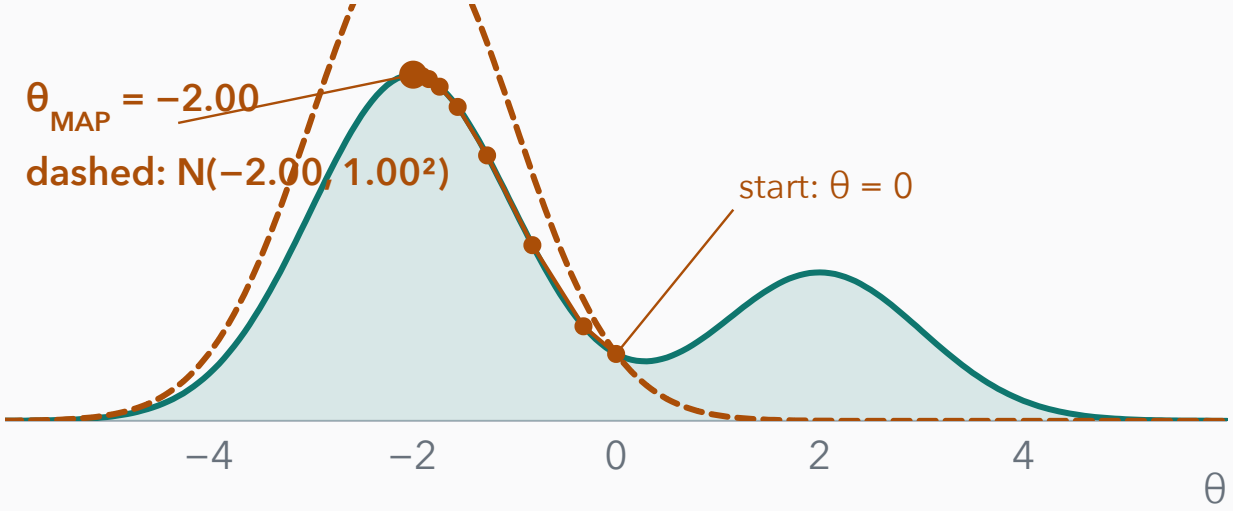
The closest member of a family we choose: one Gaussian (dashed) must stretch across both bumps; a mixture of two (solid) matches them.

> Variational inference: choose a family, then find its member closest to the posterior by optimisation. The family need not be Gaussian.

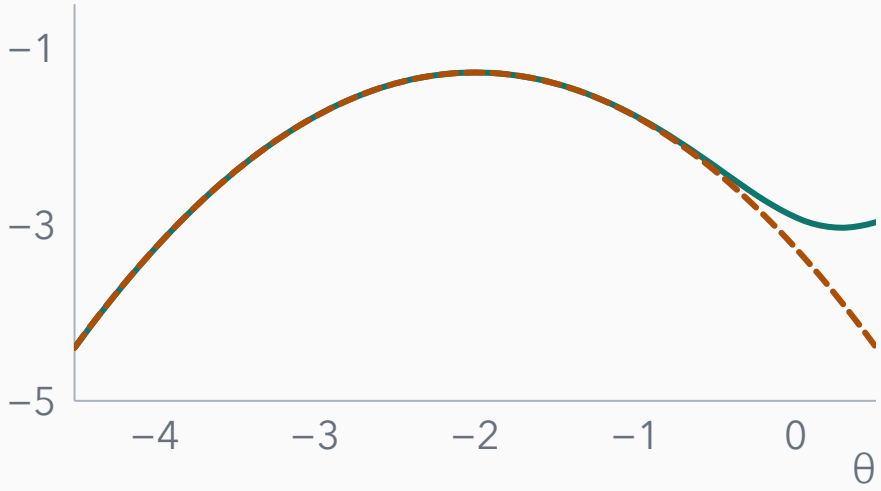
▶ Notebook 1.5.1

Laplace: climb to the peak, then fit a Gaussian there

likelihood × prior: the posterior's shape



log p near the peak, and a parabola

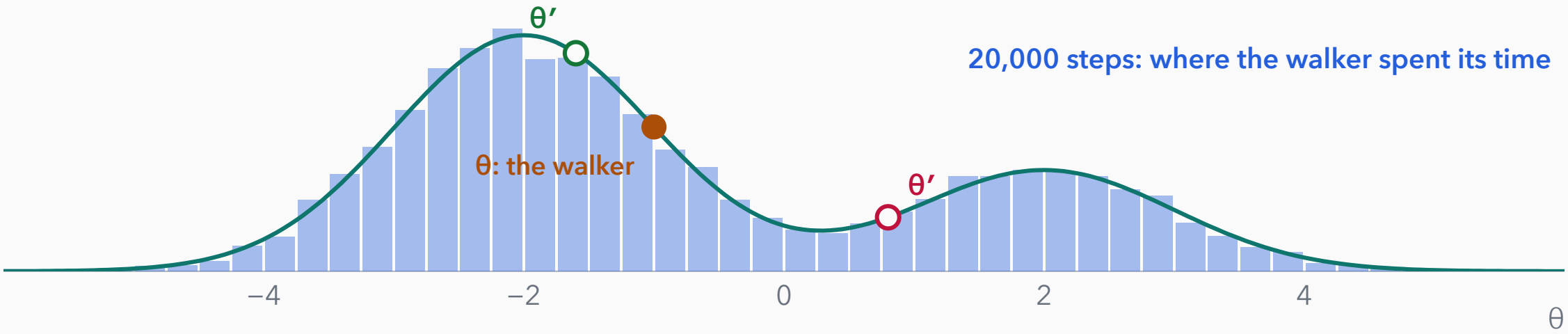


$$q_{\text{Laplace}}(\theta) = \mathcal{N}\left(\theta_{\text{MAP}},\ \sigma^2\right) = \mathcal{N}\left(-2.00,\ 1.00^2\right)$$

Step 3, fit. The Gaussian with that centre and that width matches the peak well, and never sees the second bump.

▶ Notebook 1.5.2

MCMC: a random walk that follows the posterior

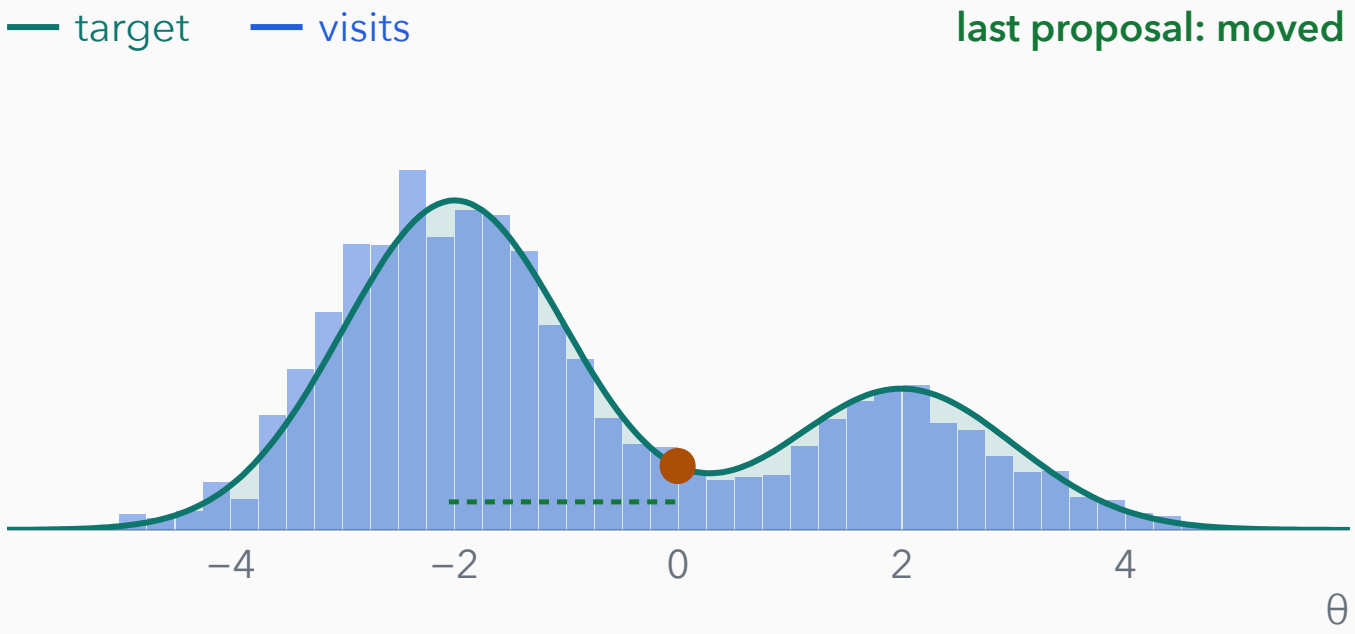


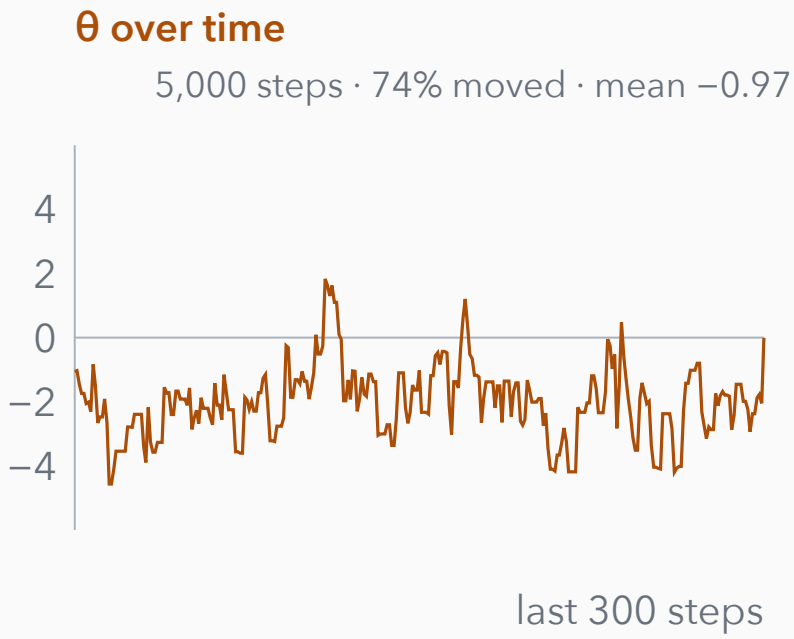
After 20,000 steps the visits follow the posterior, both bumps included: their mean is −0.80, the true mean −0.80.

> Count where the walker spends its time. In the long run the counts follow the posterior: more visits where it is high.

▶ Notebook 1.5.2

Walk it yourself: the visits build up the posterior



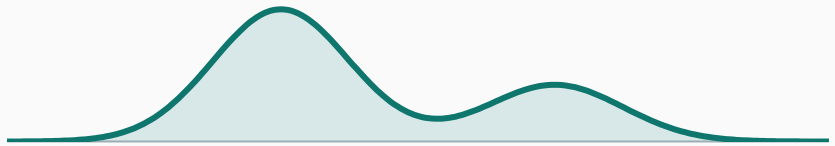


Take single steps first, then hundreds. Then try a tiny step size and a huge one: tiny steps crawl and rarely cross the gap; huge steps are mostly rejected.

▶ Notebook 1.5.3

Variational inference: choose q, make it close to the posterior

the posterior p(θ | $\mathcal{D}$)



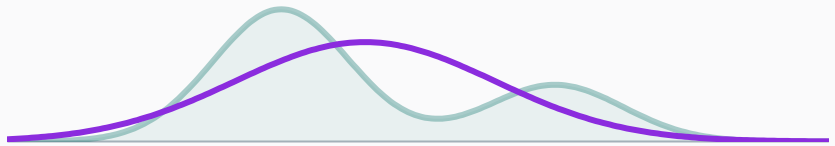
what we need: predictions, error bars

but p($\mathcal{D}$) is intractable: we cannot compute it

tune ψ to make q

as close as possible

$q_\psi(\theta)$: a distribution we control



its knobs: ψ = (μ, σ); θ ~ q is easy to draw

also called the guide (in Pyro)

$$p(y^* \mid x^*, \mathcal{D}) = \int p(y^* \mid x^*, \theta)\, p(\theta \mid \mathcal{D})\, d\theta \qquad \text{needs the posterior}$$

$$\approx \frac{1}{S} \sum_{s=1}^{S} p(y^* \mid x^*, \theta_s), \quad \theta_s \sim q_\psi(\theta) \qquad \text{needs only } q_\psi$$

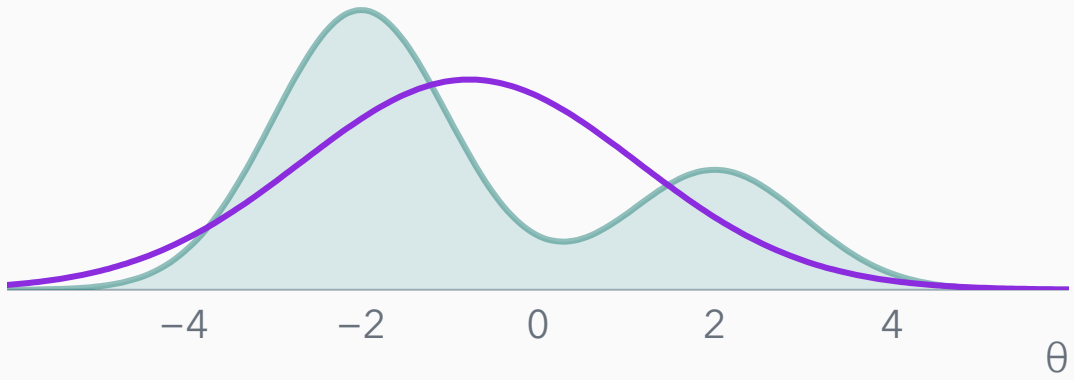
> Then use q_ψ wherever the posterior was needed. For predictions: draw networks from q_ψ and average their outputs.

▶ Notebook 1.5.3

The family is our choice: one Gaussian, or a mixture of two

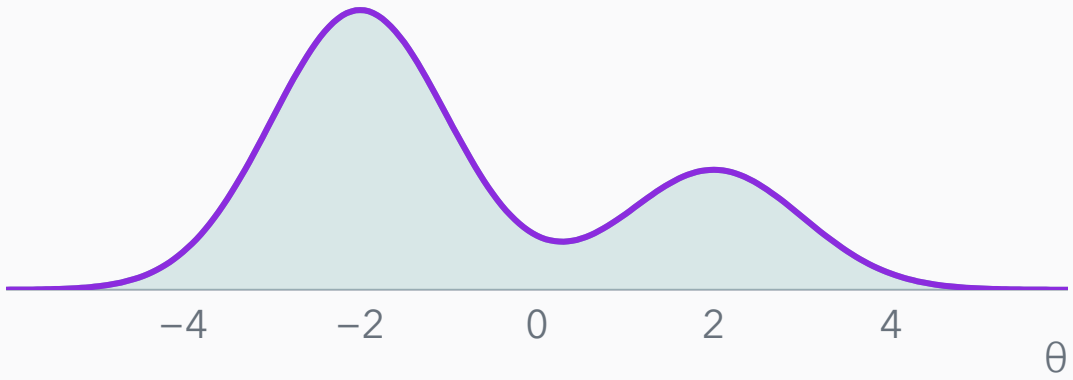
family: one Gaussian

closest member: KL(q ‖ p) = 0.24



family: mixtures of two Gaussians

closest member: KL(q ‖ p) ≈ 0

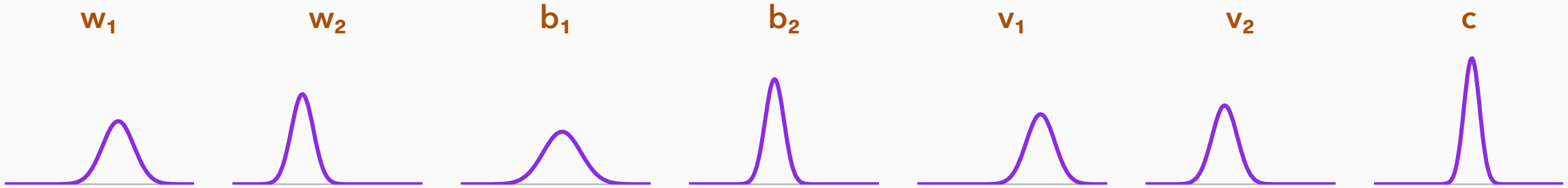


With a mixture of two Gaussians, the closest q matches both bumps and the KL falls to about 0. A richer family fits better, at the price of more knobs ψ.

▶ Notebook 1.5.3

Our q for the network: one Gaussian per parameter

$$q_\psi(\theta) = \prod_{j=1}^{7} \mathcal{N}(\theta_j;\, \mu_j,\, \sigma_j^2), \qquad \psi = (\mu_1, \ldots, \mu_7,\, \sigma_1, \ldots, \sigma_7)$$

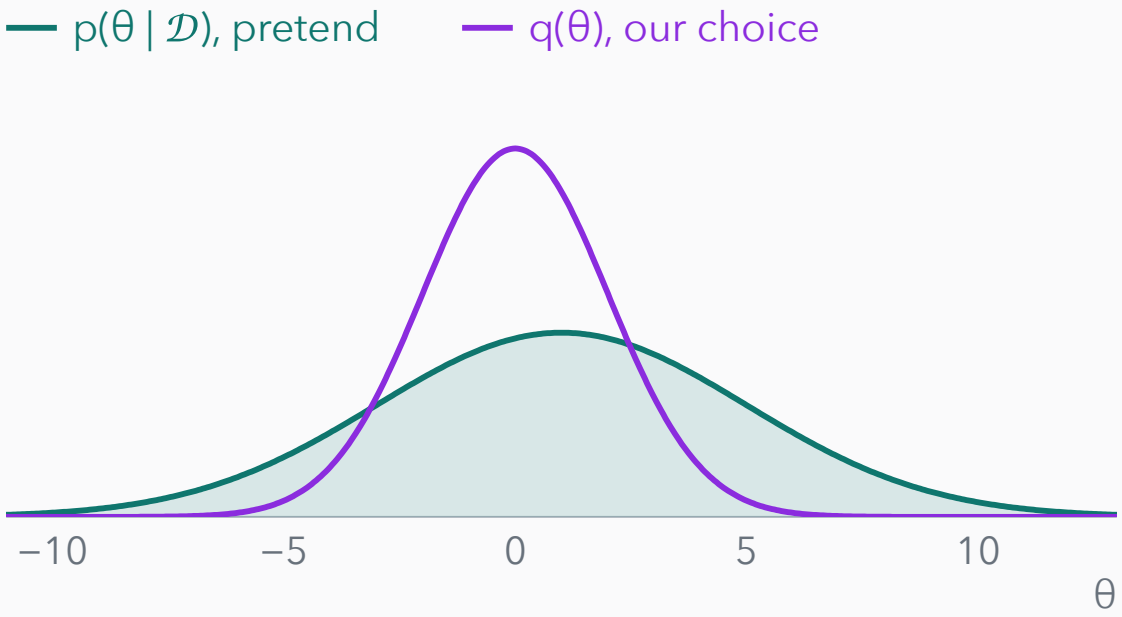


$$\psi^* = \arg\min_{\psi} \text{ distance}\big(q_\psi(\theta),\, p(\theta \mid \mathcal{D})\big)$$

> Tune ψ until q is as close as possible to the posterior. Two questions: what is "close", and how do we tune without the posterior?

▶ Notebook 2.1

For now, pretend we know the posterior



$$p(\theta \mid \mathcal{D}) = \mathcal{N}(1, 4^2)$$

A stand-in for the real posterior: known, one-dimensional, one bump.

$$q(\theta) = \mathcal{N}(\mu, \sigma^2)$$

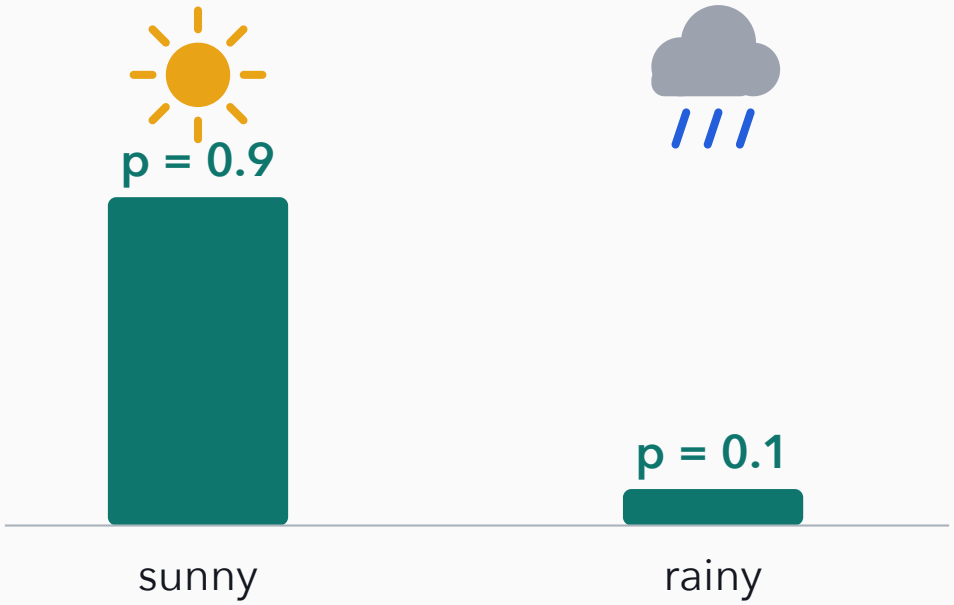
Our approximation: we choose μ and σ. Shown: μ = 0, σ = 2.

How far apart are p and q? We need one number, so that we can make it small.

> How far apart are p and q? We need one number, and we will build it from scratch, starting from surprise.

▶ Notebook 2.1

How surprised would you be? A forecast of 90% sun



The forecast for tomorrow: sun with probability 0.9, rain with probability 0.1.

If it rains you are surprised; if the sun shines, hardly at all. **Rare outcomes carry more surprise.**

Surprise is information: the outcome you did not expect tells you the most.

> Rain would surprise you; sun would not. We want a number for surprise: big for rare outcomes, small for common ones.

Story after Jia-Bin Huang, "Fantastic KL Divergence and How to (Actually) Compute It" (YouTube)

▶ Notebook 2.1

What should surprise be? Three requirements

$$I(1) = 0$$

a certain outcome is no surprise

$$p \downarrow \Rightarrow \; I(p) \uparrow$$

rarer means more surprising

$$I(p_1\, p_2) = I(p_1) + I(p_2)$$

two independent days: probabilities multiply, surprises add

candidate	I(1) = 0	rarer, more	days add: I(½ · 0.1) vs I(½) + I(0.1)
$1 - p$	✓	✓	✗ 0.95 vs 1.4
$1/p$	✗ 1	✓	✗ 20 vs 12
$\log_2 \frac{1}{p}$	✓	✓	✓ 4.32 = 1 + 3.32

> The logarithm passes all three: log $1/(p_1p_2)$ = log $1/p_1$ + log $1/p_2$. Only the log turns products into sums. So surprise is I(x) = log 1/p(x).

Story after Jia-Bin Huang, "Fantastic KL Divergence and How to (Actually) Compute It" (YouTube)

▶ Notebook 2.1

Five days: probabilities multiply, surprises add



p = 0.9	×	p = 0.9	×	p = 0.9	×	p = 0.9	×	p = 0.9	**= 0.590** probabilities multiply
0.152 bits	+	0.152 bits	+	0.152 bits	+	0.152 bits	+	0.152 bits	**= 0.76 bits** surprises add: $\log_2 1/0.590 = 0.76$



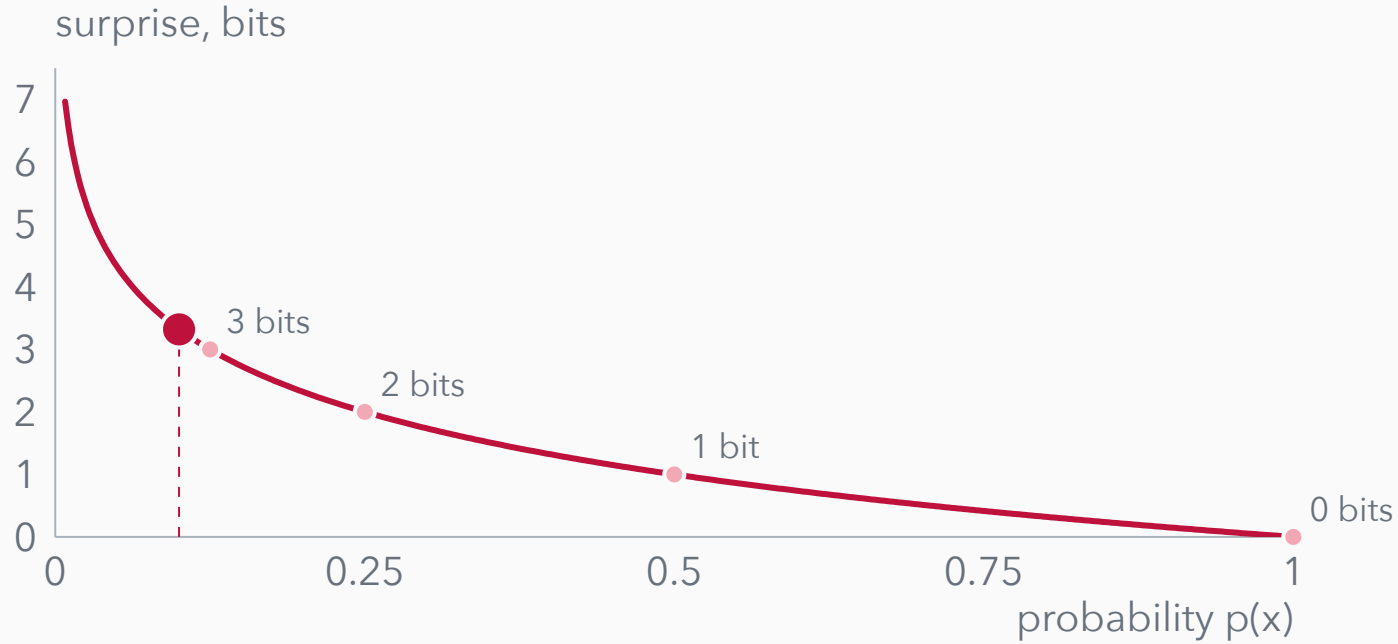
p = 0.9	×	p = 0.9	×	p = 0.1	×	p = 0.9	×	p = 0.9	**= 0.0656** probabilities multiply
0.152 bits	+	0.152 bits	+	3.32 bits	+	0.152 bits	+	0.152 bits	**= 3.93 bits** surprises add: $\log_2 1/0.0656 = 3.93$

> Make one day rainy: the probability drops to 0.066 and the surprise jumps to 3.93 bits. The single rainy day carries most of it.

Story after Jia-Bin Huang, "Fantastic KL Divergence and How to (Actually) Compute It" (YouTube)

▶ Notebook 2.1

Surprise in bits: $I(x) = \log_2 1/p(x)$



p(x) = 0.10

surprise = $\log_2 1/p$ = 3.32 bits

= ln $1/p$ = 2.30 nats

a rare outcome: a real surprise

one bit = the surprise of a fair coin flip

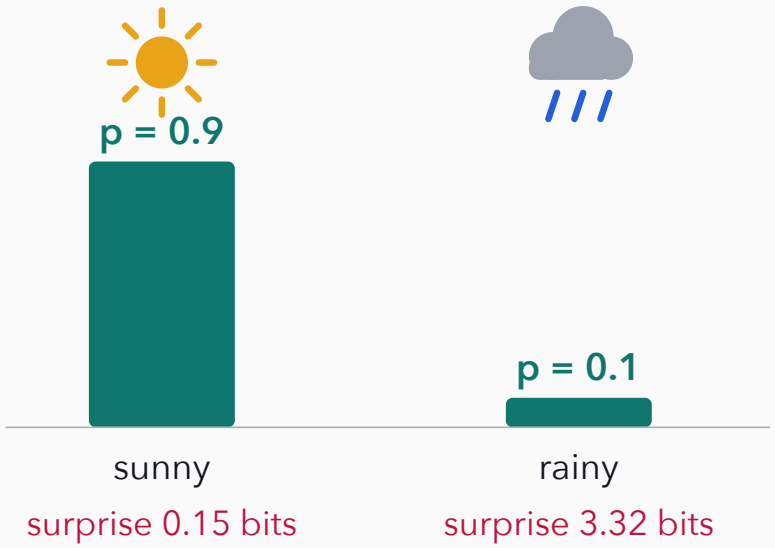
Base 2 gives bits; the natural log gives nats; 1 nat ≈ 1.44 bits.

> One bit is the surprise of a fair coin flip: one yes/no answer you could not guess. Information theory counts in bits, PyTorch in nats.

Story after Jia-Bin Huang, "Fantastic KL Divergence and How to (Actually) Compute It" (YouTube)

▶ Notebook 2.2

Entropy: how surprised are you, on average?



$$\text{sunny: } \log_2 \frac{1}{0.9} = 0.15 \text{ bits}$$

$$\text{rainy: } \log_2 \frac{1}{0.1} = 3.32 \text{ bits}$$

$$H = 0.9\,(0.15) + 0.1\,(3.32) = 0.47 \text{ bits}$$

$$H(p) = \sum_x p(x) \log_2 \frac{1}{p(x)} = \mathbb{E}_{x \sim p}\left[\log_2 \frac{1}{p(x)}\right]$$

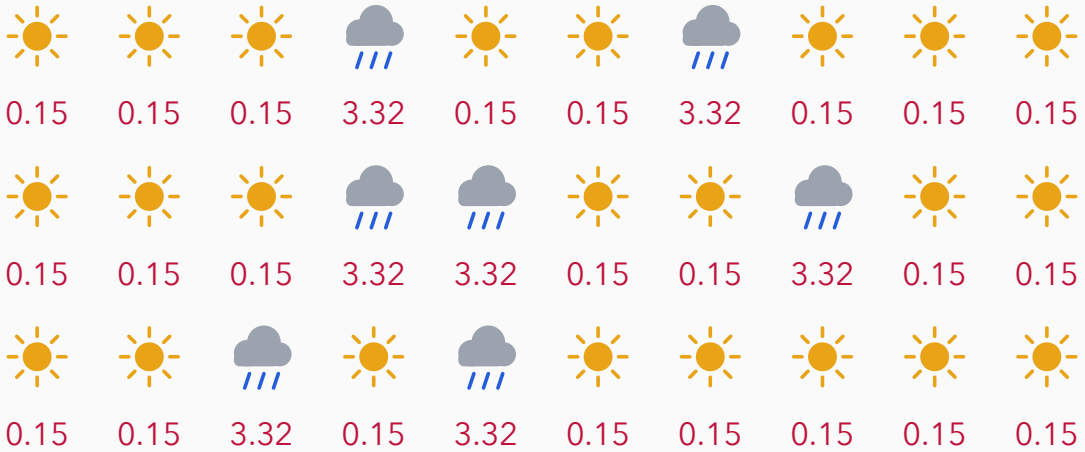
> That weighted average of surprise is the entropy: the surprise you expect from one draw.

Story after Jia-Bin Huang, "Fantastic KL Divergence and How to (Actually) Compute It" (YouTube)

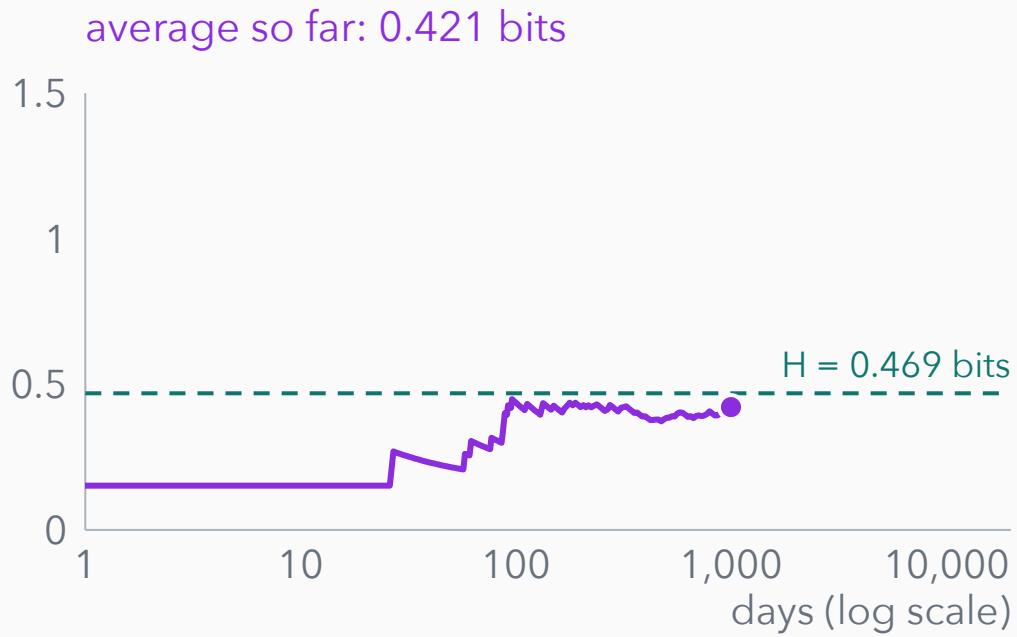
▶ Notebook 2.2

Why an expectation? It is the average over many days

days drawn from the forecast (latest 30), with their surprise



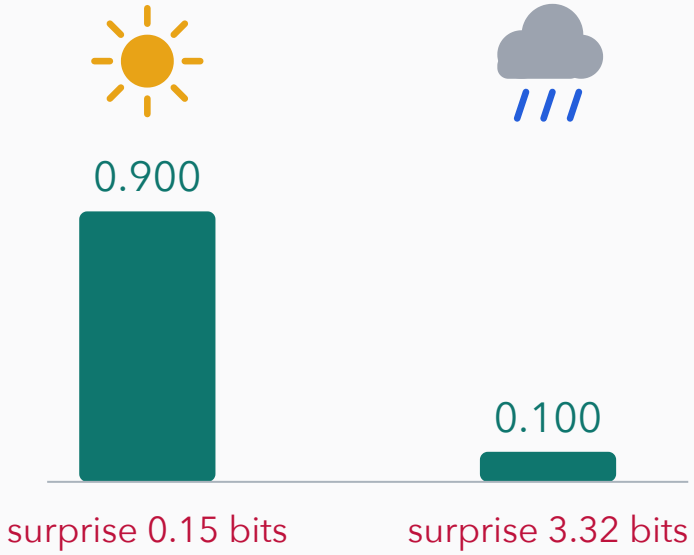
1,000 days



> Let days go by, each with its surprise: 0.15 bits if sunny, 3.32 if rainy. The running average settles on 0.47 bits. An expectation is a long-run average.

▶ Notebook 2.2

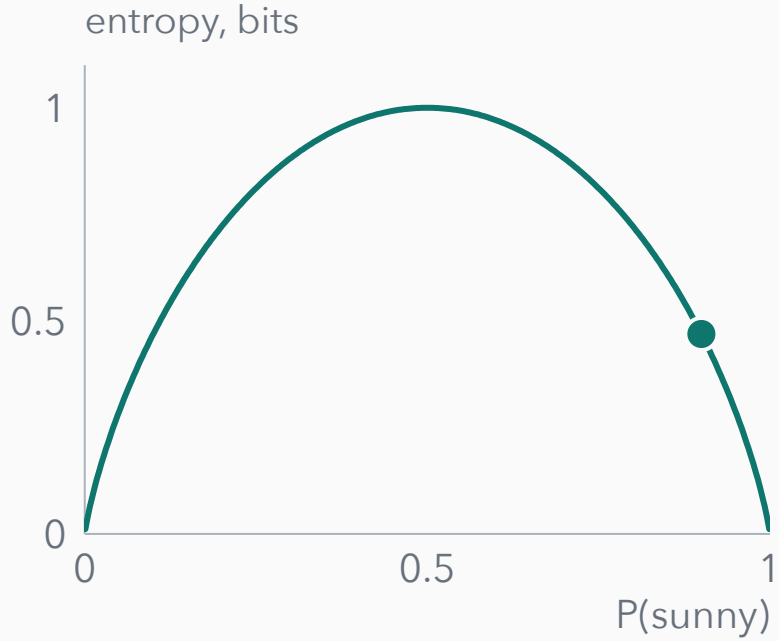
From certain to fully uncertain: between 0 and 1 bit



H = average surprise

= 0.900 × 0.15 + 0.100 × 3.32

= 0.469 bits

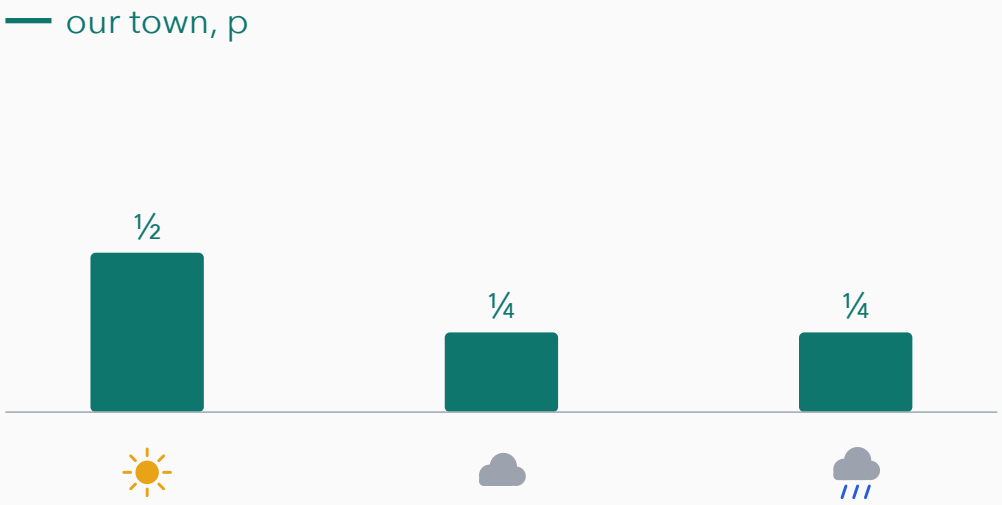


> Drag the chance of sun. A 50/50 forecast carries 1 bit, the most two outcomes can; 87.5/12.5 carries 0.54; a certain forecast, 0.

Story after Jia-Bin Huang, "Fantastic KL Divergence and How to (Actually) Compute It" (YouTube)

▶ Notebook 2.2

Three kinds of weather: 1.5 bits



weather	p	$\log_2 \frac{1}{p}$
sunny	½	1 bit
cloudy	¼	2 bits
rainy	¼	2 bits

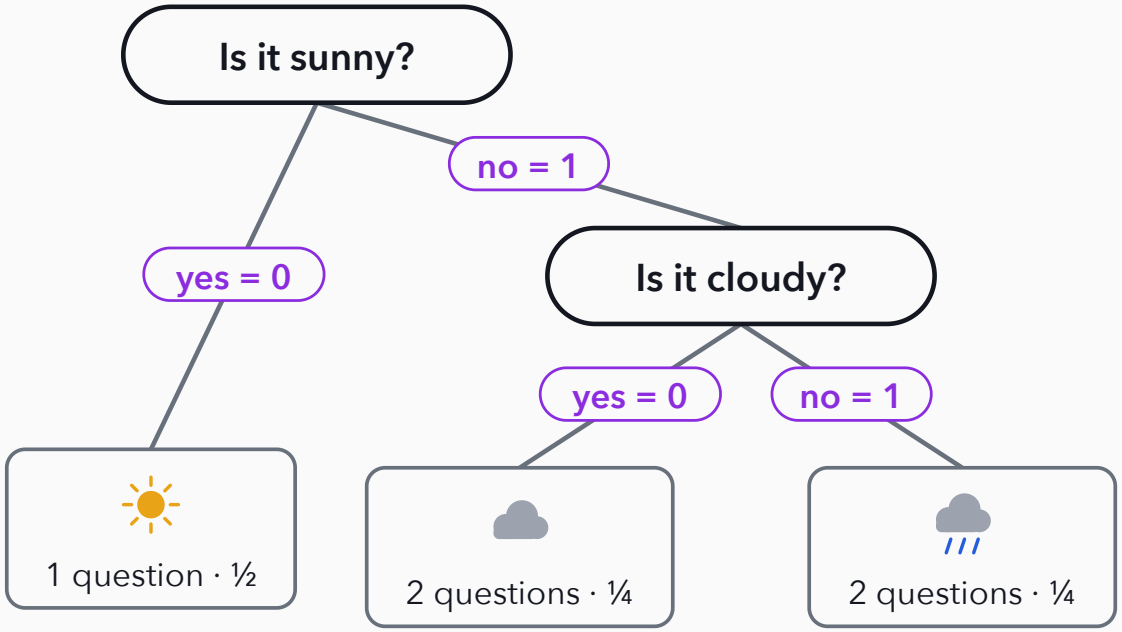
$$H = \frac{1}{2}(1) + \frac{1}{4}(2) + \frac{1}{4}(2) = 1.5 \text{ bits}$$

> Average surprise: ½(1) + ¼(2) + ¼(2) = 1.5 bits per day.

Story after Jia-Bin Huang, "Fantastic KL Divergence and How to (Actually) Compute It" (YouTube)

▶ Notebook 2.2

Entropy counts yes/no questions



Guess today's weather with yes/no questions, asking about the likeliest first.

$$\tfrac{1}{2}(1) + \tfrac{1}{4}(2) + \tfrac{1}{4}(2) = 1.5 \text{ questions}$$

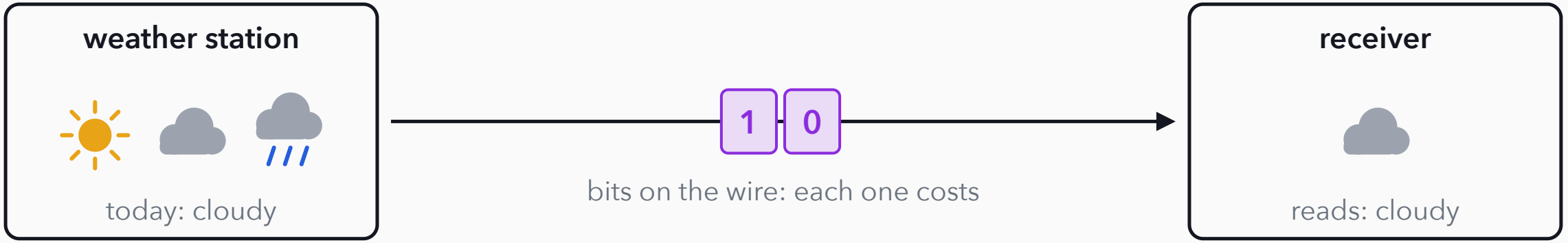
Write each answer as a bit, yes = 0 and no = 1: sunny is **0**, cloudy **10**, rainy **11**. That is a code.

> Each answer is one bit. Writing the answers down gives a code for the weather: Section 2.3.

Story after Jia-Bin Huang, "Fantastic KL Divergence and How to (Actually) Compute It" (YouTube)

▶ Notebook 2.3

Way 2: send the weather, in bits



	sunny	cloudy	rainy
how often, p	½	¼	¼

> Sunny on half the days, cloudy on a quarter, rainy on a quarter: p = (½, ¼, ¼).

Coding story after Aurélien Géron, "A Short Introduction to Entropy, Cross-Entropy and KL-Divergence" (YouTube)

▶ Notebook 2.3

A code: a string of bits for each kind of day

weather	p	uniform code	bits
sunny	½	`00`	2
cloudy	¼	`01`	2
rainy	¼	`10`	2

The simplest code gives every kind of day the same length: 2 bits.

Fair, but wasteful: half the days are sunny, yet a sunny day costs as much as a rare one.

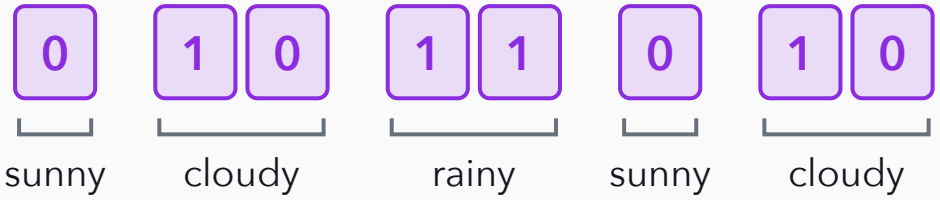
> Wasteful: common days cost as much as rare ones. Could common days get shorter strings?

Coding story after Aurélien Géron, "A Short Introduction to Entropy, Cross-Entropy and KL-Divergence" (YouTube)

▶ Notebook 2.3

Prefix codes: the bits split up without separators

prefix code: sunny 0 · cloudy 10 · rainy 11



→ the receiver reads left to right; each day is unambiguous

not a prefix code: sunny 0 · cloudy 01 · rainy 1



= sunny, then rainy?

or cloudy?

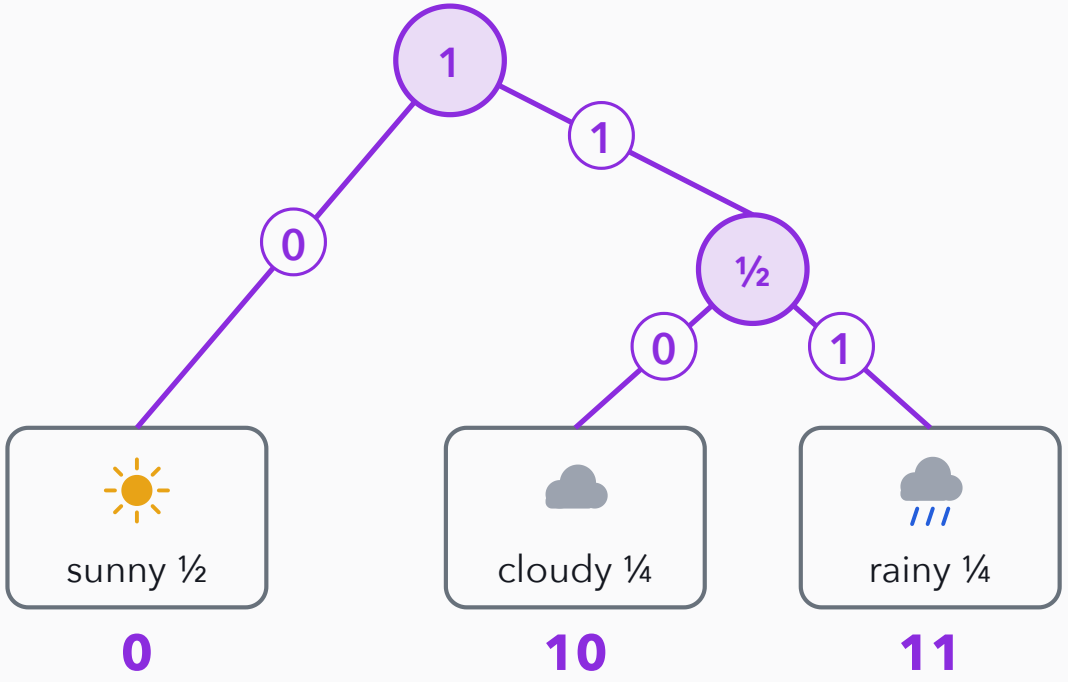
0 is the start of 01, so the receiver cannot tell.

> Break that rule, say 0, 01 and 1, and "01" could mean cloudy, or sunny then rainy. A prefix code avoids the confusion.

Coding story after Aurélien Géron, "A Short Introduction to Entropy, Cross-Entropy and KL-Divergence" (YouTube)

▶ Notebook 2.3

Huffman's recipe: merge the two rarest, repeat



Huffman (1952) builds the best prefix code from the probabilities:

1. Merge the two least likely outcomes into one node.

2. Repeat until one node is left.

3. Read each codeword off its path: left 0, right 1.

Read the codes off the tree: sunny 0, cloudy 10, rainy 11. The question game's code.

▶ Notebook 2.3

Each codeword is exactly as long as its surprise

weather	p	code	length	surprise
sunny	½	`0`	1	1 bit
cloudy	¼	`10`	2	2 bits
rainy	¼	`11`	2	2 bits

$$\text{average length} = \tfrac{1}{2}(1) + \tfrac{1}{4}(2) + \tfrac{1}{4}(2) = 1.5 \text{ bits} = H(p)$$

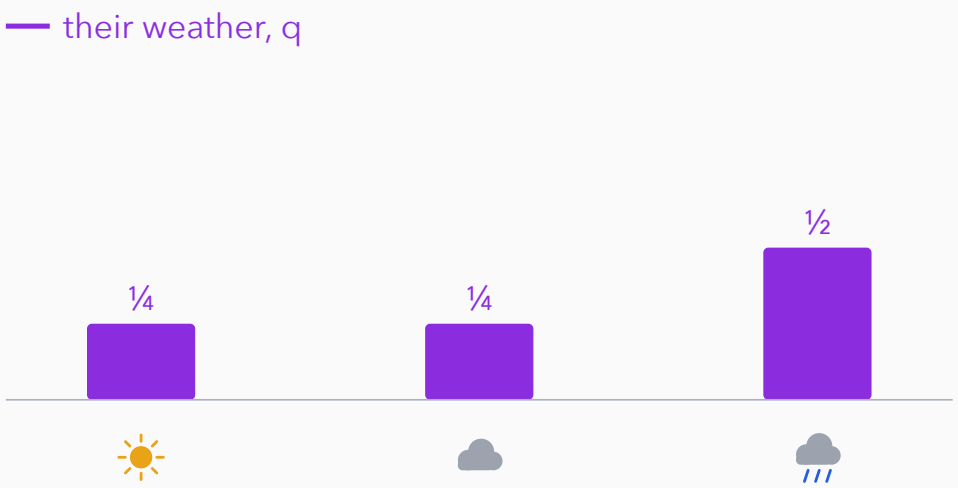
Shannon (1948): no code averages fewer than H(p) bits. Huffman reaches it when every probability is a power of ½, and comes within 1 bit otherwise.

> So the average message length is the average surprise, the entropy: 1.5 bits per day instead of 2.

Story after Jia-Bin Huang, "Fantastic KL Divergence and How to (Actually) Compute It" (YouTube)

▶ Notebook 2.4

Another town: weather q, and the best code for it



weather	q	Huffman code	length: $\log_2 1/q$
sunny	¼	10	2
cloudy	¼	11	2
rainy	½	0	1

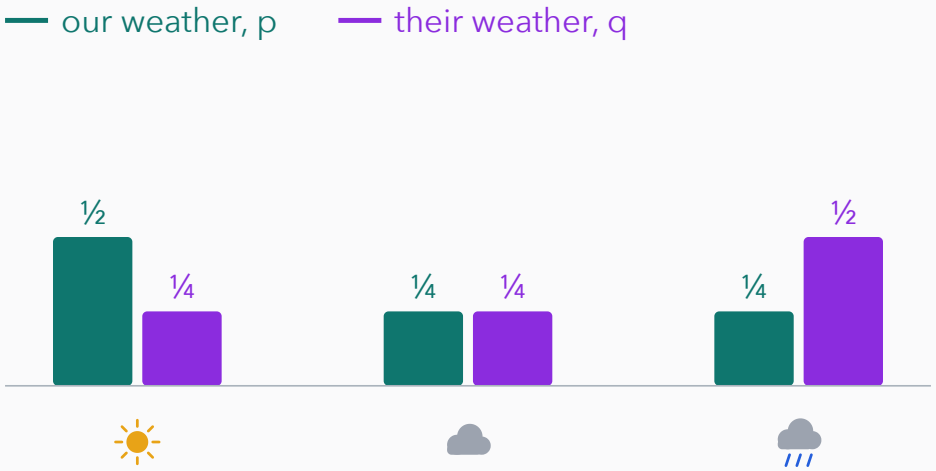
$$H(q) = \frac{1}{4} \cdot 2 + \frac{1}{4} \cdot 2 + \frac{1}{2} \cdot 1 = 1.5 \text{ bits}$$

> In their own town this code is perfect: it averages H(q) = 1.5 bits a day, the entropy of q. Each length is $\log_2 1/q$, the surprise under q.

Story after Jia-Bin Huang, "Fantastic KL Divergence and How to (Actually) Compute It" (YouTube)

▶ Notebook 2.4

Their code, our weather: a code that expects q



weather	how often here: p	their code	its length: $\log_2 1/q$
sunny	½	10	2
cloudy	¼	11	2
rainy	¼	0	1

The code **expects q**: its lengths are right only if days arrive with q's frequencies. Ours arrive with p's, so our common sunny days get a long codeword.

> "The code expects q" means it was built for days that follow q. Here sunny, half of our days, costs 2 bits instead of 1.

Story after Jia-Bin Huang, "Fantastic KL Divergence and How to (Actually) Compute It" (YouTube)

▶ Notebook 2.4

Cross-entropy: the average cost when the code expects q

weather	how often: p(x)	bits paid: $\log_2 1/q(x)$	contribution
sunny	½	2	½ × 2 = 1
cloudy	¼	2	¼ × 2 = ½
rainy	¼	1	¼ × 1 = ¼
average per day			**1.75 bits**

$$H(p, q) = \sum_x p(x) \log_2 \frac{1}{q(x)} = \tfrac{1}{2} \cdot 2 + \tfrac{1}{4} \cdot 2 + \tfrac{1}{4} \cdot 1 = 1.75 \text{ bits}$$

$$H(p, p) = H(p) = \tfrac{1}{2} \cdot 1 + \tfrac{1}{4} \cdot 2 + \tfrac{1}{4} \cdot 2 = 1.5 \text{ bits}$$

> With our own code, q = p, the same formula gives the entropy, 1.5 bits. Their code costs 0.25 bits more per day.

Story after Jia-Bin Huang, "Fantastic KL Divergence and How to (Actually) Compute It" (YouTube)

▶ Notebook 2.4

Watch it happen: our weather through both codes

the latest days, and the bits each code sends



code for p	11	11	11	0	0	0	11	10
code for q	0	0	0	10	10	10	0	11

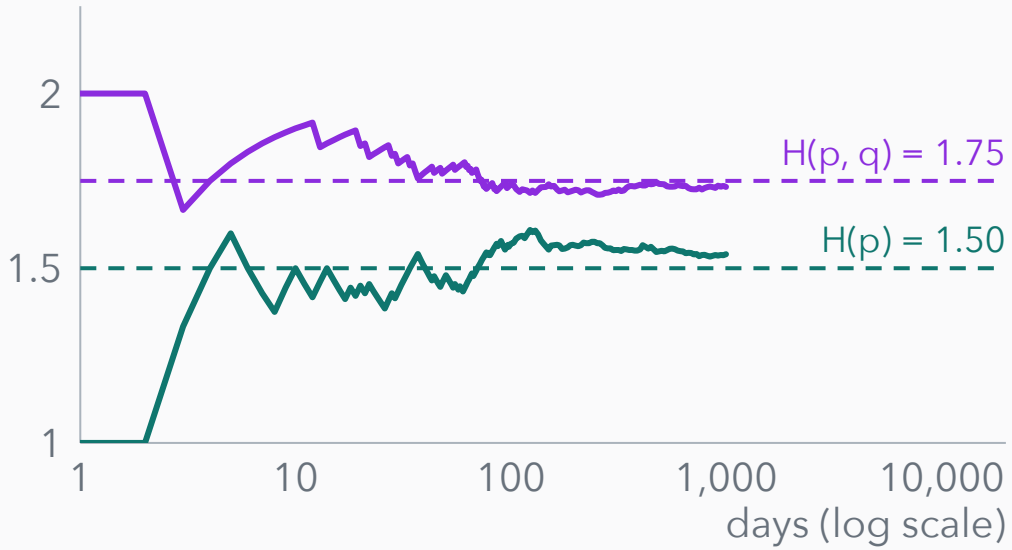
1,000 days sent

code for p: 1,540 bits, 1.540 per day

code for q: 1,733 bits, 1.733 per day

wasted: 0.193 bits per day

bits per day so far



> Send days of our weather through both codes. With 10, 100, 1,000 days the right code settles at 1.5 bits per day and the wrong one at 1.75: 0.25 bits per day wasted.

▶ Notebook 2.4

KL divergence: the extra bits we waste

weather	how often: p	their code: $\log_2 1/q$	our code: $\log_2 1/p$	extra bits
sunny	½	2	1	+1
cloudy	¼	2	2	0
rainy	¼	1	2	−1
average		**1.75**	**1.5**	**+0.25**

$$\begin{aligned} \mathrm{KL}(p \,\|\, q) &= H(p,q) - H(p) && = 1.75 - 1.5 \\ &= \sum_x p(x)\left(\log_2 \frac{1}{q(x)} - \log_2 \frac{1}{p(x)}\right) && = \tfrac{1}{2}(+1) + \tfrac{1}{4}(0) + \tfrac{1}{4}(-1) \\ &= \sum_x p(x)\, \log_2 \frac{p(x)}{q(x)} && = 0.25 \text{ bits per day} \end{aligned}$$

> A difference of logs is the log of a ratio: KL(p ‖ q) = Σ p log p/q. Inside, p/q compares the two beliefs on each day; outside, p says how often that day comes.

Story after Jia-Bin Huang, "Fantastic KL Divergence and How to (Actually) Compute It" (YouTube)

▶ Notebook 2.4

Never negative, and zero only for the right code

$$H(p, q) \geq H(p) \quad \Longrightarrow \quad \mathrm{KL}(p \,\|\, q) \geq 0$$

No code averages fewer than H(p) bits, so a code built for q can only waste bits.

$$\mathrm{KL}(p \,\|\, q) = 0 \quad \Longleftrightarrow \quad q = p$$

Single terms can be negative, as rainy's was; the weighted total cannot. Part 4 proves KL ≥ 0 for any distributions in one line.

> And it is zero only when the belief matches the truth.

▶ Notebook 2.4

Reading KL(p ‖ q): data from the left, code from the right

$$\mathrm{KL}(p \,\|\, q) = \sum_x \underbrace{p(x)}_{\text{how often: the data}} \log_2 \frac{p(x)}{\underbrace{q(x)}_{\text{the code, or model}}}$$

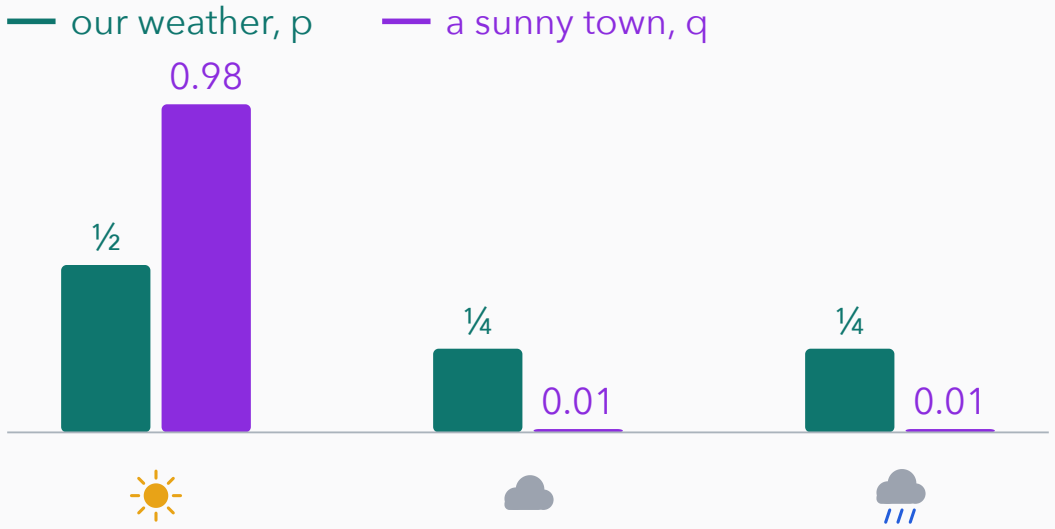
	left: p	right: q
its role	the reference: where the data come from	the model: the code we use
in the sum	supplies the weights	supplies the lengths
our weather	our weather	their code

Read KL(p ‖ q) as **data from p, coded with q**. In Section 2.5 the left slot holds the truth (a label, the data) and the right slot the model.

> So read KL(p ‖ q) as: data from p, coded with q. The reference on the left, the model on the right. Swap them and you ask a different question.

▶ Notebook 2.4

Which one is the truth? KL is not symmetric



	bits wasted per day
our weather, their code: $\mathrm{KL}(p\|\|q)$	1.84
their weather, our code: $\mathrm{KL}(q\|\|p)$	0.86

> Swap the roles: our code on their weather wastes only 0.86 bits a day, KL(q‖p). The truth supplies the weights, so swapping changes the answer.

Story after Jia-Bin Huang, "Fantastic KL Divergence and How to (Actually) Compute It" (YouTube)

▶ Notebook 2.5

KL at work: one recipe, three applications

Three losses you may know separately are one idea. Each goes through the same five steps:

	2.5.1 Classification	2.5.2 Maximum likelihood	2.5.3 Distillation
① **the problem**	label an image	model the weather	shrink a big model
② **data, model**	images; a classifier	20 days; three numbers q	inputs; teacher, student
③ **usual loss**	cross-entropy	minus log-likelihood	soft-label cross-entropy
④ **as KL**	KL(label ‖ prediction)	KL(data ‖ model)	KL(teacher ‖ student)
⑤ **check**	PyTorch's loss = KL	best q = frequencies	student ≈ teacher

> Three applications, one recipe: state the problem, name the data and the model, write down the loss people use, rewrite it as a KL, and check with numbers.

▶ Notebook 2.5.1

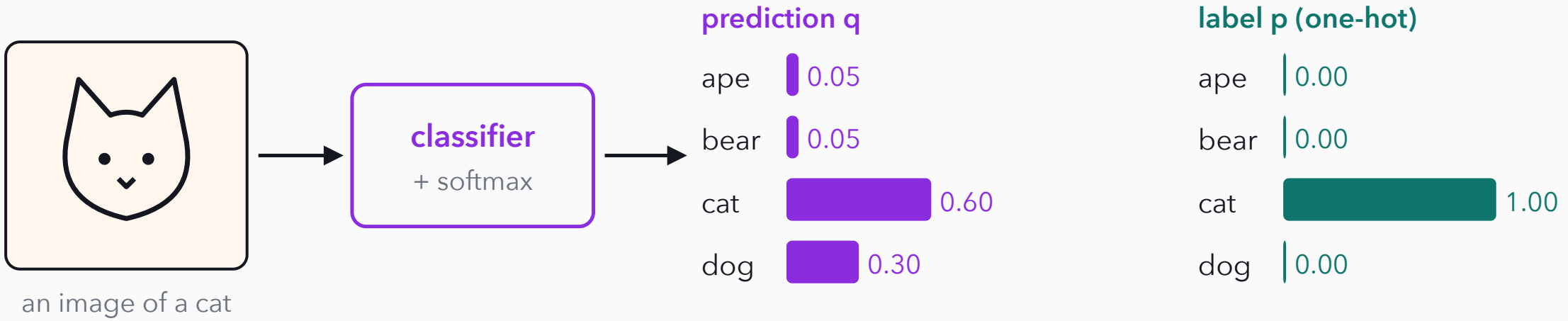
2.5.1 Classification: the plan

step	in this application
① **the problem**	Given an image, say what is in it: ape, bear, cat or dog.
② **data and model**	Images with their true labels. A network with a softmax outputs a distribution q over the four labels.
③ **the usual loss**	Cross-entropy: the loss you have used to train every classifier.
④ **the same loss as KL**	A one-hot label has no surprise, so cross-entropy = KL(label ‖ prediction).
⑤ **check**	PyTorch's loss for our cat is 0.511 nats, the KL; plotted, it is the surprise curve of 2.1.

> The first application, in five steps. You have trained classifiers before; now see which KL their loss is.

▶ Notebook 2.5.1

①② A classifier outputs a distribution



> The true label is a distribution too: all of its probability on cat. Call it p.

Story after Jia-Bin Huang, "Fantastic KL Divergence and How to (Actually) Compute It" (YouTube)

▶ Notebook 2.5.1

③ The usual loss: surprise at the true label

$$H(p, q) = \sum_y p(y) \log \frac{1}{q(y)}$$

$$= 0 \cdot \log \tfrac{1}{0.05} + 0 \cdot \log \tfrac{1}{0.05} + 1 \cdot \log \tfrac{1}{0.6} + 0 \cdot \log \tfrac{1}{0.3}$$

$$= -\log q(\text{cat}) = 0.51 \text{ nats} = 0.74 \text{ bits}$$

> What is left is −log q(cat): the model's surprise at the true label. That is the loss you have been minimising all along.

Story after Jia-Bin Huang, "Fantastic KL Divergence and How to (Actually) Compute It" (YouTube)

▶ Notebook 2.5.1

④ As KL: with a one-hot label, cross-entropy = KL

$$\mathrm{KL}(\text{label} \,\|\, \text{prediction}) = H(p, q) - H(p)$$

$$H(p) = 1 \cdot \log \tfrac{1}{1} + 0 + 0 + 0 = 0$$

A one-hot label is certain, so it has no surprise (0 · log 1/0 counts as 0).

```
F.cross_entropy(logits, target)   # 0.511 nats: here equal to KL(p ‖ q)
```

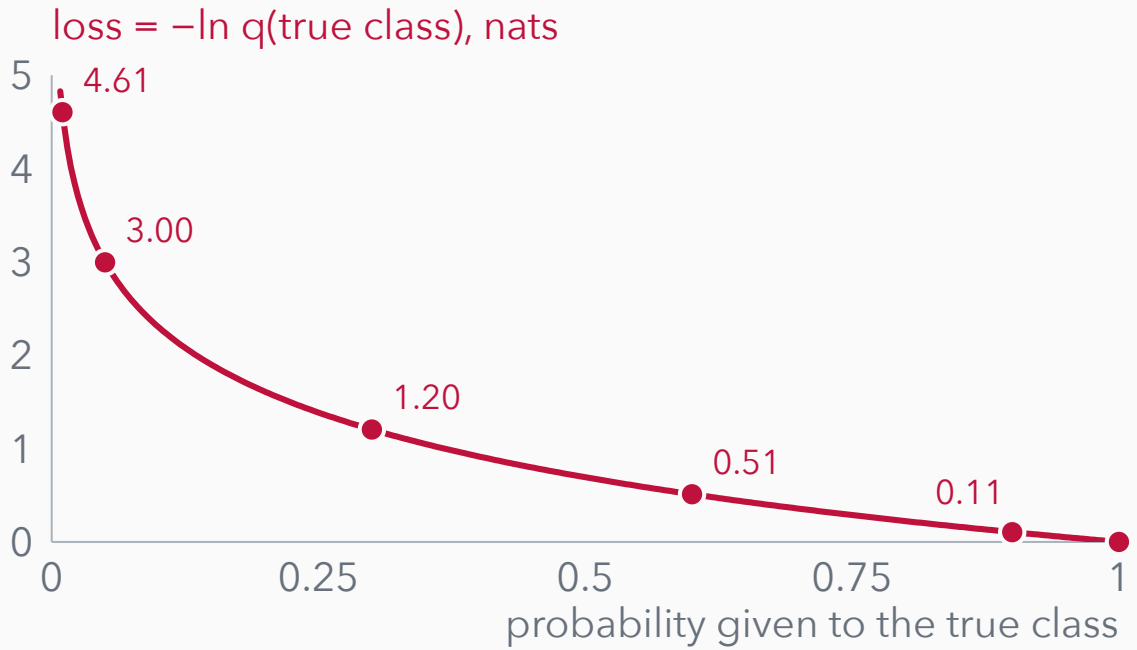
Why label ‖ prediction? The label is the reference: the data come from it, so it goes on the left. The prediction is the model, on the right. Swapped, KL(prediction ‖ label) would need log q/0 for every wrong class: infinite.

> Why this order? Data from the left, code from the right: the label generates the data, the prediction encodes it. The other order divides by the label's zeros.

Story after Jia-Bin Huang, "Fantastic KL Divergence and How to (Actually) Compute It" (YouTube)

▶ Notebook 2.5.1

⑤ Check: the loss is the surprise curve



The loss is −ln q(true class): the surprise curve of Section 2.1, in nats.

Confident and wrong is expensive: q(true) = 0.01 costs 4.6 nats; q(true) = 0.6 costs 0.51.

Training pushes q(true) up the curve towards 1. Being confidently wrong is punished hardest.

▶ Notebook 2.5.2

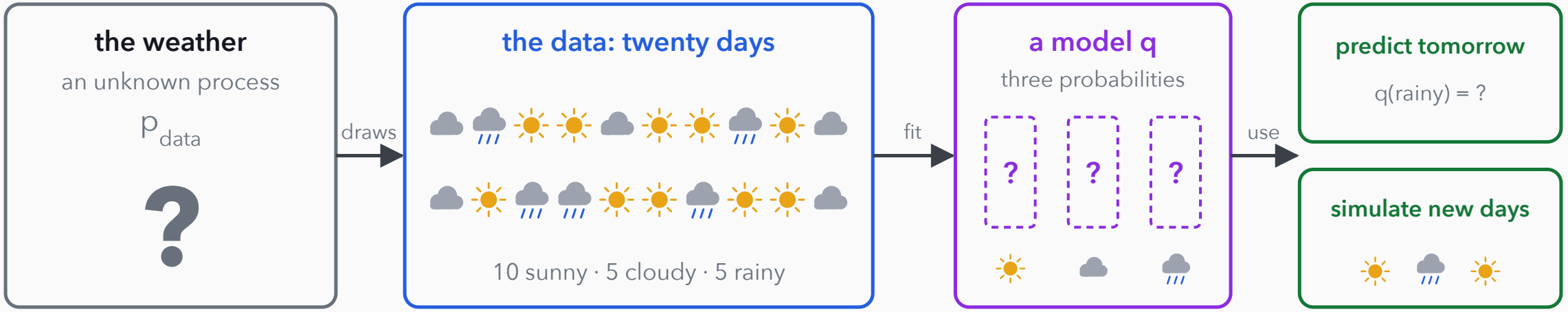
2.5.2 Maximum likelihood: the plan

step	in this application
① **the problem**	Learn a probability model from data: from a record of the weather, how likely is each kind of day? Generative modelling in its simplest form.
② **data and model**	Twenty recorded days. The model q is three probabilities: sunny, cloudy, rainy.
③ **the usual loss**	Maximum likelihood: choose the q that makes the recorded days most probable.
④ **the same loss as KL**	Per day, minus the log-likelihood is $H(\hat{p}, q) = H(\hat{p}) + KL(\hat{p} \,\|\|\, q)$, with $\hat{p}$ the data's frequencies.
⑤ **check**	The best q is the frequencies, and four formulations pick the same q.

> The second application: fitting a model to data. The same five steps; this time the "truth" is the data.

▶ Notebook 2.5.2

① The problem: learn a distribution from data

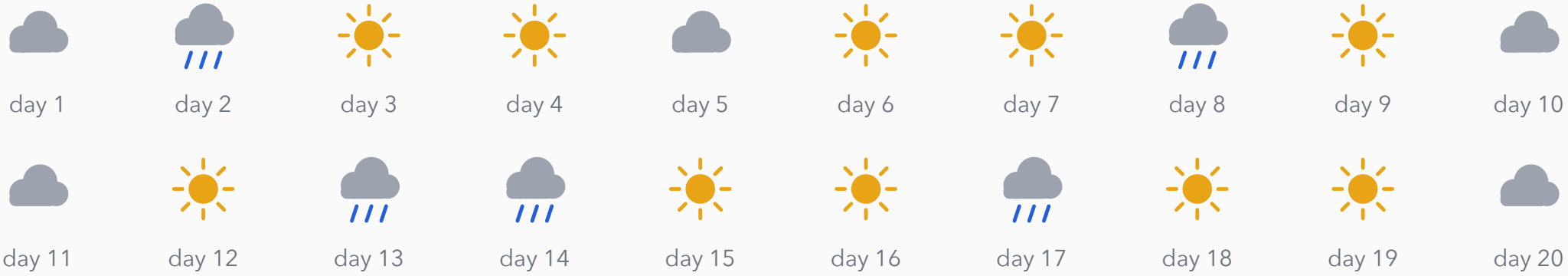


Unknown: the process p_{data}. **Observed**: twenty days. **To choose**: the model q.

> Choose a model q, fit it to the record, then use it: to predict tomorrow, or to simulate new days. Fitting a distribution to samples is generative modelling.

▶ Notebook 2.5.2

② The data and the model: twenty days, three numbers



The model: q = (q(sunny), q(cloudy), q(rainy)), three numbers that add to 1. **The counts**: 10, 5, 5, so the frequencies are $\hat{p}$ = (½, ¼, ¼).

> The model: three probabilities that add to 1. Training means choosing them. The counts are 10, 5 and 5: frequencies $\hat{p}$ = (½, ¼, ¼).

▶ Notebook 2.5.2

③ The usual loss: how probable are the twenty days?

$$p(\mathcal{D} \mid q) = \prod_{i=1}^{20} q(x_i) = q(\text{sunny})^{10}\, q(\text{cloudy})^{5}\, q(\text{rainy})^{5}$$

$$q = (\tfrac{1}{4}, \tfrac{1}{4}, \tfrac{1}{2}): \quad (\tfrac{1}{4})^{10}(\tfrac{1}{4})^{5}(\tfrac{1}{2})^{5} = 2^{-35} \approx 2.9 \times 10^{-11}$$

$$\log_2 p(\mathcal{D} \mid q) = -35$$

> Tiny numbers are why we take logs: $\log_2 p(\mathcal{D} \mid q) = -35$. The whole record is 35 bits of surprise.

▶ Notebook 2.5.2

③ Per day: the data's average surprise under q

$$-\frac{1}{20}\log_2 p(\mathcal{D} \mid q) = \frac{1}{20}\sum_{i=1}^{20}\log_2 \frac{1}{q(x_i)} = \frac{35}{20} = 1.75 \text{ bits}$$

Have we seen 1.75 before?

It is the cross-entropy H(p, q) of Section 2.4.

> Same number: the data's average surprise under q is a cross-entropy. Why?

▶ Notebook 2.5.2

④ Rewrite it: group the days by weather

$$\frac{1}{20}\sum_{i=1}^{20}\log_2\frac{1}{q(x_i)} = \frac{1}{20}\left[10\log_2\frac{1}{q(\text{sunny})} + 5\log_2\frac{1}{q(\text{cloudy})} + 5\log_2\frac{1}{q(\text{rainy})}\right]$$

$$= \frac{10}{20}\log_2\frac{1}{q(\text{sunny})} + \frac{5}{20}\log_2\frac{1}{q(\text{cloudy})} + \frac{5}{20}\log_2\frac{1}{q(\text{rainy})}$$

$$= \sum_x \hat{p}(x)\log_2\frac{1}{q(x)} = H(\hat{p},\, q)$$

> Those frequencies are p̂. The data's average surprise is the cross-entropy H(p̂, q): the data became a distribution.

▶ Notebook 2.5.2

④ As KL: the data's surprise = H(p̂) + KL(p̂ ‖ q)

$$H(\hat{p}, q) = \underbrace{H(\hat{p})}_{\text{fixed by the data}} + \underbrace{\mathrm{KL}(\hat{p} \,\|\, q)}_{\text{depends on } q}$$

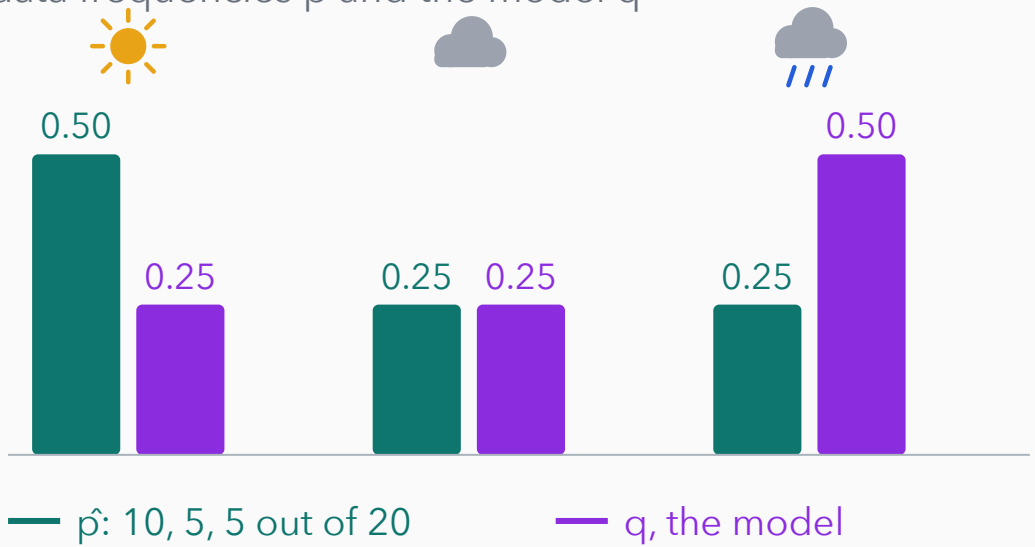
$$1.75 = 1.5 + 0.25 \qquad \text{for } q = (\tfrac{1}{4}, \tfrac{1}{4}, \tfrac{1}{2})$$

For q = (¼, ¼, ½): 1.75 = 1.5 + 0.25. The model can only remove the KL part.

▶ Notebook 2.5.2

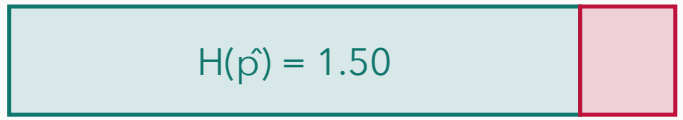
⑤ Check: find the least surprising q

data frequencies $\hat{p}$ and the model q



the data's average surprise under q

= 1.750 bits per day



KL($\hat{p}$ ‖ q) = 0.250 bits

$\log_2 p(\mathcal{D} \mid q) = -35.0$: 32× less probable than under $\hat{p}$

> Move q. The teal part, H($\hat{p}$), never changes; the red part, the KL, shrinks to zero exactly at q = $\hat{p}$ = (½, ¼, ¼). Maximum likelihood matches the frequencies.

▶ Notebook 2.5.2

⑤ Four formulations, one answer

to fit the data …	$q = (¼, ¼, ½)$	$q = \hat{p} = (½, ¼, ¼)$
maximise the likelihood $p(\mathcal{D} \mid q)$	2^{-35}	2^{-30}: 32 times larger
minimise the average surprise, $-(1/20) \log_2 p(\mathcal{D} \mid q)$	1.75 bits	1.50 bits
minimise the cross-entropy $H(\hat{p}, q)$	1.75 bits	1.50 bits
minimise $KL(\hat{p} \,\|\| q)$	0.25 bits	0 bits

Four ways to say "fit the data", and the same winner, $q = \hat{p}$. Maximum likelihood **is** minimum KL(data ‖ model).

> Every row prefers $\hat{p}$, by the same margin: 0.25 bits per day, 5 bits over twenty days, a factor of $2^5 = 32$ in likelihood.

▶ Notebook 2.5.2

In general: maximum likelihood = minimum KL(data ‖ model)

$$\max_\theta \ \frac{1}{N}\sum_{i=1}^{N} \log q_\theta(x_i) \iff \min_\theta \ H(\hat{p}, q_\theta) \iff \min_\theta \ \mathrm{KL}(\hat{p} \,\|\, q_\theta)$$

Any model, any data: the average log-likelihood is minus the data's cross-entropy, and the data's entropy is fixed.

A classifier's training set does the same, label by label: each example costs $-\log q_\theta(y_i \mid x_i)$, the surprise at its label.

> The classification loss of 2.5.1 is the same story, averaged over a training set: training a classifier is maximum likelihood.

▶ Notebook 2.5.3

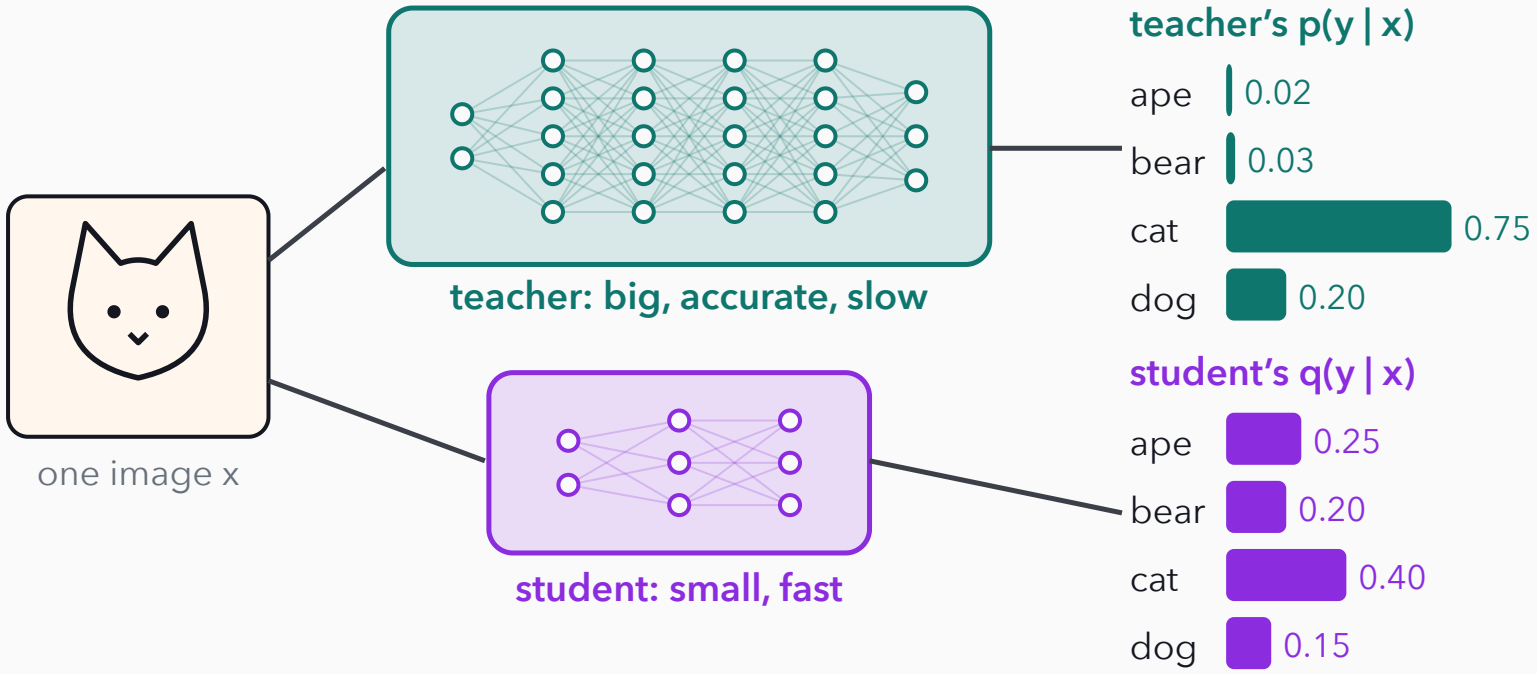
2.5.3 Knowledge distillation: the plan

step	in this application
① **the problem**	A big, accurate network is too slow and costly to deploy. We want a small network that behaves like it.
② **data and model**	Inputs, labelled or not, go to both networks. The teacher is frozen; only the student is trained.
③ **the usual loss**	Cross-entropy, with the teacher's probabilities as soft labels in place of the one-hot label.
④ **the same loss as KL**	Cross-entropy = H(teacher) + KL(teacher ‖ student); the teacher is fixed, so this minimises the KL.
⑤ **check**	For our cat 0.77 = 0.72 + 0.05 nats; a 27-parameter student learns a 4,547-parameter teacher.

> The third application: compressing a big model into a small one. The same five steps; now the "truth" is the teacher.

▶ Notebook 2.5.3

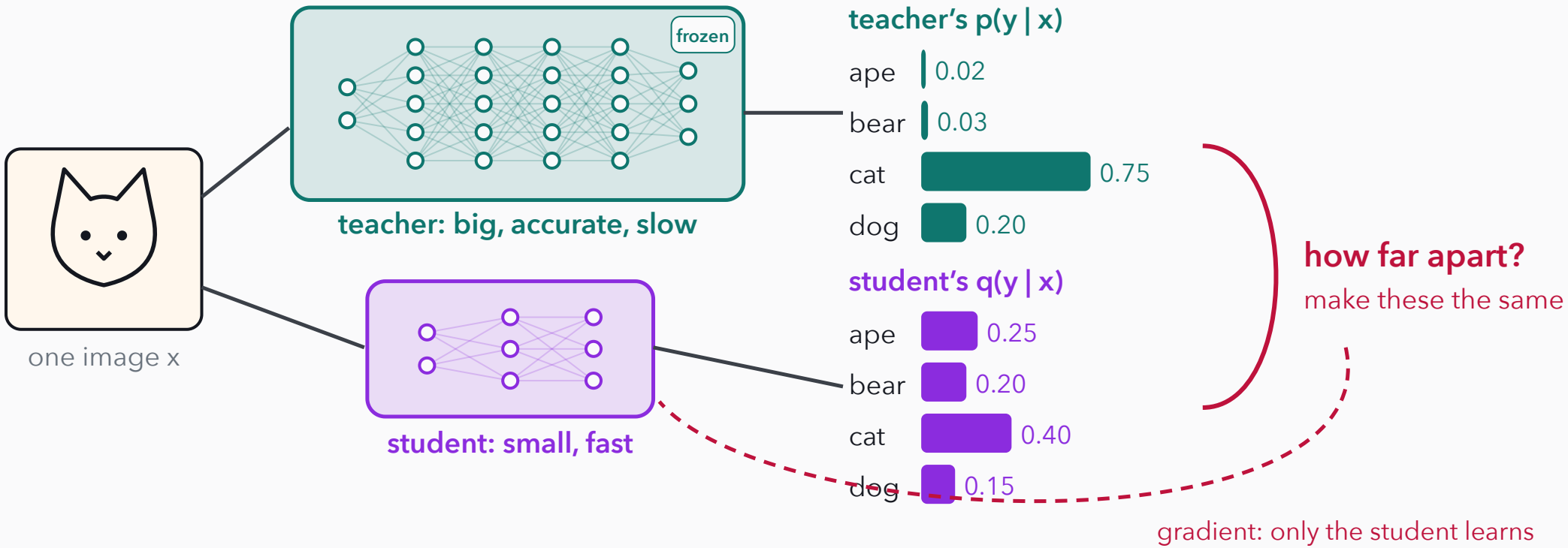
① The problem: a big teacher, a small student



> We want a small network, the student, that behaves like it. Give both the same image: the teacher says cat 0.75, dog 0.20; the untrained student is vaguer.

▶ Notebook 2.5.3

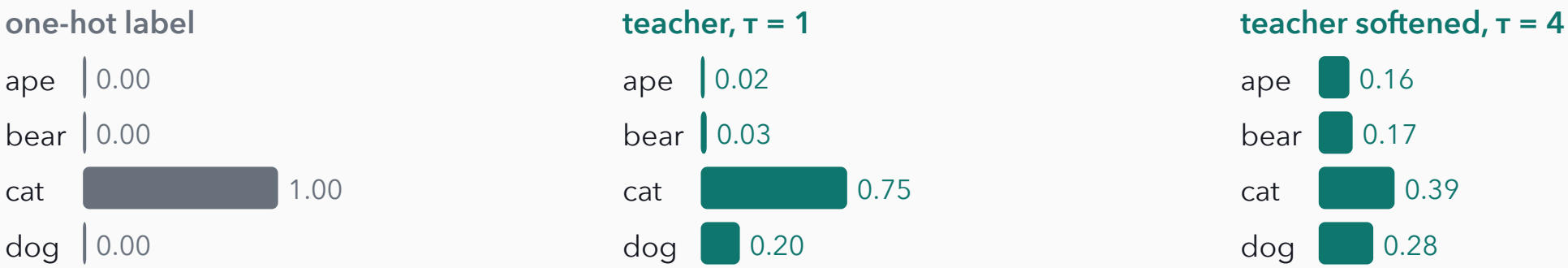
② The data and the model: same inputs, two networks



> The model: the student, the only network we train; the teacher is frozen. We need a loss that measures how far apart the two distributions are.

▶ Notebook 2.5.3

③ The usual loss: cross-entropy with soft labels



$$\mathcal{L} = H(p_T, q_S) = -\sum_y p_T(y)\ \log q_S(y)$$

The classification loss of 2.5.1, with the teacher's probabilities in place of the one-hot label. Their small values say "a bit like a dog, not like an ape": Hinton's dark knowledge. A temperature τ = 4 turns them up.

> The loss is the cross-entropy $H(p_T, q_S)$: the student's surprise, weighted by the teacher's probabilities. The small ones say which mistakes are reasonable.

▶ Notebook 2.5.3

④ The same loss as KL, term by term

$$H(p_T, q_S) = \underbrace{H(p_T)}_{\text{teacher only}} + \mathrm{KL}(p_T \,\|\, q_S)$$

$$\text{teacher frozen} \;\Rightarrow\; \min_{\text{student}} H(p_T, q_S) \;\Longleftrightarrow\; \min_{\text{student}} \mathrm{KL}(p_T \,\|\, q_S)$$

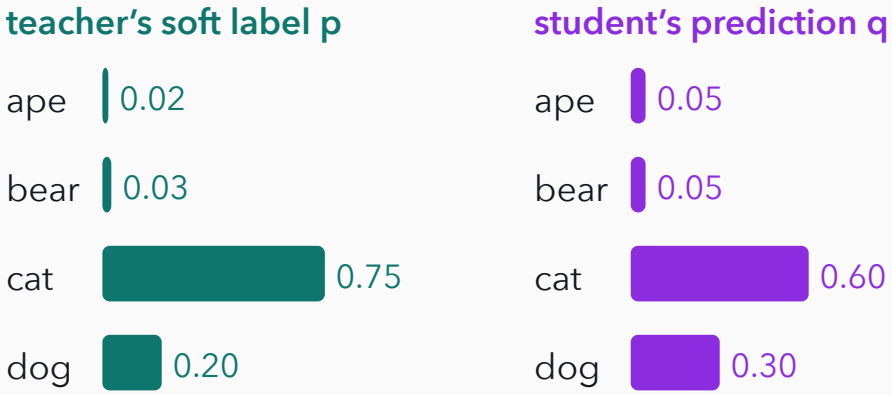
$$\mathcal{L} = (1-\alpha)\, H(y_{\text{true}}, q_S) + \alpha\, \tau^2\, \mathrm{KL}\big(p_T^{(\tau)} \,\|\, q_S^{(\tau)}\big)$$

In practice: $p^{(\tau)}$ = softmax(logits / τ) softens both distributions, τ^2 keeps the gradient scale comparable, and α blends in the true labels. Each term is averaged over the inputs.

> In practice both distributions are softened with a temperature τ, and a small term with the true labels is added.

▶ Notebook 2.5.1

⑤ Check with numbers: cross-entropy = entropy + KL



$$H(p, q) = \underbrace{H(p)}_{0.72} + \underbrace{\mathrm{KL}(p \,\|\, q)}_{0.05} = 0.77$$

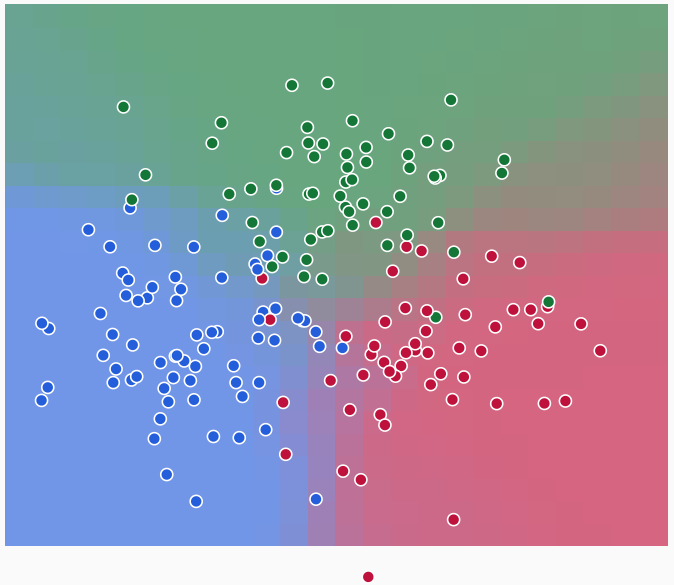
H(p) is fixed by the teacher, so lowering the cross-entropy lowers the KL by exactly as much. The best the student can reach is 0.72 nats: a copy of the teacher.

> Only the KL depends on the student, so lowering the cross-entropy lowers the KL by exactly as much.

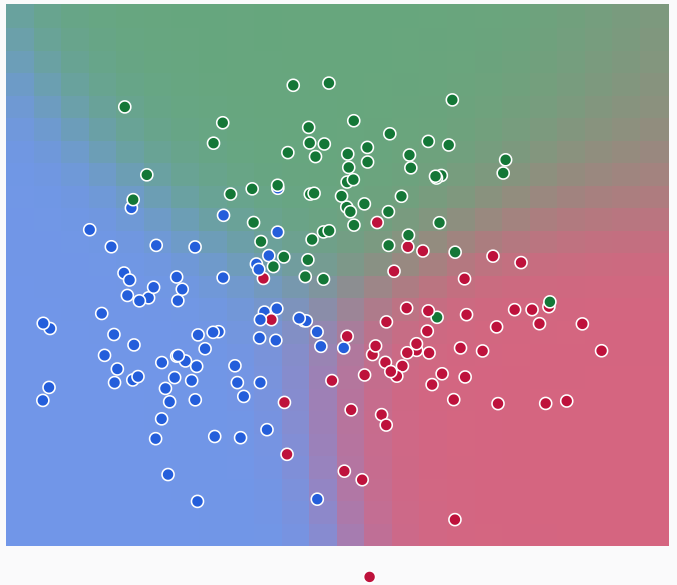
▶ Notebook 2.5.3

⑤ Check: a tiny student learns a big teacher

teacher · 4,547 parameters



student · 27 parameters · step 3000



KL(teacher ‖ student) = 0.009



Test accuracy: teacher 84.6%, student 85.0%; the student agrees with the teacher on 97.0% of test points, with 168× fewer parameters.

> Press play. The student's map turns into the teacher's, uncertain boundaries included, and KL(teacher ‖ student) falls from 1.07 to 0.009 nats.

▶ Notebook 2.5

One principle in many disguises

application	the usual loss	is the same as minimising	the truth
2.5.1 classification	cross-entropy	KL(label ‖ prediction)	the label
2.5.2 maximum likelihood	negative log-likelihood	KL(data ‖ model)	the data
2.5.3 distillation	cross-entropy with soft labels	KL(teacher ‖ student)	the teacher

Parts 3–5: variational inference minimises KL(q ‖ posterior), the same KL with the order flipped: our q comes first.

KL turns up in many other places too: for example, when chatbots are fine-tuned with human feedback (RLHF), a KL term keeps the model close to where it started.

> Variational inference flips the order: q comes first, because we can sample from q but not from the posterior. Section 3.6 shows what that changes.

▶ Notebook 2.6

From sums to integrals

$$\text{discrete:} \qquad \mathrm{KL}(p\|q) = \sum_x p(x) \log \frac{p(x)}{q(x)}$$

$$\text{continuous:} \qquad \mathrm{KL}(p\|q) = \int p(\theta) \log \frac{p(\theta)}{q(\theta)}\, d\theta$$

Probabilities become densities and the sum becomes an integral; the recipe is the same weighted average of log ratios.

> Nothing else changes. KL is never negative either; Part 4 proves it, where we need it.

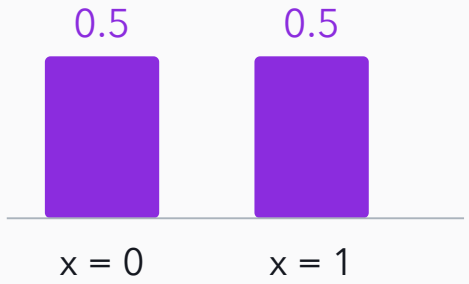
▶ Notebook 2.6

Bernoulli: a coin with P(x = 1) = a

p = Bernoulli(0.8)



q = Bernoulli(0.5)



$$p(x) = a^x(1-a)^{1-x}, \qquad x \in \{0, 1\}$$

$$p(1) = a, \qquad p(0) = 1 - a$$

Your turn: write $\mathrm{KL}(p \,\|\, q)$ for p = Bernoulli(a) and q = Bernoulli(b).

Your turn: put the PMF into Σ_x p(x) log p(x)/q(x). There are only two values of x.

▶ Notebook 2.6

KL between two Bernoullis, step by step

$$\mathrm{KL}(p \,\|\, q) = \sum_{x \in \{0,1\}} p(x) \log \frac{p(x)}{q(x)}$$

$$= p(1) \log \frac{p(1)}{q(1)} + p(0) \log \frac{p(0)}{q(0)}$$

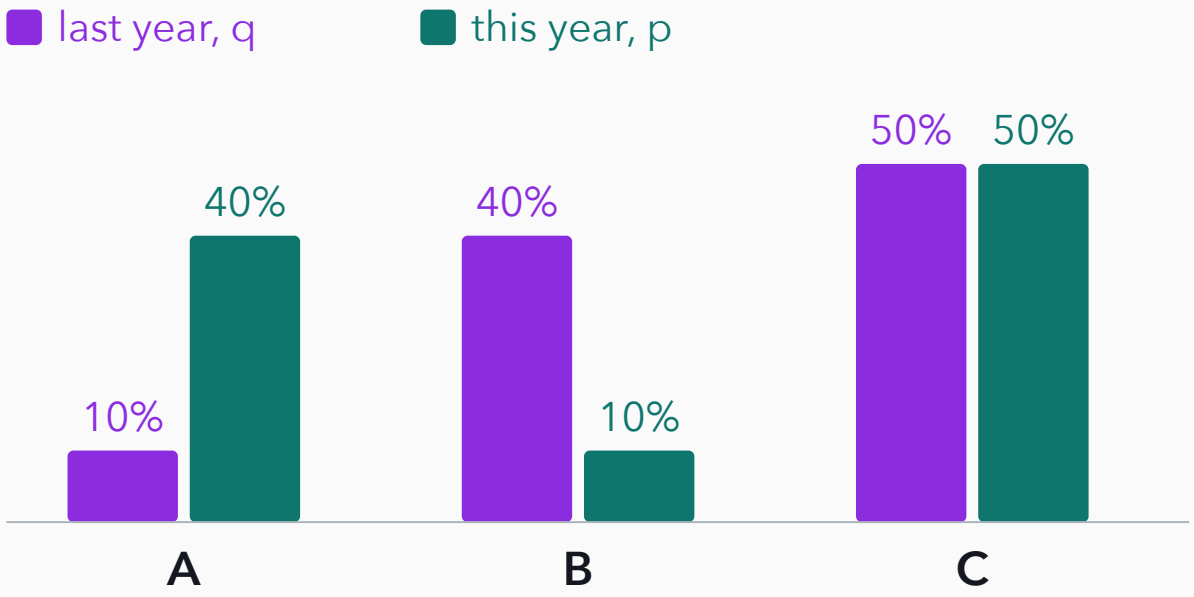
$$= a \log \frac{a}{b} + (1-a) \log \frac{1-a}{1-b}$$

$$a = 0.8,\ b = 0.5: \quad 0.8 \log 1.6 + 0.2 \log 0.4 = 0.376 - 0.183 = 0.19$$

For a = 0.8 and b = 0.5: 0.38 – 0.18 = 0.19 nats.

▶ Notebook 2.6

Categorical: K outcomes with probabilities $\pi_1, \ldots, \pi_K$



$$p(x = k) = \pi_k, \quad k = 1, \ldots, K$$

$$\pi_k \geq 0, \qquad \sum_k \pi_k = 1$$

Our grades: K = 3, with π = (0.4, 0.1, 0.5) this year and ρ = (0.1, 0.4, 0.5) last year.

Your turn: write $\mathrm{KL}(p \,\|\, q)$ for p = Categorical(π) and q = Categorical(ρ).

> Your turn: the same recipe, now with K terms.

▶ Notebook 2.6

KL between two categoricals, step by step

$$\mathrm{KL}(p \,\|\, q) = \sum_{k=1}^{K} p(k) \log \frac{p(k)}{q(k)} = \sum_{k=1}^{K} \pi_k \log \frac{\pi_k}{\rho_k}$$

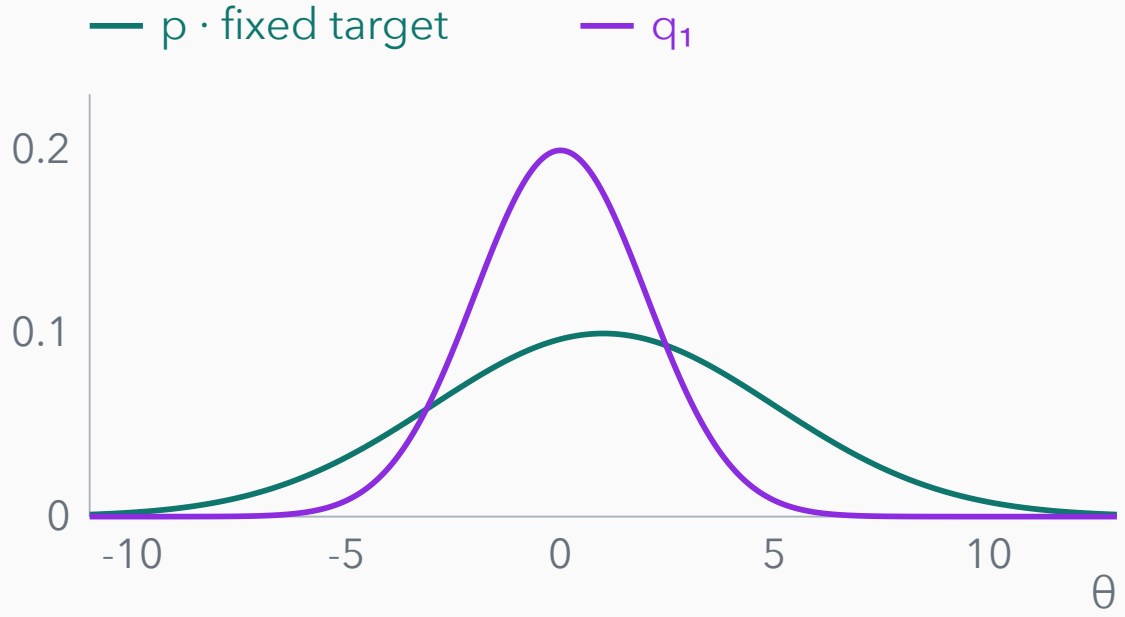
$$K = 2: \quad \pi = (a,\, 1-a),\ \rho = (b,\, 1-b) \ \Rightarrow\ a \log \frac{a}{b} + (1-a) \log \frac{1-a}{1-b}$$

$$\text{grades: } 0.4 \log 4 + 0.1 \log \tfrac{1}{4} + 0.5 \log 1 = 0.42$$

For the grades: 0.42 nats, the number we built by hand in Way 1.

▶ Notebook 2.6

The Gaussian: a bell with mean μ and width σ



$$\mathcal{N}(\theta; \mu, \sigma^2) = \frac{1}{\sqrt{2\pi\sigma^2}}\, e^{-(\theta-\mu)^2/(2\sigma^2)}$$

q = N(μ, σ²) is our approximation and p = N(m, s²) the pretend posterior. Shown: q = N(0, 2²), p = N(1, 4²).

Your turn: work out $\mathrm{KL}(q \,\|\, p)$. Start with log q(θ) − log p(θ).

> Your turn: work out KL(q ‖ p). The log makes the exponentials easy.

▶ Notebook 2.6

Gaussian KL, step 1: the log ratio

$$\log q(\theta) = -\tfrac{1}{2}\log(2\pi\sigma^2) - \frac{(\theta-\mu)^2}{2\sigma^2}$$

$$\log p(\theta) = -\tfrac{1}{2}\log(2\pi s^2) - \frac{(\theta-m)^2}{2s^2}$$

$$\log q(\theta) - \log p(\theta) = \log\frac{s}{\sigma} - \frac{(\theta-\mu)^2}{2\sigma^2} + \frac{(\theta-m)^2}{2s^2}$$

Subtract. The 2π terms cancel, and the two log widths combine into log(s/σ).

▶ Notebook 2.6

Gaussian KL, step 2: average over q

$$\mathrm{KL}(q\|p) = \mathbb{E}_q\Big[\log\frac{s}{\sigma} - \frac{(\theta-\mu)^2}{2\sigma^2} + \frac{(\theta-m)^2}{2s^2}\Big]$$

$$\mathbb{E}_q\big[(\theta-\mu)^2\big] = \sigma^2 \quad\Rightarrow\quad -\frac{\sigma^2}{2\sigma^2} = -\frac{1}{2}$$

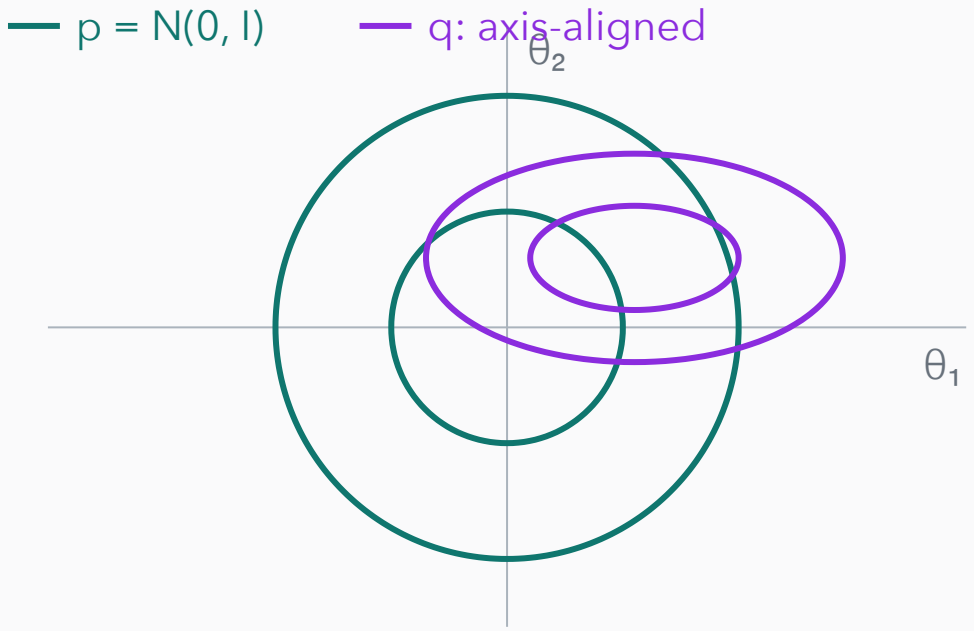
$$\mathbb{E}_q\big[(\theta-m)^2\big] = \mathbb{E}_q\big[\big((\theta-\mu)+(\mu-m)\big)^2\big] = \sigma^2 + (\mu-m)^2$$

$$\mathrm{KL}(q\|p) = \log\frac{s}{\sigma} + \frac{\sigma^2+(\mu-m)^2}{2s^2} - \frac{1}{2}$$

Together: a width term, the squared shift between the means, and −½. That is the Gaussian KL.

▶ Notebook 2.6

A diagonal Gaussian: one bell per coordinate



$$q(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = \prod_{j=1}^{d} \mathcal{N}(\theta_j;\, \mu_j,\, \sigma_j^2)$$

$$p(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = \prod_{j=1}^{d} \mathcal{N}(\theta_j;\, m_j,\, s_j^2)$$

Independent coordinates, so the contours are axis-aligned. Our network's q is exactly this, with d = 7.

Your turn: what is KL(q ‖ p) in d dimensions?

> Your turn: what happens to the log of a product?

▶ Notebook 2.6

KL between diagonal Gaussians, step by step

$$\log \frac{q(\boldsymbol{\theta})}{p(\boldsymbol{\theta})} = \sum_{j=1}^{d} \log \frac{\mathcal{N}(\theta_j; \mu_j, \sigma_j^2)}{\mathcal{N}(\theta_j; m_j, s_j^2)}$$

$$\mathrm{KL}(q\|p) = \sum_{j=1}^{d} \mathrm{KL}\big(\mathcal{N}(\mu_j, \sigma_j^2) \,\|\, \mathcal{N}(m_j, s_j^2)\big)$$

$$p = \mathcal{N}(0, I): \qquad \mathrm{KL}(q\|p) = \sum_{j=1}^{d} \Big[-\log \sigma_j + \frac{\sigma_j^2 + \mu_j^2}{2} - \frac{1}{2} \Big]$$

> Against a N(0, 1) prior on every coordinate: exactly the KL term in our network's ELBO, and in every VAE.

▶ Notebook 2.6

The same formulas in PyTorch: Bernoulli and categorical

```
@register_kl(Bernoulli, Bernoulli)
def _kl_bernoulli_bernoulli(p, q):
    t1 = p.probs * (softplus(-q.logits) - softplus(-p.logits))
    t2 = (1 - p.probs) * (softplus(q.logits) - softplus(p.logits))
    return t1 + t2

@register_kl(Categorical, Categorical)
def _kl_categorical_categorical(p, q):
    t = p.probs * (p.logits - q.logits)
    return t.sum(-1)
```

softplus(−logit) = −log(probability), so t1 = a log(a/b) and t2 = (1 − a) log((1 − a)/(1 − b)). For a categorical, logits are log-probabilities: $\Sigma\ \pi_k\ (\log \pi_k - \log \rho_k)$.

> Read them against our formulas: a log(a/b) + (1 − a) log((1 − a)/(1 − b)), and $\Sigma_k\ \pi_k \log(\pi_k/\rho_k)$. The same.

PyTorch source: torch/distributions/kl.py

▶ Notebook 2.6

The same formulas in PyTorch: Gaussian and diagonal

```python
@register_kl(Normal, Normal)
def _kl_normal_normal(p, q):
    var_ratio = (p.scale / q.scale).pow(2)
    t1 = ((p.loc - q.loc) / q.scale).pow(2)
    return 0.5 * (var_ratio + t1 - 1 - var_ratio.log())

@register_kl(Independent, Independent)
def _kl_independent_independent(p, q):
    result = kl_divergence(p.base_dist, q.base_dist)
    return _sum_rightmost(result, p.reinterpreted_batch_ndims)
```

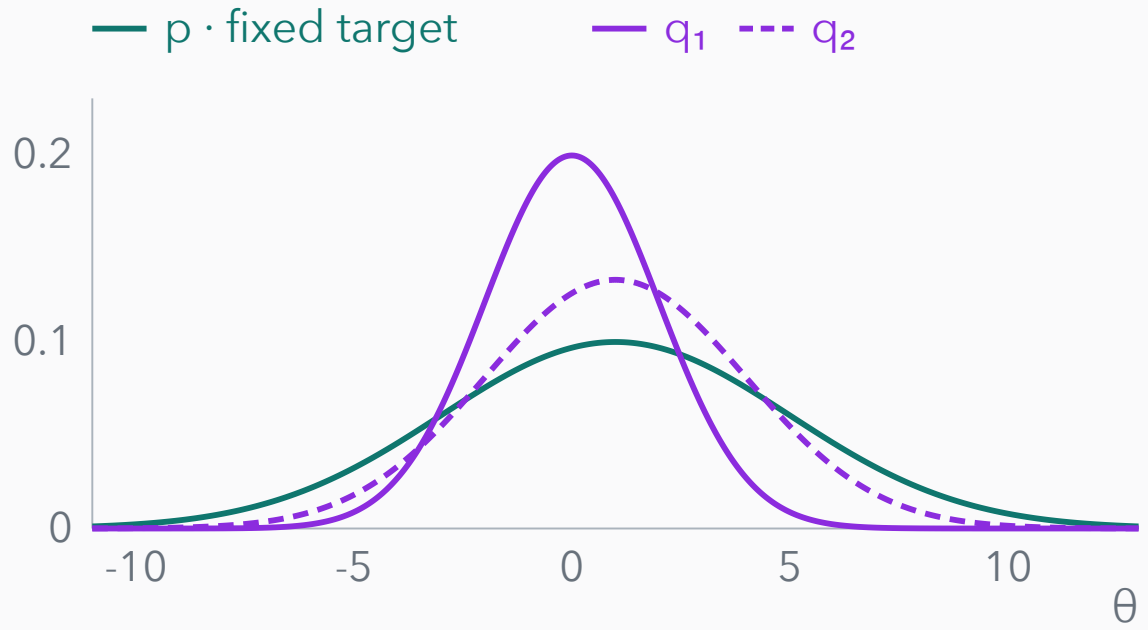
$\frac{1}{2}(\sigma^2/s^2 + (\mu - m)^2/s^2 - 1 - \log \sigma^2/s^2) = \log(s/\sigma) + (\sigma^2 + (\mu - m)^2)/(2s^2) - \frac{1}{2}$. Independent: the one-dimensional KLs, summed over coordinates.

> Expand the Normal line: it is our formula. Independent sums the per-coordinate KLs: the diagonal-Gaussian rule.

PyTorch source: torch/distributions/kl.py

▶ Notebook 2.6

Use the formula: which Gaussian is closer to p?



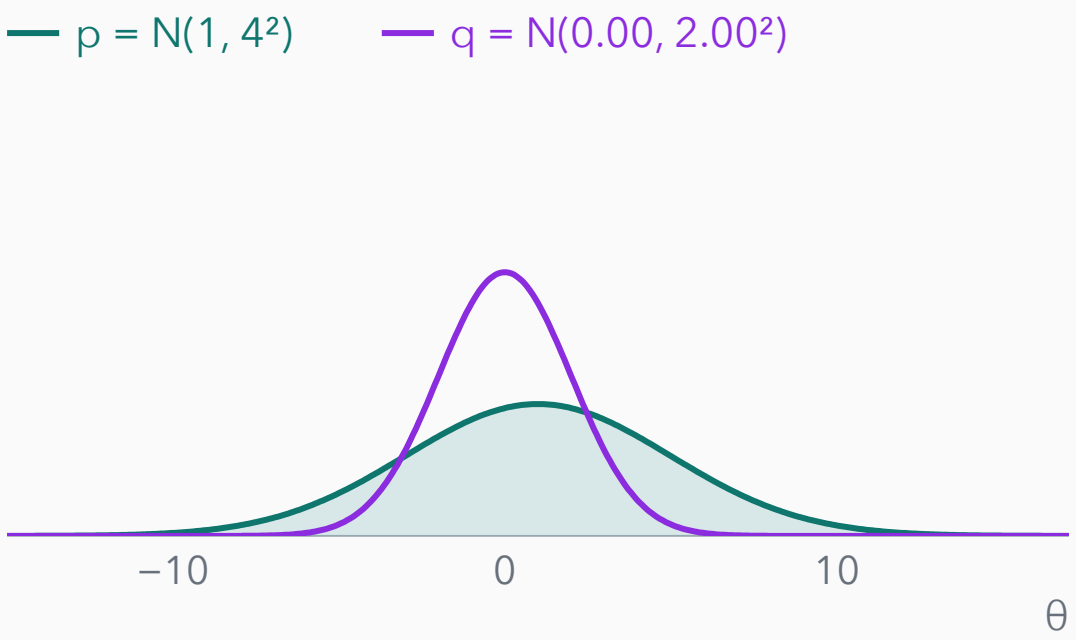
$$p = \mathcal{N}(1, 4^2)$$

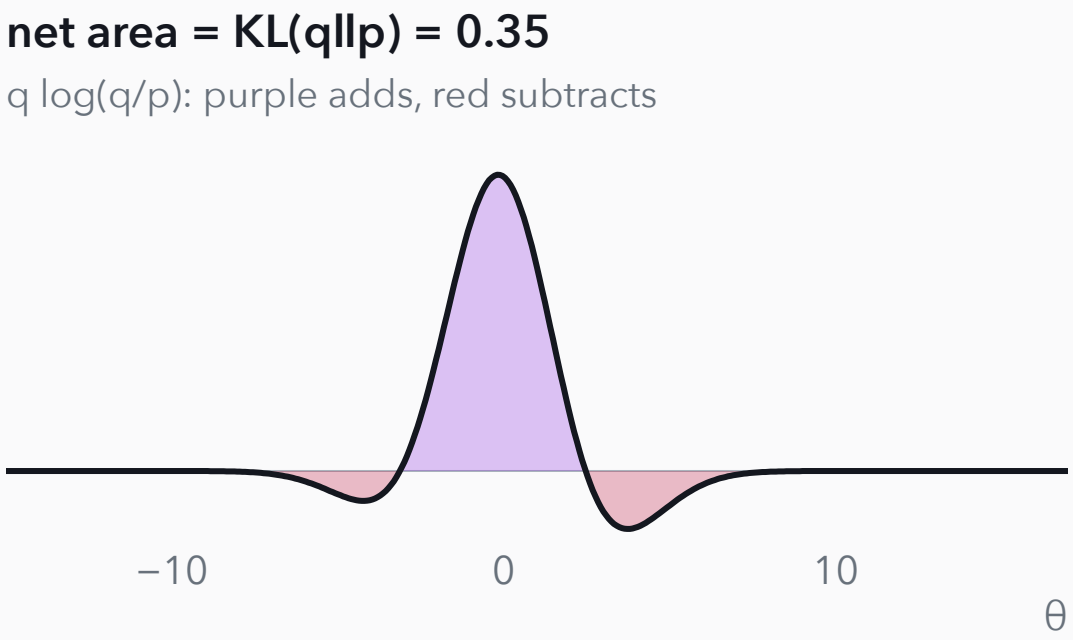
	substitute	KL
$q_1 = \mathcal{N}(0, 2^2)$	$\log 2 + \frac{4+1}{32} - \frac{1}{2}$	0.35
$q_2 = \mathcal{N}(1, 3^2)$	$\log \frac{4}{3} + \frac{9+0}{32} - \frac{1}{2}$	0.07

KL(q_1‖p) = 0.35 nats and KL(q_2‖p) = 0.07. The formula settles the vote.

▶ Notebook 2.6

KL is an area you can watch





Purple area adds and red area subtracts; the net area is the KL. Drag q, or flip the direction.

▶ Notebook 2.7

KL is an average: an expectation under p

$$\mathrm{KL}(p \,\|\, q) = \sum_x p(x) \log \frac{p(x)}{q(x)}$$

$$= \mathbb{E}_{x \sim p}\left[\log \frac{p(x)}{q(x)} \right]$$

E with x ~ p means: the average value when x is drawn from p.

So KL is an expectation: the average log ratio when x is drawn from p.

▶ Notebook 2.7

Two ways to compute an expectation

$$\mathbb{E}_{x\sim p}[f(x)] = \sum_{x} p(x)\, f(x)$$

$$\mathbb{E}_{\theta\sim p}[f(\theta)] = \int p(\theta)\, f(\theta)\, d\theta$$

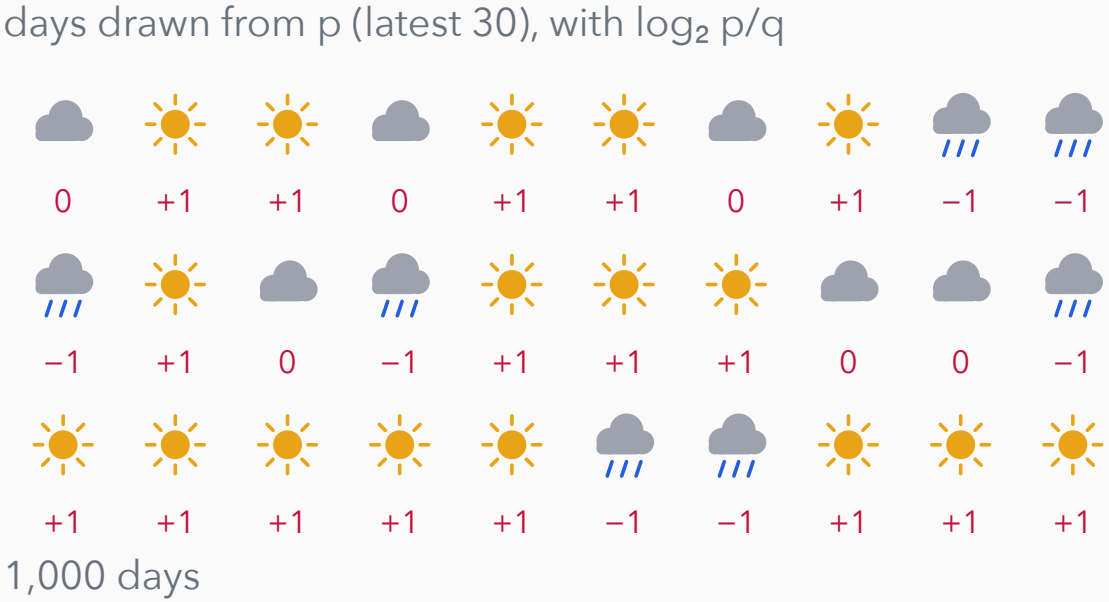
$$\mathbb{E}_{x\sim p}[f(x)] \approx \frac{1}{S}\sum_{s=1}^{S} f(x_s), \qquad x_s \sim p$$

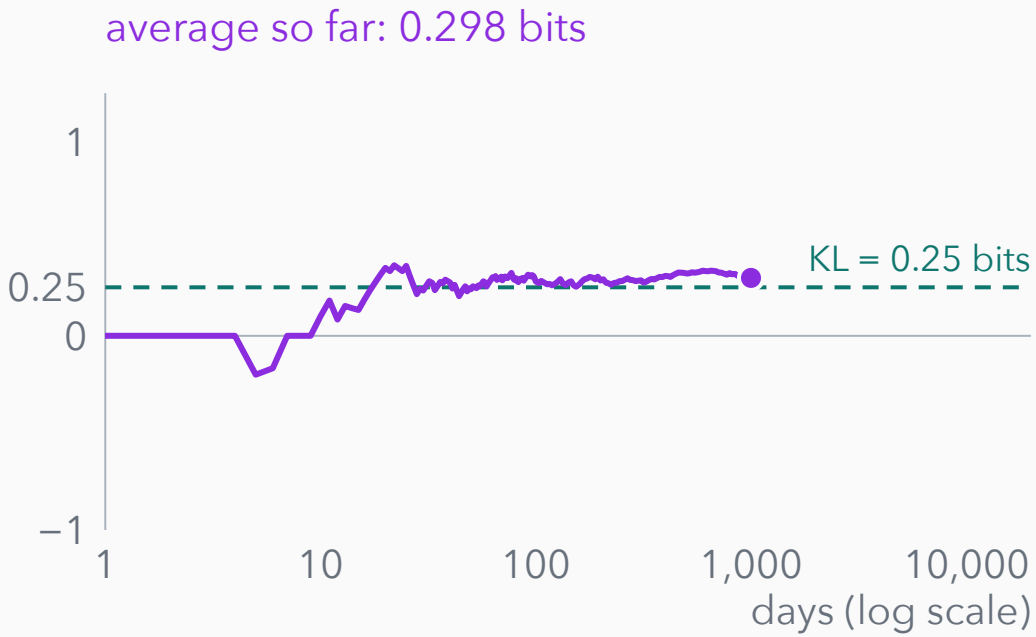
Draws land on each x in proportion to p(x), so a plain average over draws weights each f(x) by p(x) automatically.

> Or draw samples from p and take a plain average. Values that are more probable show up more often, so the weighting happens by itself.

▶ Notebook 2.7

Sample days and watch the average find the KL





Draw days from our weather p and average $\log_2$ p/q: +1 bit on sunny days, 0 on cloudy, −1 on rainy. The average settles on the KL, 0.25 bits, with no formula needed.

▶ Notebook 2.7

No formula needed: estimate KL by sampling

$$\mathrm{KL}(q\|p) = \mathbb{E}_{\theta\sim q}\big[\log q(\theta) - \log p(\theta)\big] \approx \frac{1}{S}\sum_{i=1}^{S}\big[\log q(\theta_i) - \log p(\theta_i)\big]$$

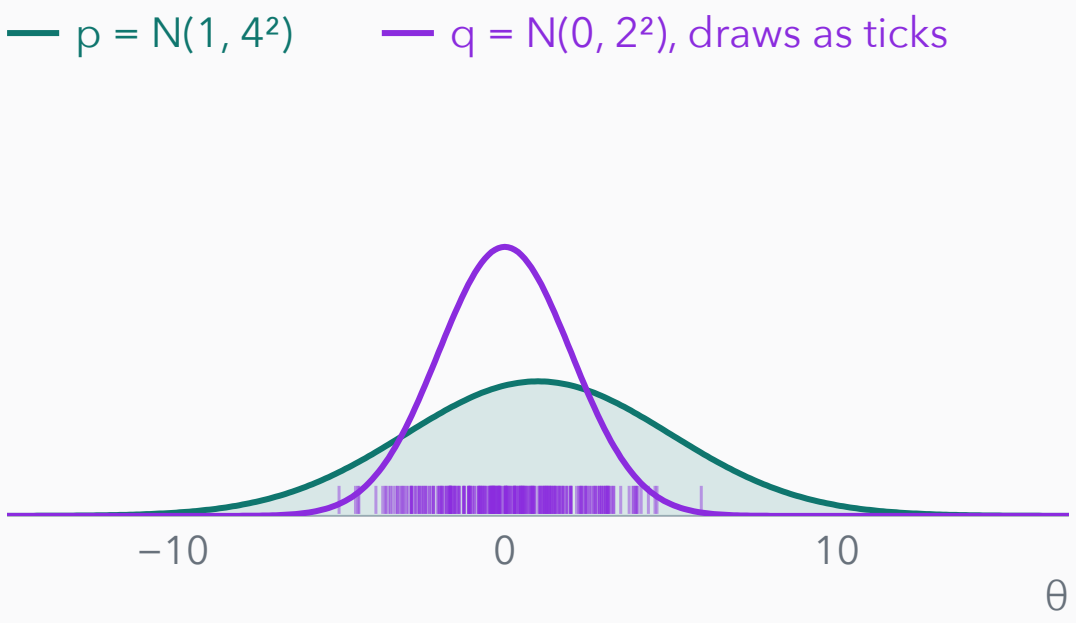
```
theta = q.sample((S,))
log_q = q.log_prob(theta)
log_p = p.log_prob(theta)
est = (log_q - log_p).mean()
exact = kl_divergence(q, p)
```

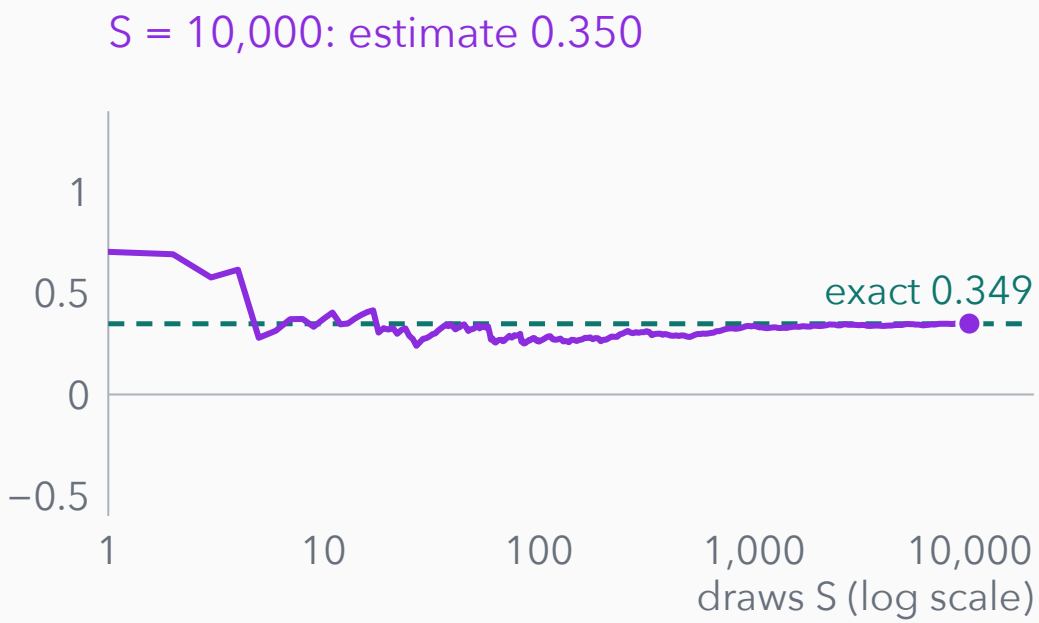
	$KL(q_2\|\|p)$
exact formula	0.069
estimate, S = 10,000	0.067

Checked on a pair that has a formula: 0.067 from 10,000 draws, against the exact 0.069.

▶ Notebook 2.7

Watch the estimate settle



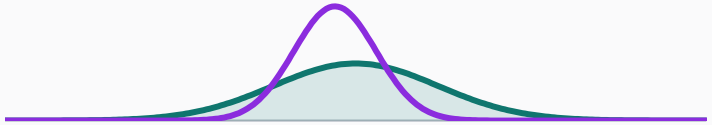


Add draws from q and watch the running average of log q − log p settle on the exact 0.349.

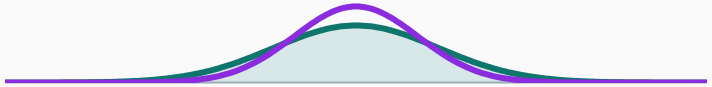
▶ Notebook 3.1

Six candidates: which q is closest to p?

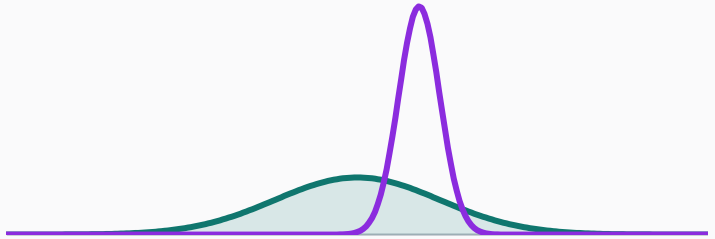
q = N(0, 2²) KL 0.35



q = N(1, 3²) **KL 0.07**



q = N(4, 1²) KL 1.20



q = N(−3, 4²) KL 0.50



q = N(1, 8²) KL 0.81



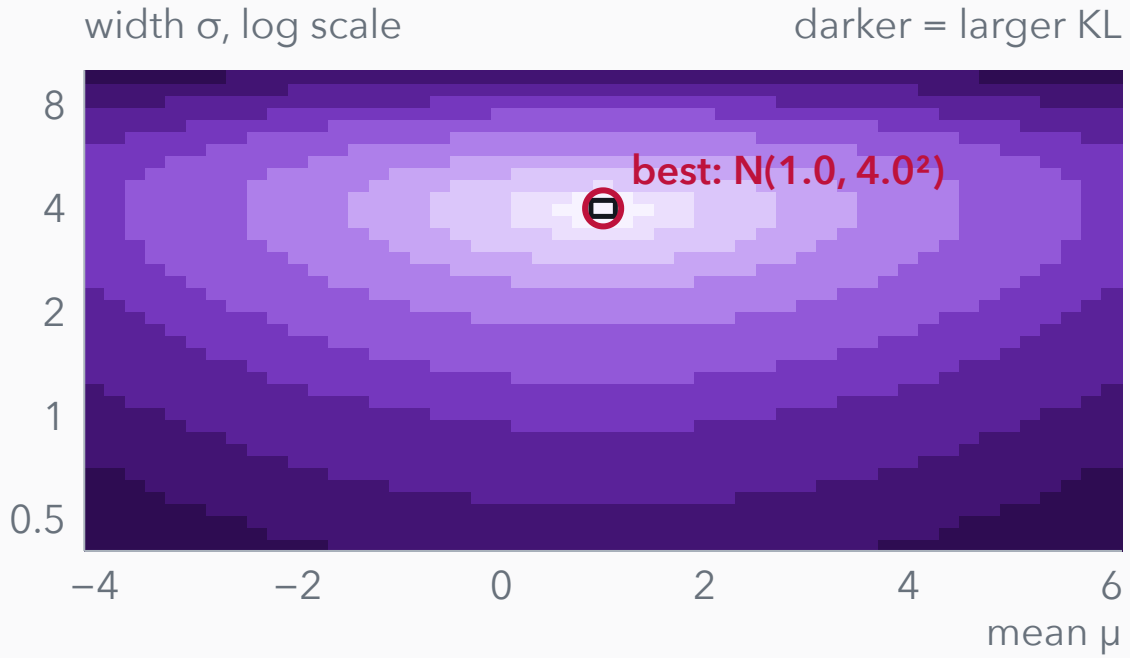
q = N(2, 5²) KL 0.09

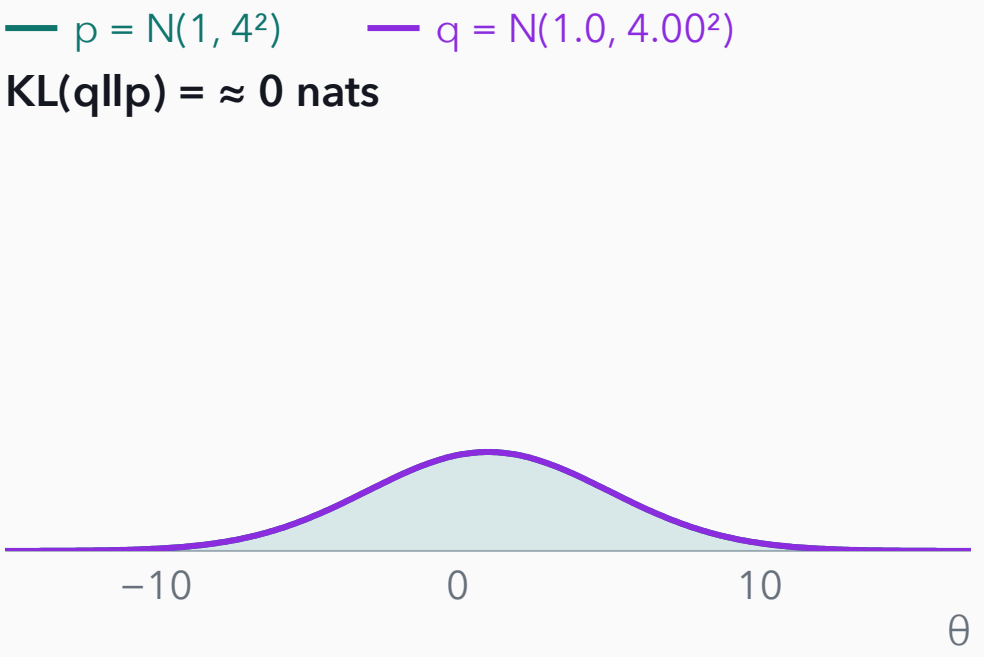


Smallest KL: N(1, 3²) at 0.07, then N(2, 5²) at 0.09. Could another q do better?

▶ Notebook 3.1

Search a grid of means and widths: hover over it

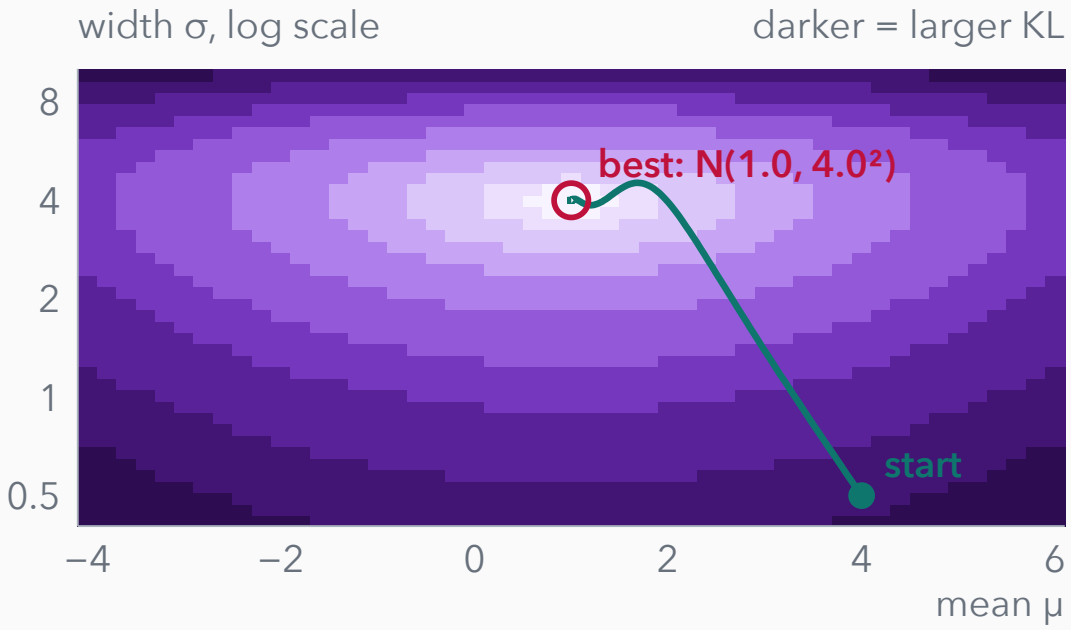




> The lightest point is q = p: 2,040 evaluations. For our network's fourteen numbers a grid needs $40^{14} \approx 3 \times 10^{22}$. We need to walk downhill instead.

▶ Notebook 3.2

Instead of a grid, walk downhill



$$\psi^* = \arg\min_{\psi} \mathrm{KL}(q_\psi \,\|\, p)$$

$$\psi \leftarrow \psi - \eta \, \nabla_\psi \mathrm{KL}(q_\psi \,\|\, p)$$

Gradient descent from N(4, 0.5²): the teal path. About a hundred steps, and the same recipe works for millions of parameters.

From N(4, 0.5²) the optimiser walks downhill to p. It needs only gradients, which autograd provides.

▶ Notebook 3.2

The same search in code

```
mu  = Parameter(tensor(4.0))
rho = Parameter(tensor(log(0.5)))
opt = Adam([mu, rho], lr=0.05)
for step in range(200):
    q = Normal(mu, rho.exp())
    loss = kl_divergence(q, p)
    opt.zero_grad()
    loss.backward()
    opt.step()
```

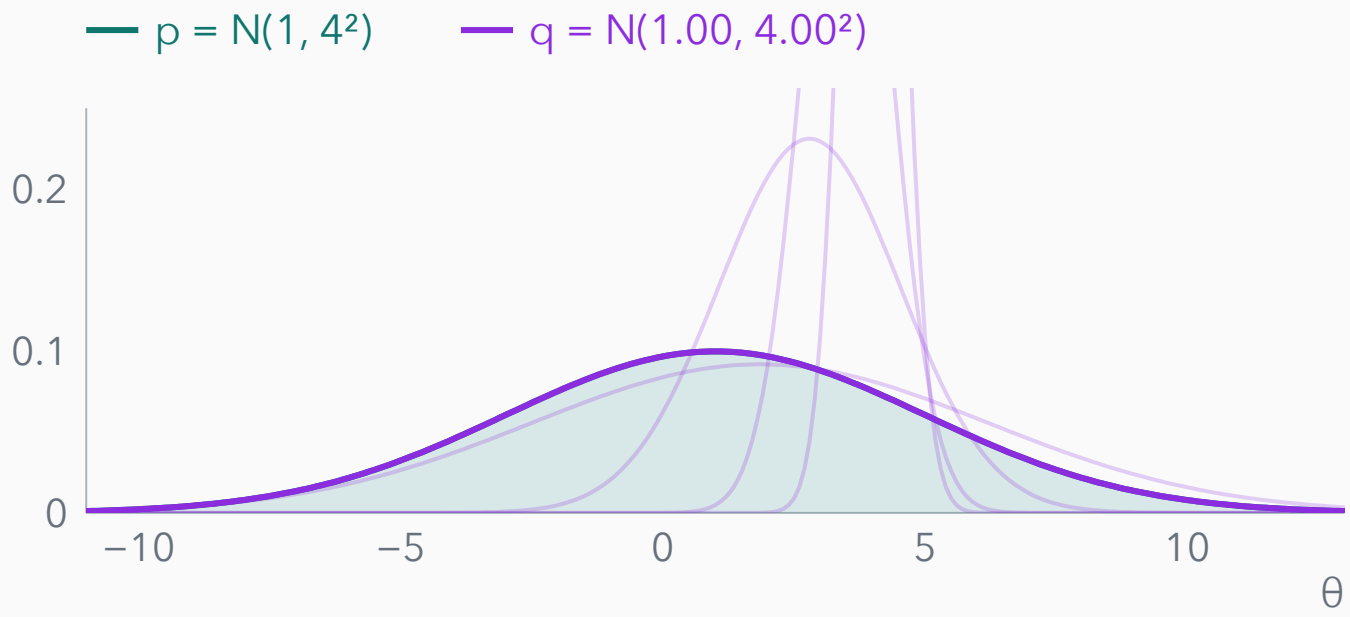
$$\sigma = \exp(\rho) > 0 \text{ for every } \rho$$

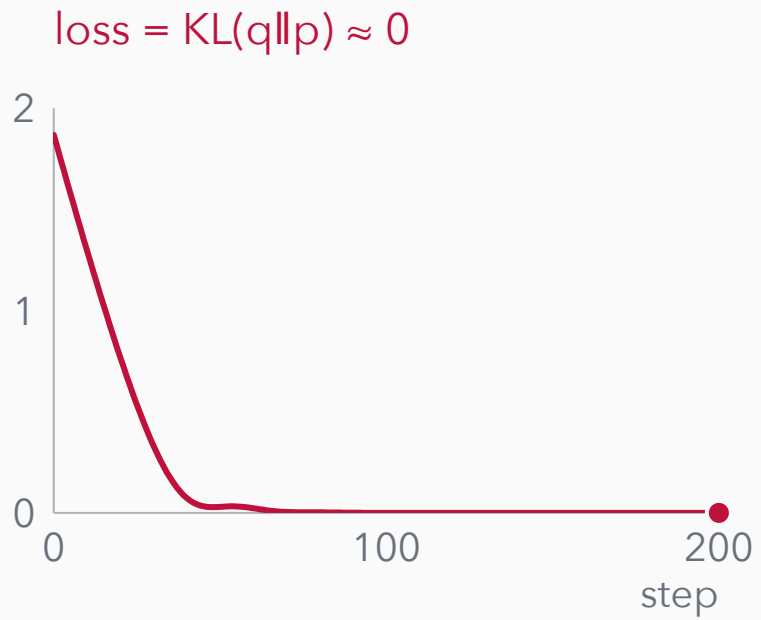
Rebuild q, score it, differentiate, update. The notebook runs exactly this loop and plots the loss, μ, σ and the learned curve.

> Rebuild q, score it, differentiate, update. The same five lines fit our network in Part 5.

▶ Notebook 3.2

Press play: the loss falls as q slides onto p



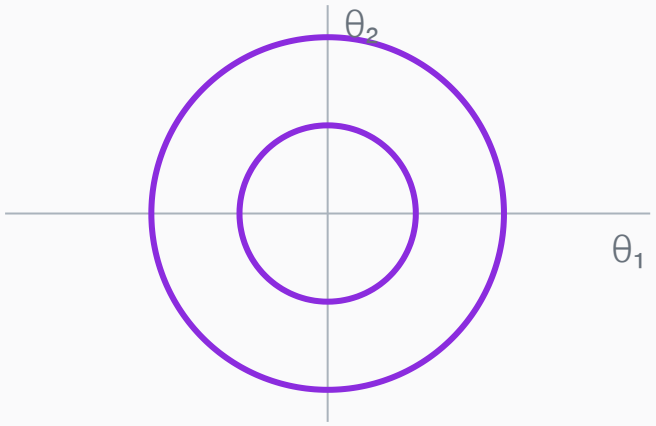


> The width gets there first and overshoots a little; the centre slides in by step 100. Then the loss, KL(q‖p), is about 0. Drag the slider to replay any step.

▶ Notebook 3.3

In two dimensions, q needs a covariance matrix: three families

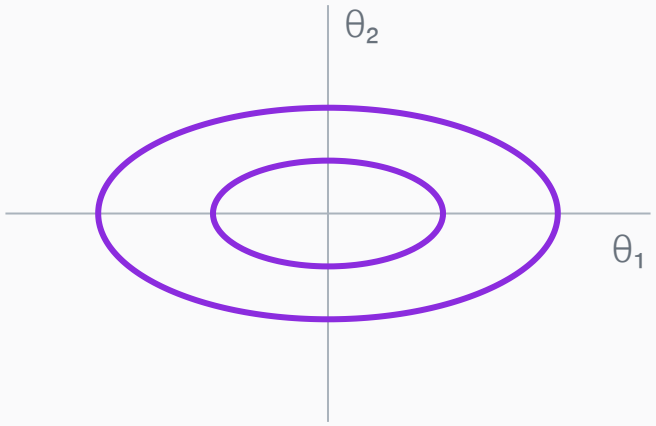
isotropic: $s^2 I$



$$\Sigma = \begin{bmatrix} 1.00 & 0.00 \\ 0.00 & 1.00 \end{bmatrix}$$

1 number, whatever the dimension

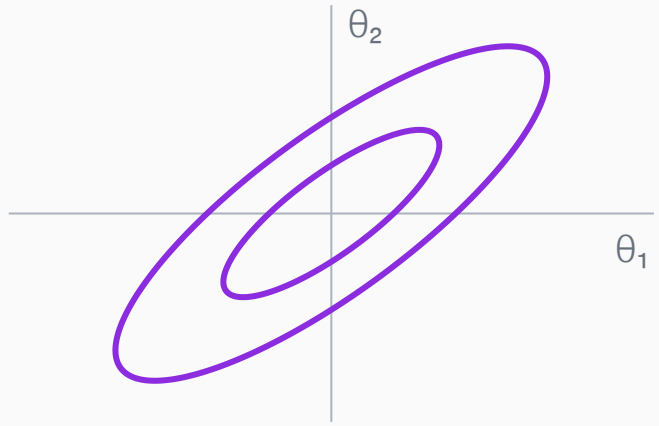
diagonal: $\mathrm{diag}(s_1^2, s_2^2)$



$$\Sigma = \begin{bmatrix} 1.70 & 0.00 \\ 0.00 & 0.36 \end{bmatrix}$$

2 numbers; d in d dimensions

full: LL^T



$$\Sigma = \begin{bmatrix} 1.50 & 0.95 \\ 0.95 & 0.90 \end{bmatrix}$$

3 numbers; $d(d + 1)/2$ in general

Our network has $d = 7$ parameters: 1, 7 or 28 numbers. A network with a million weights: 1, a million, or 5×10^{11}.

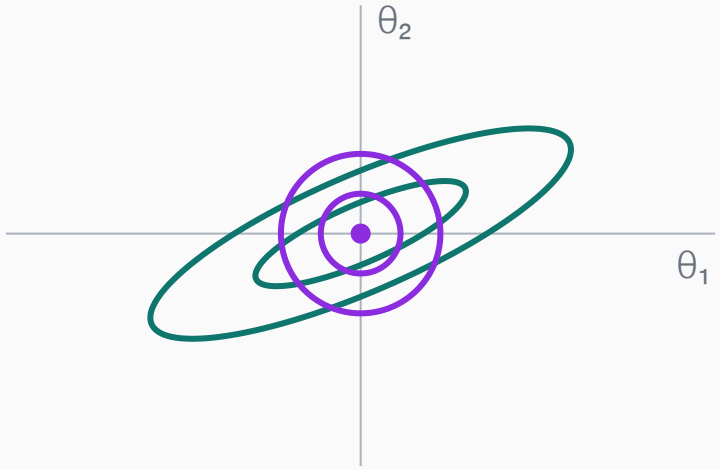
> Full: the ellipse can tilt. Writing $\Sigma = LL^T$ with L lower-triangular keeps Σ a valid covariance for any L. It costs $d(d + 1)/2$ numbers.

▶ Notebook 3.3

Fit all three to the same tilted target

isotropic KL 0.73

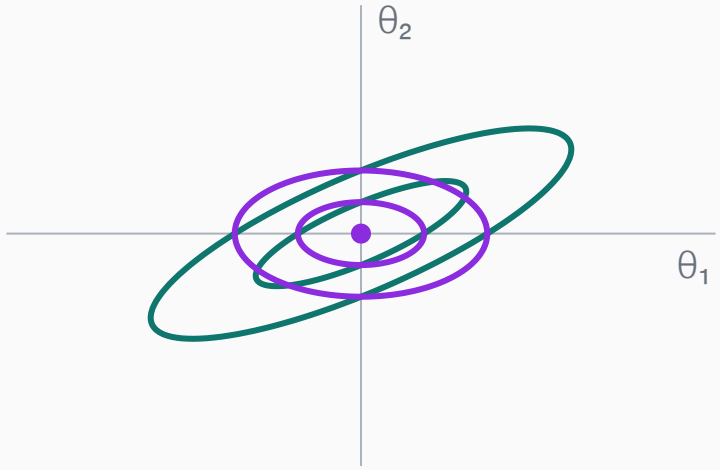
$s^2 I$ · 1 number



$$\Sigma_q = \begin{bmatrix} 0.32 & 0.00 \\ 0.00 & 0.32 \end{bmatrix}$$

diagonal KL 0.51

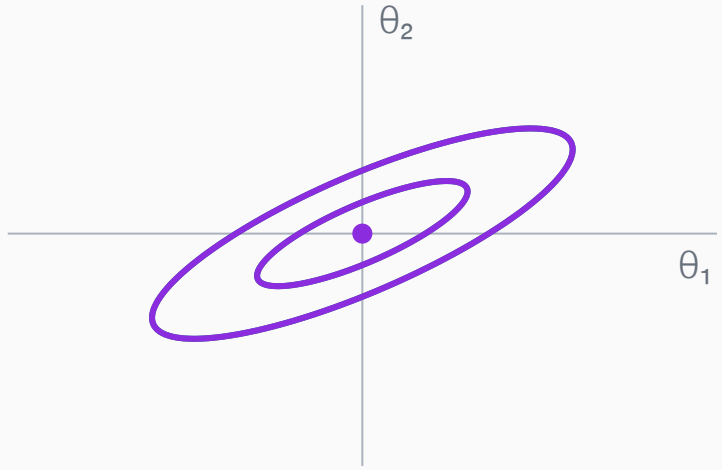
$\mathrm{diag}(s_1^2, s_2^2)$ · 2 numbers



$$\Sigma_q = \begin{bmatrix} 0.81 & 0.00 \\ 0.00 & 0.20 \end{bmatrix}$$

full KL ≈ 0

LL^T · 3 numbers



$$\Sigma_q = \begin{bmatrix} 2.25 & 0.90 \\ 0.90 & 0.56 \end{bmatrix}$$

Press play. The full q matches p exactly: KL → 0. The diagonal q cannot tilt; it shrinks to widths 0.90 and 0.45. The isotropic q shrinks to a circle of radius 0.57.

▶ Notebook 3.3

A q that cannot tilt shrinks instead

q family	widths it finds	KL(q‖p)
target p	1.50 and 0.75, tilted	–
isotropic	0.57 and 0.57	0.73
diagonal (mean-field)	0.90 and 0.45	0.51
full	1.50 and 0.75, tilted	0

KL(q‖p) charges heavily for q-mass where p is small, off the tilted ridge. So a q that cannot tilt shrinks: it underestimates the uncertainty. Our network's q is diagonal; Part 5 shows what that does to its error bars.

> Rather than spill mass off the ridge, a q that cannot tilt shrinks. Mean-field VI underestimates uncertainty.

▶ Notebook 3.4

A mixture of Gaussians: first pick a bump, then draw from it

step 1: pick a bump

bump 1
probability ½

bump 2
probability ½

z

z ~ Categorical(½, ½)

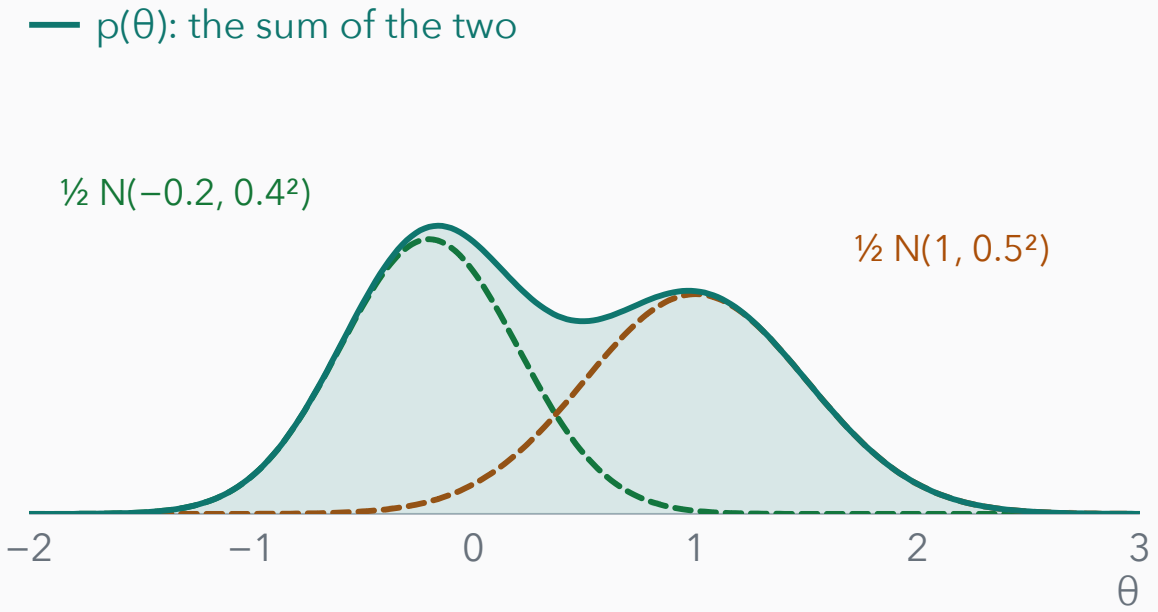
step 2: draw θ from bump z

bump 1: N(−0.2, 0.4²)
bump 2: N(1.0, 0.5²)

θ

θ | z ~ N(μ_z, σ_z^2)

We see θ. We never see which bump made it.



$$p(\theta) = \sum_k \pi_k \mathcal{N}(\theta; \mu_k, \sigma_k^2)$$

We see θ but not the bump that made it, so the density adds both bells: $p(\theta) = \Sigma_k \pi_k N(\theta; \mu_k, \sigma_k^2)$. Two bumps, one distribution.

▶ Notebook 3.4

Draw from the mixture yourself

step 1: pick a bump

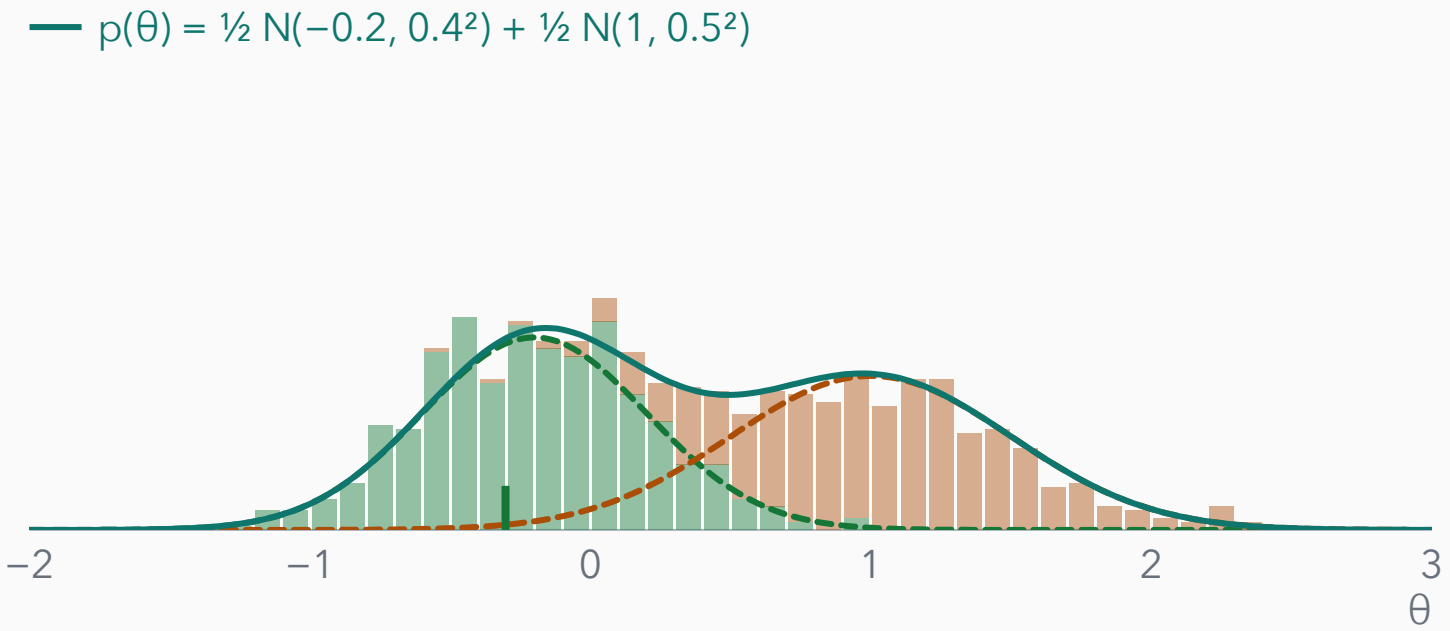
bump 1: probability ½
N(−0.2, 0.4²) · picked 539×

bump 2: probability ½
N(1.0, 0.5²) · picked 461×

step 2: draw θ from that bump

latest: bump 1, θ = −0.30

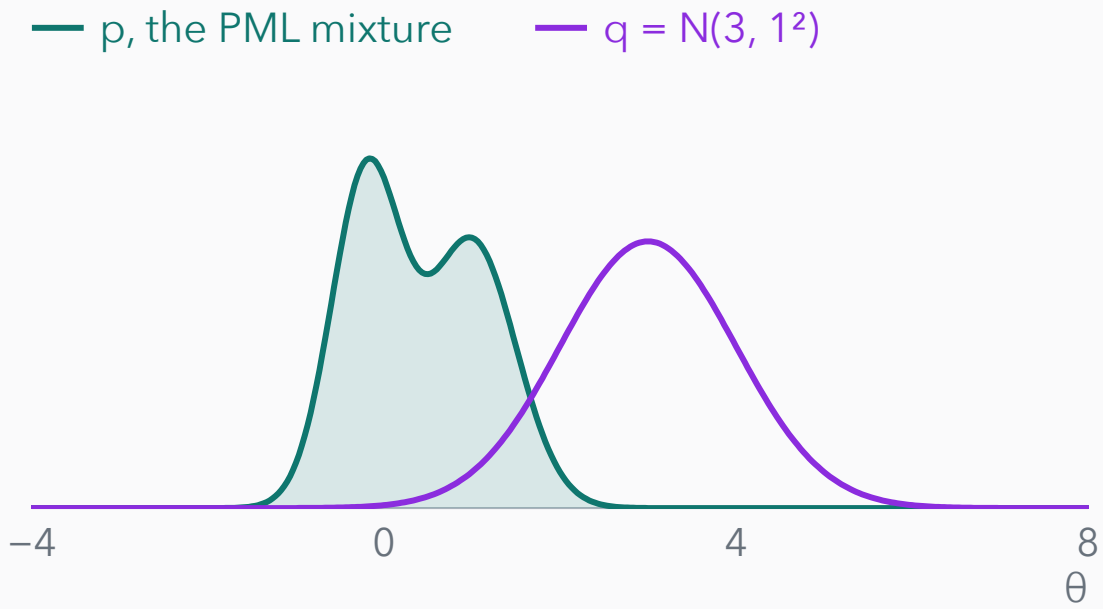
1,000 draws so far



> Each draw first picks a bump (its colour), then draws θ from it. Add 10, 100, then 1,000 draws and watch the histogram fill in the teal density.

▶ Notebook 3.4

PyTorch has no formula for this KL. The definition still works.




```
kl_divergence(q, mixture)
```

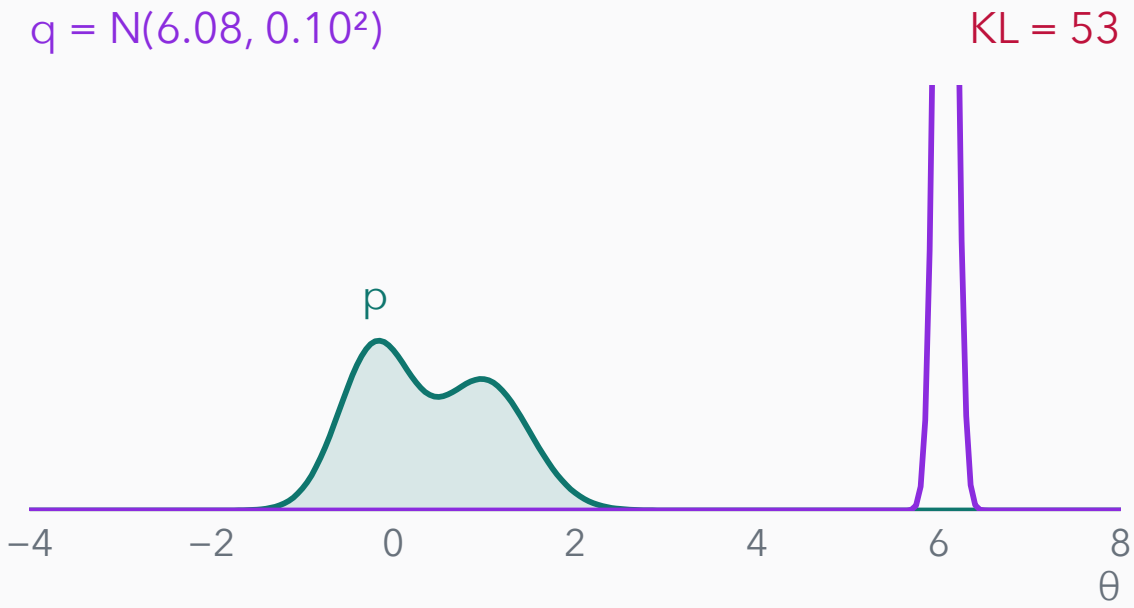
```
NotImplementedError:
No KL(p || q) is implemented
for p type Normal and
q type MixtureSameFamily
```

No formula exists for a Gaussian against a mixture. But KL(q‖p) is an average under q, and averages can be estimated by sampling, as in 2.7.

▶ Notebook 3.4

Now optimise it: the code runs, and q does not move

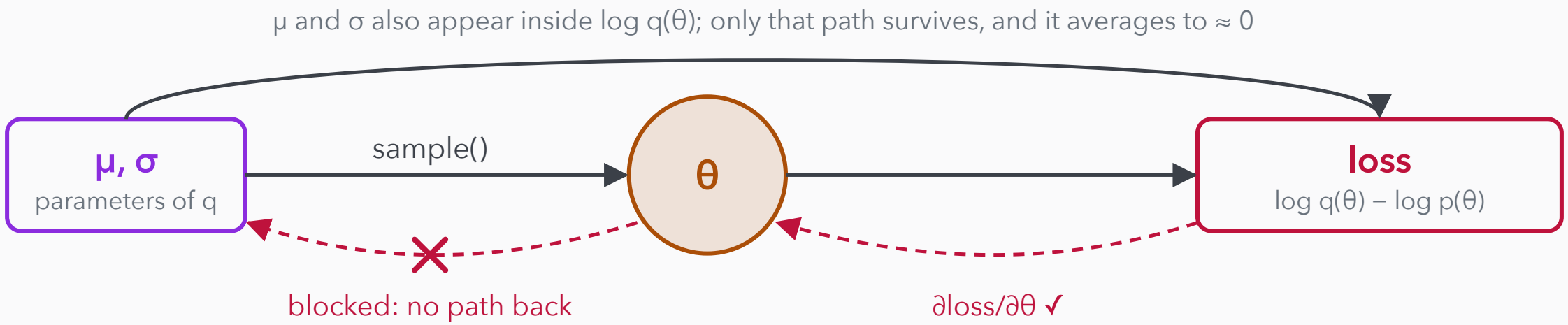
```
theta = q.sample((5000,))
log_q = q.log_prob(theta)
log_p = p.log_prob(theta)
loss = (log_q - log_p).mean()
opt.zero_grad()
loss.backward(); opt.step()
```



No error, no warning, and q stays at N(6, 0.1²): after 400 steps the KL is still about 53. Is this a bug? Hold that question: Section 3.5 answers it.

▶ Notebook 3.5

Why q does not move: the gradient stops at a random node



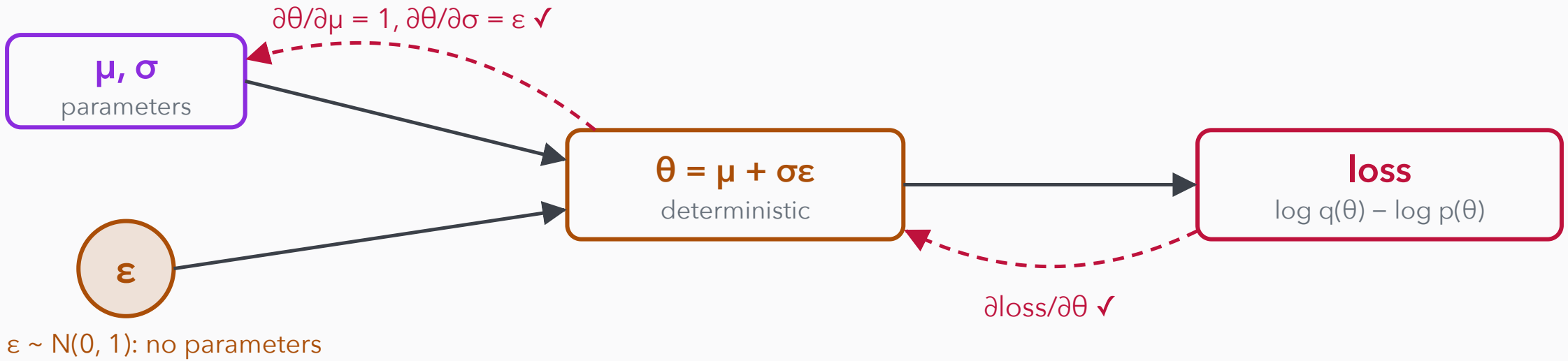
	$\partial \mathrm{KL}/\partial \mu$	$\partial \mathrm{KL}/\partial \sigma$
what autograd gets through sample()	0.0013	−0.0003
the true gradient	−0.063	−0.375

> Only the path through log q(θ)'s formula survives, and it averages to zero: 0.0013 and −0.0003 against −0.063 and −0.375. Not a bug: a missing path in the graph.

Graph conventions after Lilian Weng, "From Autoencoder to Beta-VAE", which follows Kingma's NIPS 2015 talk

▶ Notebook 3.5

The fix: move the randomness into ε, and θ = μ + σε



$$\epsilon \sim \mathcal{N}(0,1), \qquad \theta = \mu + \sigma\epsilon \qquad\qquad \theta = -1.5, \quad \frac{\partial\theta}{\partial\mu} = 1, \quad \frac{\partial\theta}{\partial\sigma} = \epsilon = -0.75$$

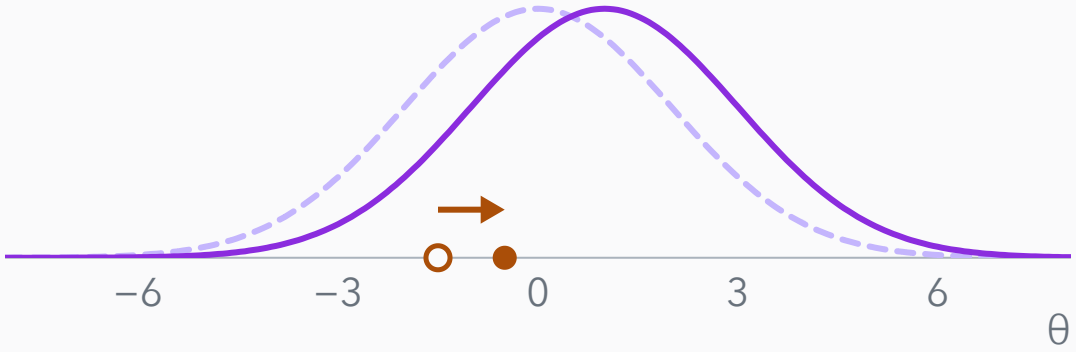
> θ = −1.5, ∂θ/∂μ = 1 and ∂θ/∂σ = ε = −0.75. The only random node, ε, has no parameters, so nothing blocks the path. In PyTorch this is rsample().

Graph conventions after Lilian Weng, "From Autoencoder to Beta-VAE"

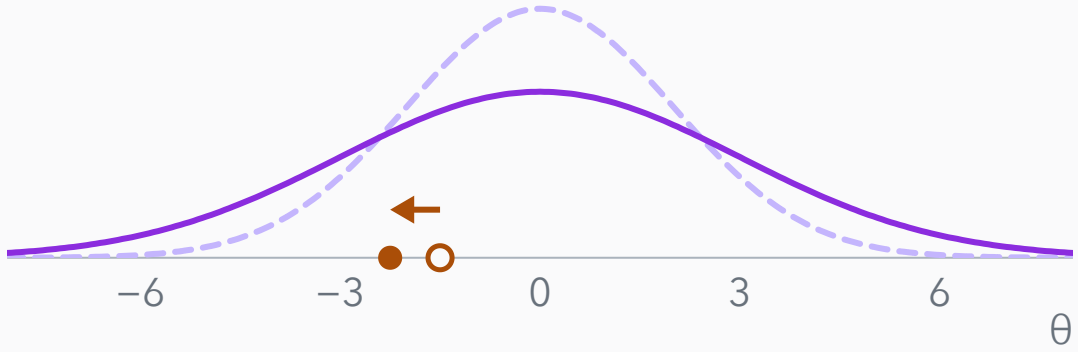
▶ Notebook 3.5

What a fixed ε does when μ or σ changes

move μ from 0 to 1 θ: −1.50 → −0.50



widen σ from 2 to 3 θ: −1.50 → −2.25

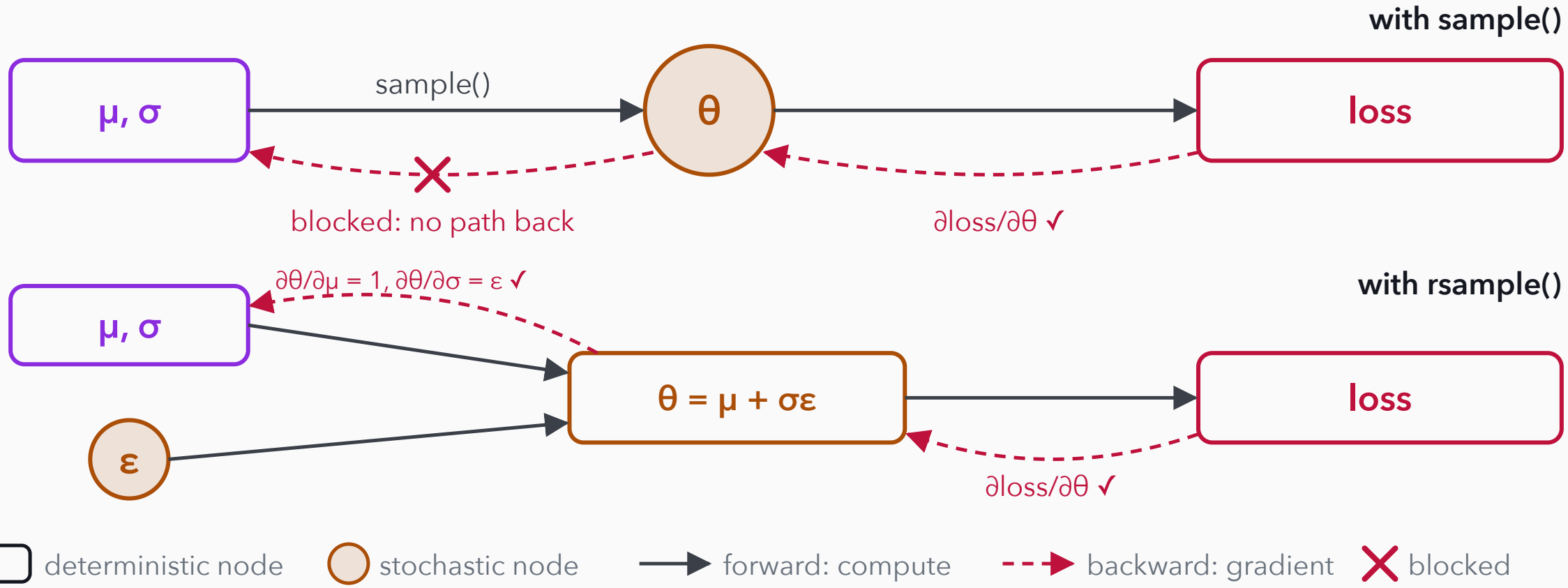


$$\frac{\partial \theta}{\partial \mu} = 1, \qquad \frac{\partial \theta}{\partial \sigma} = \epsilon = -0.75$$

> Widen σ by 1: the draw moves by ε = −0.75, further out on its side. These are the derivatives the gradient needs.

▶ Notebook 3.5

Side by side: where the randomness lives



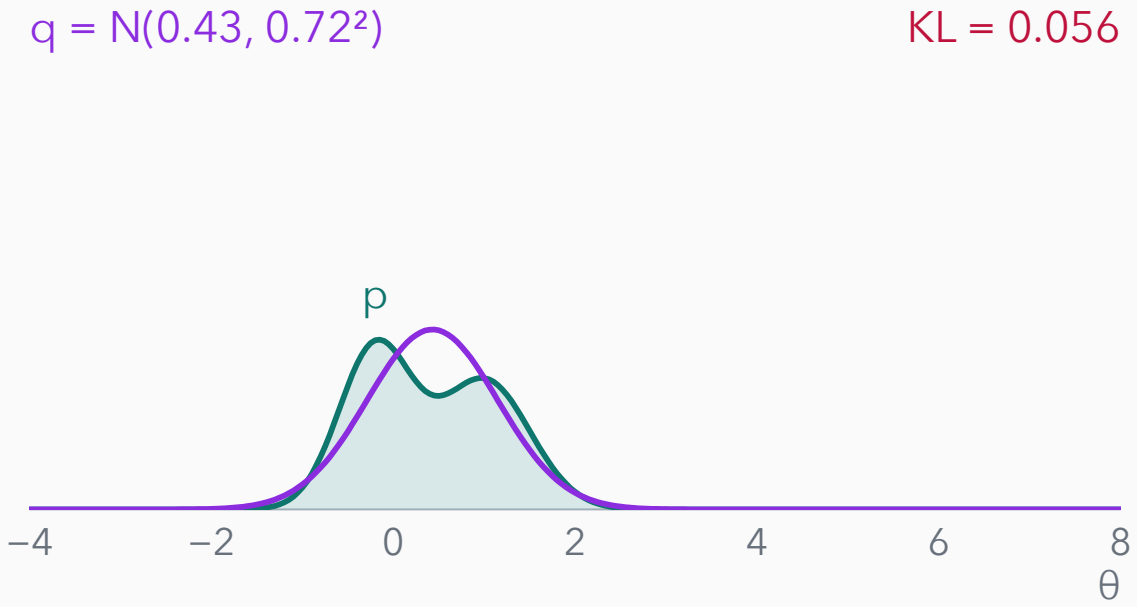
> With rsample(), the randomness enters as a parameter-free input ε and θ = μ + σε is deterministic: the gradient flows from the loss to μ and σ. Same distribution, different graph.

Graph conventions after Lilian Weng, "From Autoencoder to Beta-VAE"

▶ Notebook 3.5

Change one word: rsample() fits the mixture

```
# one word changed
theta = q.rsample((5000,))
log_q = q.log_prob(theta)
log_p = p.log_prob(theta)
loss = (log_q - log_p).mean()
opt.zero_grad()
loss.backward(); opt.step()
```

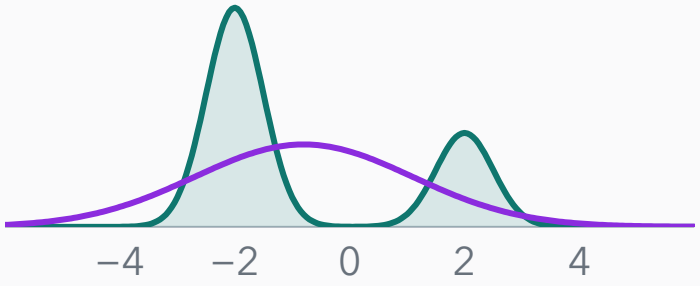


q settles at N(0.43, 0.72²), KL = 0.056: the best single Gaussian for this mixture. No formula was needed.

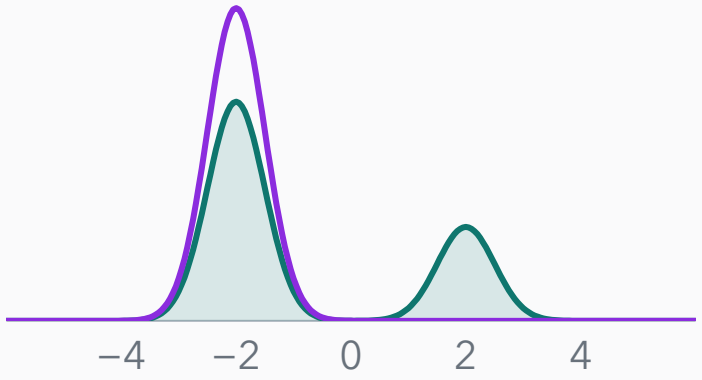
▶ Notebook 3.6

The price: reverse KL picks one bump

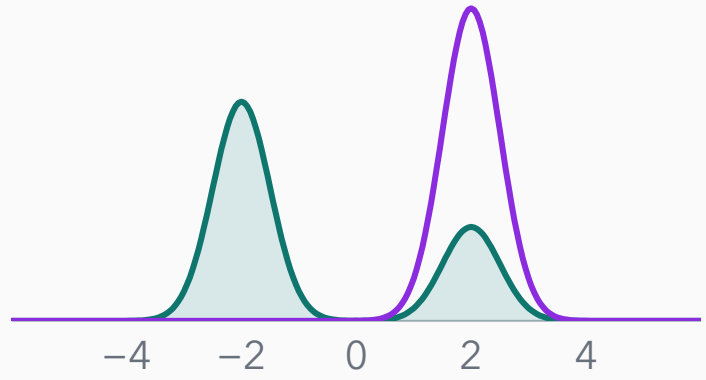
KL(p||q) 0.72



KL(q||p), start left 0.36



KL(q||p), start right 1.20



KL(p||q) spreads over both bumps. KL(q||p) locks onto whichever bump is nearer its start, and reports it confidently.

▶ Notebook 4.1

Back to Bayes: minimise KL to the posterior directly?

$$\mathrm{KL}\big(q_\psi(\theta) \,\|\, p(\theta \mid \mathcal{D})\big) = \mathbb{E}_{\theta\sim q}\big[\log q_\psi(\theta) - \log p(\theta \mid \mathcal{D})\big]$$

the loss needs	available?
draws θ ~ q	yes: rsample, as in 3.5
$\log q_\psi(\theta)$	yes
$\log p(\theta \mid \mathcal{D})$	no: it needs p($\mathcal{D}$), the integral of 1.4

> Everything is available except log p(θ | $\mathcal{D}$), which needs the evidence p($\mathcal{D}$): the integral we cannot do. Four small steps get rid of it.

A careful written derivation: Gregory Gundersen, "The ELBO in Variational Inference"

▶ Notebook 4.1

Step 1: Bayes' rule, in logs

$$p(\theta \mid \mathcal{D}) = \frac{p(\mathcal{D} \mid \theta)\, p(\theta)}{p(\mathcal{D})}$$

$$\log p(\theta \mid \mathcal{D}) = \log p(\mathcal{D} \mid \theta) + \log p(\theta) - \log p(\mathcal{D})$$

Rule: log(a · b / c) = log a + log b − log c.

Look at the last term: $\log p(\mathcal{D})$ has no θ in it. Whatever θ is, it is the same number, fixed by our model and our data.

> The last term does not contain θ: it is one fixed number. Remember that; it does the work in step 3.

▶ Notebook 4.1

Step 2: substitute into the KL

$$\mathrm{KL}\big(q \,\|\, p(\theta \mid \mathcal{D})\big) = \mathbb{E}_q\big[\log q(\theta) - \log p(\theta \mid \mathcal{D})\big]$$

$$= \mathbb{E}_q\Big[\log q(\theta) - \big(\log p(\mathcal{D} \mid \theta) + \log p(\theta) - \log p(\mathcal{D})\big)\Big]$$

$$= \mathbb{E}_q\big[\log q(\theta) - \log p(\mathcal{D} \mid \theta) - \log p(\theta) + \log p(\mathcal{D})\big]$$

$E_q[\,\cdot\,]$ means: draw θ from q, evaluate the bracket, average. Rule used: −(a + b − c) = −a − b + c.

> Open the brackets: every sign flips, and log p($\mathcal{D}$) now enters with a plus sign.

▶ Notebook 4.1

Step 3: a constant comes out of an average

$$\mathbb{E}_q\big[f(\theta) + c\big] = \mathbb{E}_q\big[f(\theta)\big] + c \qquad \text{when } c \text{ does not depend on } \theta$$

	three draws	their average
$f(\theta)$	2, 4, 6	4
$f(\theta) + 10$	12, 14, 16	14 = 4 + 10

$$\mathrm{KL}\big(q \,\|\, p(\theta \mid \mathcal{D})\big) = \mathbb{E}_q\big[\log q(\theta) - \log p(\mathcal{D} \mid \theta) - \log p(\theta)\big] + \log p(\mathcal{D})$$

> log p($\mathcal{D}$) is such a constant: step 1 showed it has no θ. So it leaves the average.

▶ Notebook 4.1

Step 4: rearrange, and name the part we can compute

$$\mathrm{KL}\big(q \,\|\, p(\theta \mid \mathcal{D})\big) = -\mathbb{E}_q\big[\log p(\mathcal{D} \mid \theta) + \log p(\theta) - \log q(\theta)\big] + \log p(\mathcal{D})$$

$$\log p(\mathcal{D}) = \mathbb{E}_q\big[\log p(\mathcal{D} \mid \theta) + \log p(\theta) - \log q(\theta)\big] + \mathrm{KL}\big(q \,\|\, p(\theta \mid \mathcal{D})\big)$$

$$\log p(\mathcal{D}) = \underbrace{\mathbb{E}_q\big[\log p(\mathcal{D} \mid \theta) + \log p(\theta) - \log q(\theta)\big]}_{\mathrm{ELBO}(q)} + \mathrm{KL}\big(q \,\|\, p(\theta \mid \mathcal{D})\big)$$

> Give the average a name: the ELBO, the evidence lower bound. Every term in it is computable: draws from q, the likelihood, the prior and log q. No p($\mathcal{D}$) anywhere.

▶ Notebook 4.1

One fixed number = what we can compute + what we cannot

$$\underbrace{\log p(\mathcal{D})}_{\text{fixed}} = \underbrace{\mathrm{ELBO}(q)}_{\text{computable}} + \underbrace{\mathrm{KL}\big(q \,\|\, p(\theta \mid \mathcal{D})\big)}_{\text{unknown, but } \geq 0}$$

piece	what it is	changes with q?
$\log p(\mathcal{D})$	the log evidence: the data's probability, averaged over every θ	no: fixed
$\mathrm{ELBO}(q)$	average under q of log likelihood + log prior − log q	yes; computable
the KL	how far q is from the posterior	yes; ≥ 0, and 0 only at the posterior

> The KL is the part we want small. We cannot compute it, but we know one thing about it: it is never negative.

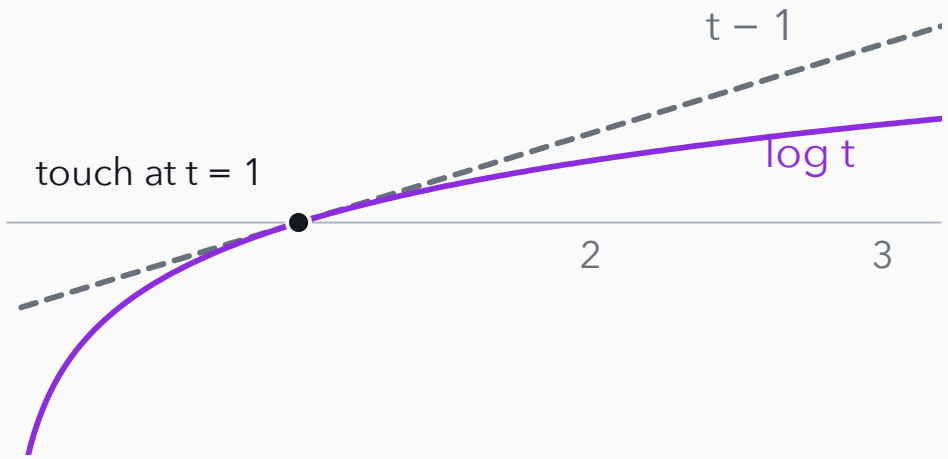
▶ Notebook 4.1

Why KL is never negative

$$\log t \le t - 1 \quad \text{for every } t > 0$$

$$-\mathrm{KL}(q\|p) = \mathbb{E}_q\left[\log \frac{p(\theta)}{q(\theta)}\right] \le \mathbb{E}_q\left[\frac{p(\theta)}{q(\theta)} - 1\right]$$

$$\mathbb{E}_q\left[\frac{p}{q}\right] = \int q(\theta)\,\frac{p(\theta)}{q(\theta)}\,d\theta = \int p(\theta)\,d\theta = 1$$



So $-\mathrm{KL} \le 1 - 1 = 0$: KL ≥ 0, and KL = 0 only when q = p.

> The average of p/q under q is the integral of p, which is 1. So minus the KL is at most 1 − 1 = 0.

▶ Notebook 4.1

The ELBO is a lower bound on the log evidence

In plain words: whatever q we choose, the **ELBO** never rises above the **log evidence log p($\mathcal{D}$)**. It is a lower bound **on log p($\mathcal{D}$)**: an **E**vidence **L**ower **BO**und.

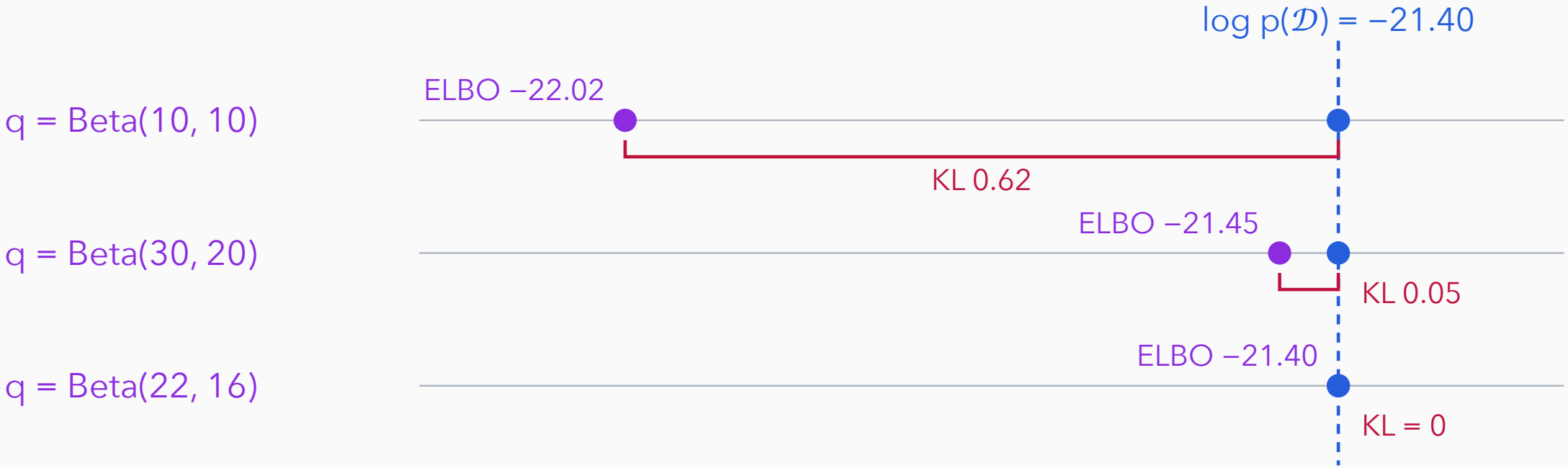
$$\mathrm{ELBO}(q) = \log p(\mathcal{D}) - \underbrace{\mathrm{KL}\big(q \,\|\, p(\theta \mid \mathcal{D})\big)}_{\geq 0} \leq \log p(\mathcal{D})$$

	log p($\mathcal{D}$)	it is the log of …
the coin: discrete data	−21.40	a probability: never above 0
our network: continuous data	−1.43	a density: either sign

> "Lower bound" says nothing about signs: a probability is at most 1, but a density can exceed it (log p($\mathcal{D}$ | θ_A) = +12.2). Only the order is guaranteed.

▶ Notebook 4.1

Raise the ELBO, and the KL falls by exactly as much



$$\max_q \ \mathrm{ELBO}(q) \quad \Longleftrightarrow \quad \min_q \ \mathrm{KL}\big(q \,\|\, p(\theta \mid \mathcal{D})\big)$$

> So maximising the ELBO, which we can compute, minimises the KL to the posterior, which we cannot. At the best q the gap is 0.

▶ Notebook 4.1

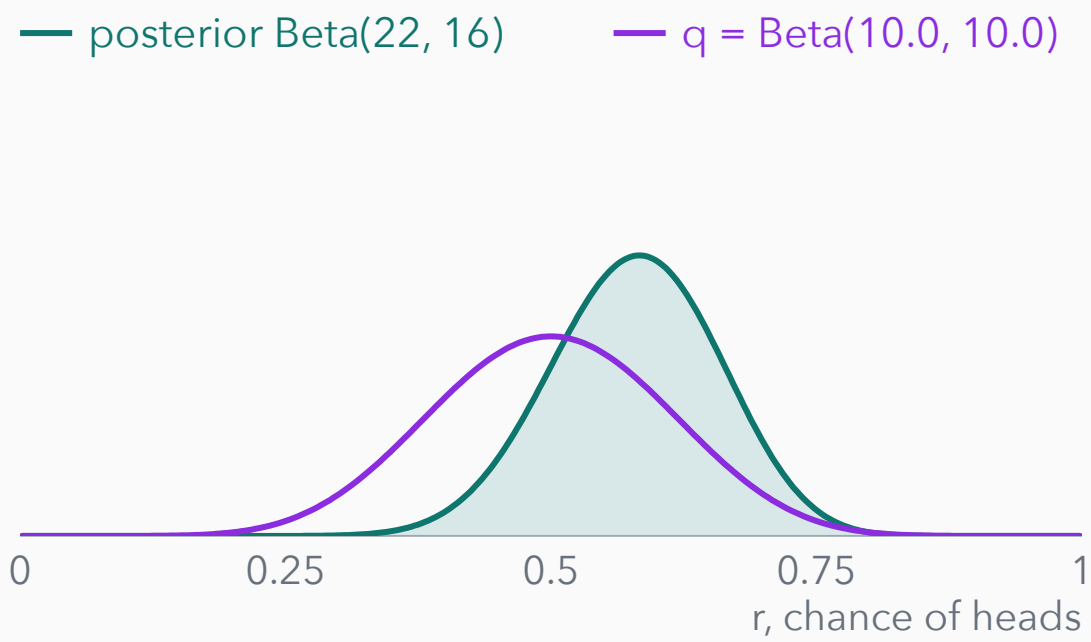
The ELBO in two terms: fit the data, stay near the prior

$$\begin{aligned}\mathrm{ELBO}(q) &= \mathbb{E}_q\big[\log p(\mathcal{D} \mid \theta) + \log p(\theta) - \log q(\theta)\big] \\ &= \mathbb{E}_q\big[\log p(\mathcal{D} \mid \theta)\big] + \mathbb{E}_q\big[\log p(\theta) - \log q(\theta)\big] \\ &= \underbrace{\mathbb{E}_q\big[\log p(\mathcal{D} \mid \theta)\big]}_{\text{fit the data}} - \underbrace{\mathrm{KL}\big(q(\theta) \,\|\, p(\theta)\big)}_{\text{stay near the prior}}\end{aligned}$$

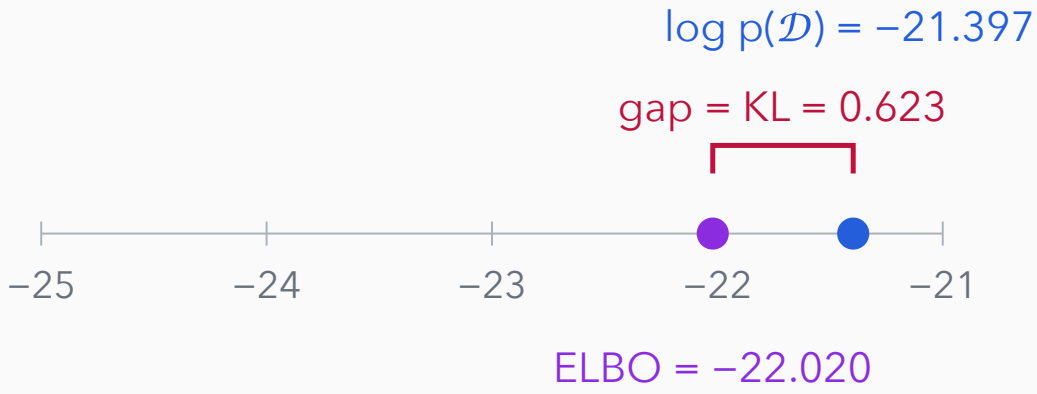
> The rest is minus a KL, from q to the prior. Fit the data, but stay near the prior. For our network the second term is the diagonal-Gaussian formula of 2.6; the first needs samples.

▶ Notebook 4.2

Check the identity where p($\mathcal{D}$) is known: a coin



One fixed total



−22.020 + 0.623 = −21.397

A coin with a Beta(5, 3) prior and 17 heads in 30 tosses has an exact posterior and an exact p($\mathcal{D}$). Drag q: the ELBO and the KL trade off, and their sum never changes.

▶ Notebook 5.1

The ELBO for our network, in code

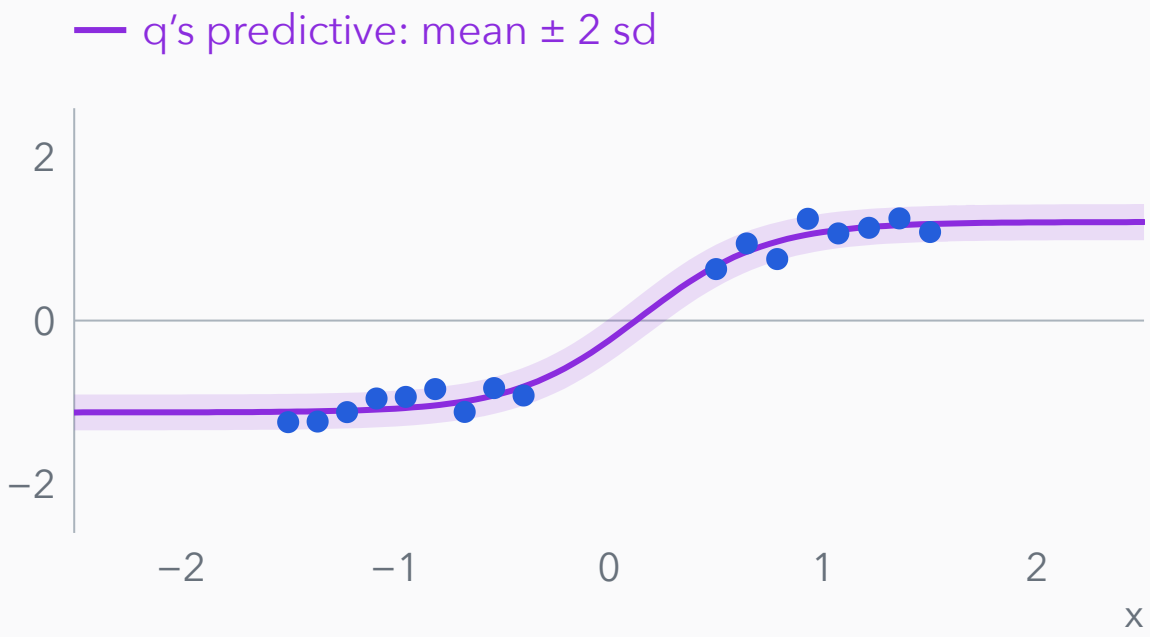

```
mu  = Parameter(0.5 * randn(7))          # 7 means
rho = Parameter(full((7,), log(0.1)))    # 7 log-widths
q = Normal(mu, rho.exp())                # one bell per parameter
theta = q.rsample((16,))                 # 16 sampled networks
log_lik = log_likelihood(theta).mean()   # forward pass
kl = kl_divergence(q, prior).sum()       # closed form
loss = -(log_lik - kl)                   # minus the ELBO
```

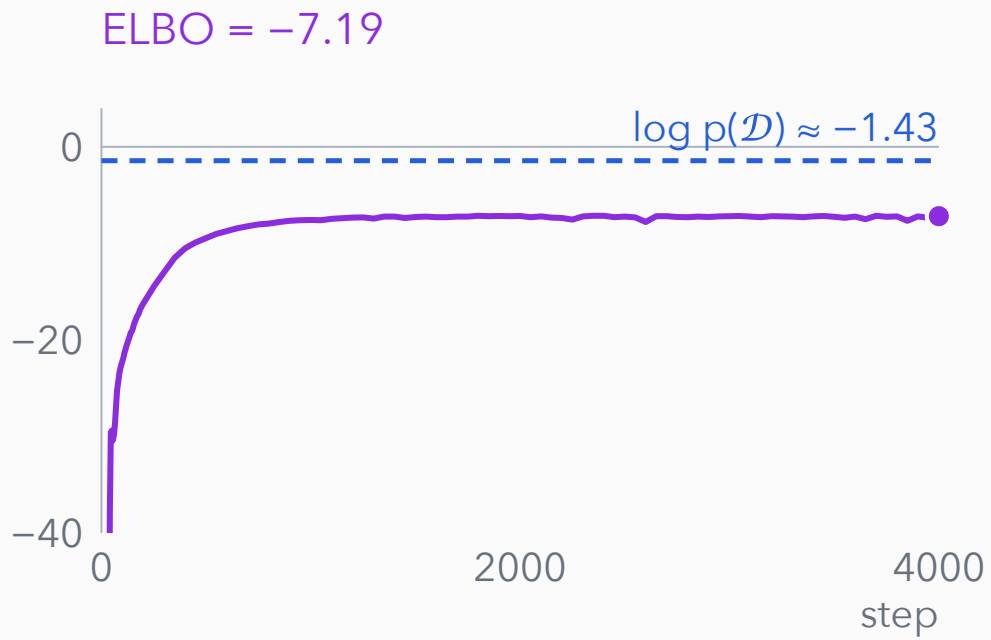
Adam, learning rate 0.02, 4,000 steps; best of five random starts. No p($\mathcal{D}$) anywhere.

> Every line is computable: rsample, a forward pass and a formula. Never p($\mathcal{D}$).

▶ Notebook 5.1

Press play: q learns the network

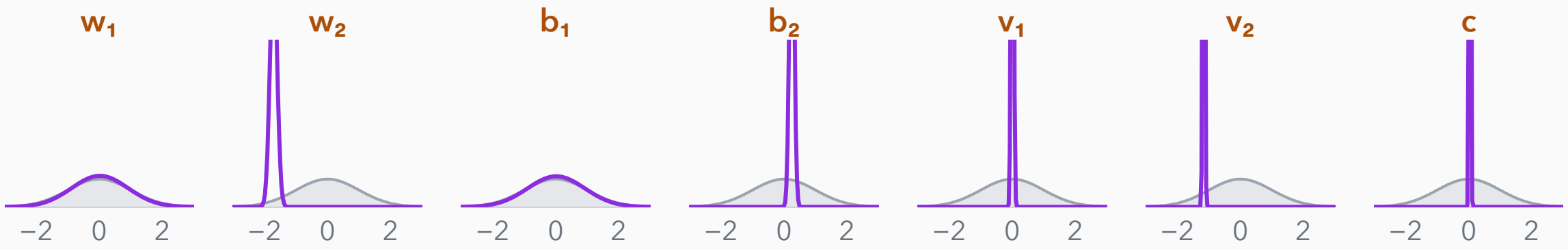




> The ELBO climbs from −1,235 to about −7.2 and the band settles onto the data. It stays below log p(𝒟) ≈ −1.43.

▶ Notebook 5.1

What q learned: one hidden unit switched off



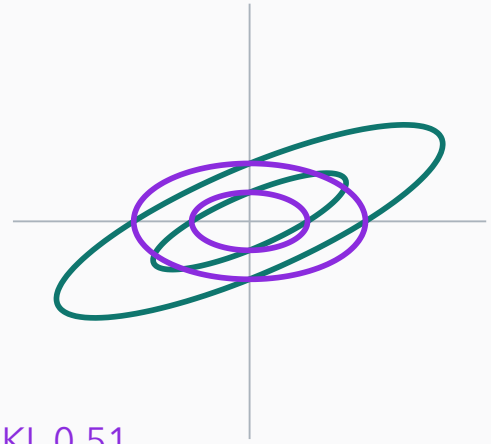
$v_1 \approx 0.01$ with width 0.035: the first hidden unit is switched off, and its w_1 and b_1 fall back to the prior.

> VI switched the first hidden unit off. Mean-field VI often prunes units like this: every parameter kept away from the prior costs KL.

▶ Notebook 5.1

Mean-field VI, and full-covariance VI

diagonal q (mean-field)



KL 0.51

full-covariance q



KL ≈ 0

$$\text{mean-field: } q(\theta) = \prod_{j=1}^{7} \mathcal{N}(\theta_j; \mu_j, \sigma_j^2)$$

One independent bell per parameter: the diagonal family of 3.3. 7 + 7 = 14 numbers.

$$\text{full covariance: } q(\theta) = \mathcal{N}\left(\mu,\, LL^\top\right)$$

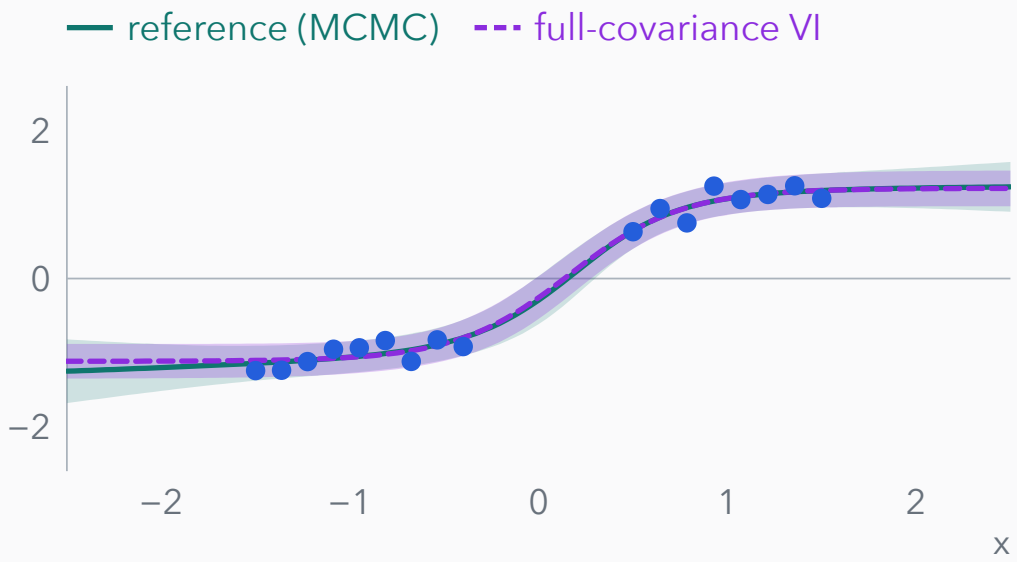
One tilted bell in $\mathbb{R}^7$: 7 + 28 = 35 numbers; d(d + 1)/2 in general.

Full q: correlation −0.76 between w_2 and v_2; ELBO −7.18 → −6.32.

> Starting from the mean-field answer, it learns that a steeper w_2 goes with a smaller v_2, and the ELBO rises by 0.86 nats: the KL to the posterior falls by exactly that much.

▶ Notebook 5.1

Against the reference: the right curve, bands still too narrow



	ELBO	sd at −2.5	sd at 2.5
mean-field	−7.18	0.110	0.110
full covariance	−6.32	0.117	0.120
MCMC reference	$\log p(\mathcal{D}) \approx -1.43$	0.215	0.168

> Full covariance helps a little. The rest of the gap is the family: the posterior has several modes (swap the hidden units, flip signs), and one Gaussian sits on one.

▶ Notebook 5.2

Six obstacles, six tools

obstacle	tool	where
$p(\mathcal{D})$ is an impossible integral	approximate the posterior with q	1.4 – 1.5
"close" needs a number	KL(q ‖ p)	2.1 – 2.4
a grid cannot search 14 numbers	gradient descent	3.1 – 3.2
no formula for the average	Monte Carlo	2.5, 3.4
no gradient through a draw	$\theta = \mu + \sigma\varepsilon$, rsample()	3.5
KL to the posterior needs $p(\mathcal{D})$	maximise the ELBO	4.1

> Every obstacle today earned a tool, and our network used them all. In Lecture 2 a VAE does the same with one q per image.

▶ Notebook 5.2

Generative models create this inference problem again

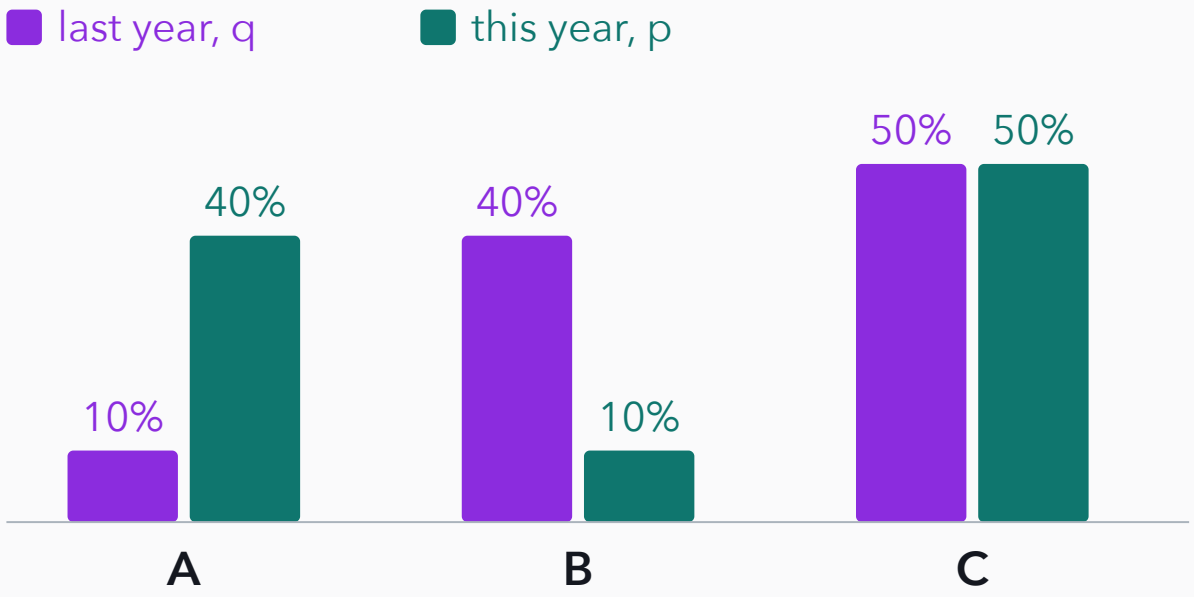
A hidden description can generate an observation.

Next: learn representations for images, then ask whether they can generate new ones.

> Lecture 2 builds autoencoders, then returns to VI with an encoder that outputs q for each image: the VAE.

▶ Notebook

By hand: two runs of this course, two grade distributions



Appendix: KL by hand. A second route to the same formula.

Grades in last year's run (q) and this year's (p).

A: 10% → 40%. B: 40% → 10%. C: 50% both years.

> Four times as many A's, a quarter as many B's, the same share of C's.

KL intuition after ritvikmath, "The KL Divergence: Data Science Basics" (YouTube)

Compare grade by grade: ratios

grade	p	q	p/q
A	0.4	0.1	4
B	0.1	0.4	¼
C	0.5	0.5	1



Average the ratios? (4 + ¼ + 1) / 3 = 1.75. Identical years would give 1, not 0, and ×4 sits 3 above 1 while ÷4 sits only 0.75 below.

> Averaging raw ratios is lopsided: a fourfold rise counts four times as much as a fourfold fall.

KL intuition after ritvikmath, "The KL Divergence: Data Science Basics" (YouTube)

What should a ratio count for? Find the function

We want a function f of the ratio r with:

$$f(1) = 0$$

$$f(4) = +y, \qquad f(\tfrac{1}{4}) = -y$$

$$f(2 \cdot 2) = f(2) + f(2)$$

$f(r)$	$f(\frac{1}{4})$	$f(1)$	$f(4)$	$f(2) + f(2)$
$r - 1$	−0.75	0	3	2 ≠ 3 ✗
$r - \frac{1}{r}$	−3.75	0	3.75	3 ≠ 3.75 ✗
$\log r$	−1.39	0	1.39	1.39 = 1.39 ✓

> The logarithm passes every test: log 4 = 1.39, log ¼ = −1.39, and log 2 + log 2 = log 4.

▶ Notebook

Weight each grade by this year's share: that is KL

p(x) × log ratio, and their sum



$$\text{plain average: } \tfrac{1}{3}\left(1.39 - 1.39 + 0\right) = 0$$

$$\text{weighted: } 0.4(1.39) + 0.1(-1.39) + 0.5(0) = 0.42$$

$$\mathrm{KL}(p \,\|\, q) = \sum_x p(x) \log \frac{p(x)}{q(x)}$$

That weighted average of log ratios is the Kullback–Leibler divergence of p from q.

KL intuition after ritvikmath, "The KL Divergence: Data Science Basics" (YouTube)

▶ Notebook

The unit: nats, or bits

$$\mathrm{KL}(p\|q) = \sum_x p(x)\,\ln\frac{p(x)}{q(x)} = 0.42 \text{ nats}$$

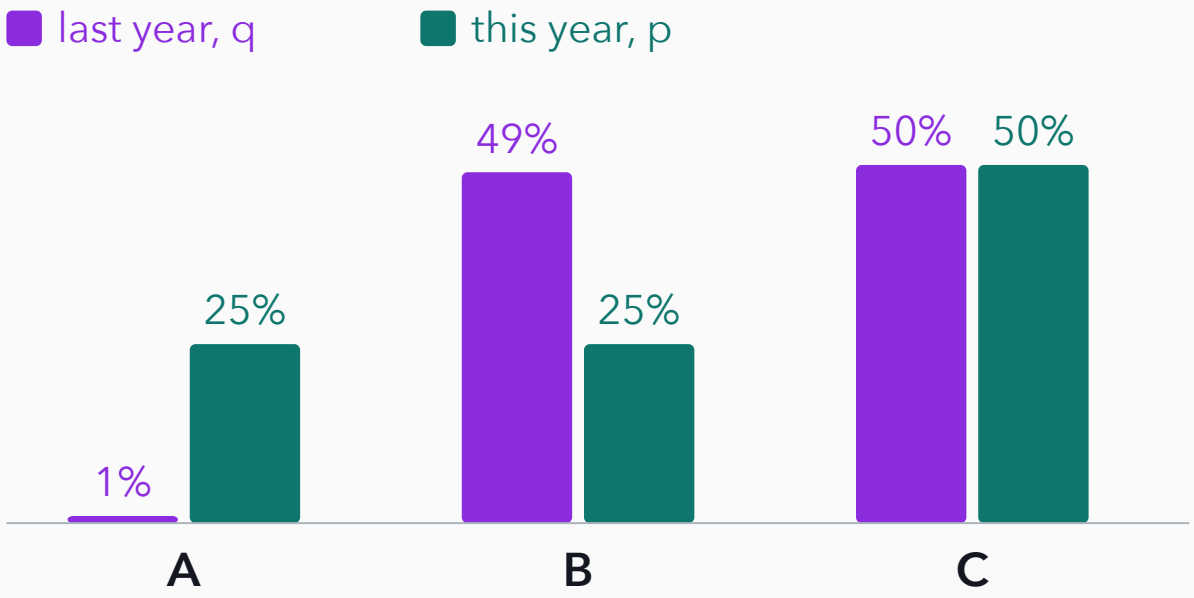
$$\sum_x p(x)\,\log_2\frac{p(x)}{q(x)} = 0.60 \text{ bits}$$

Read 0.42 nats as $e^{0.42} \approx 1.5$: on average, a grade from this year is 1.5 times more probable under this year's distribution than under last year's.

> 0.42 nats means a typical this-year grade is about 1.5 times more probable under this year's distribution than under last year's.

▶ Notebook

Swap the reference year: a different number



$$\mathrm{KL}(\text{this} \,\|\, \text{last}) = 0.64$$

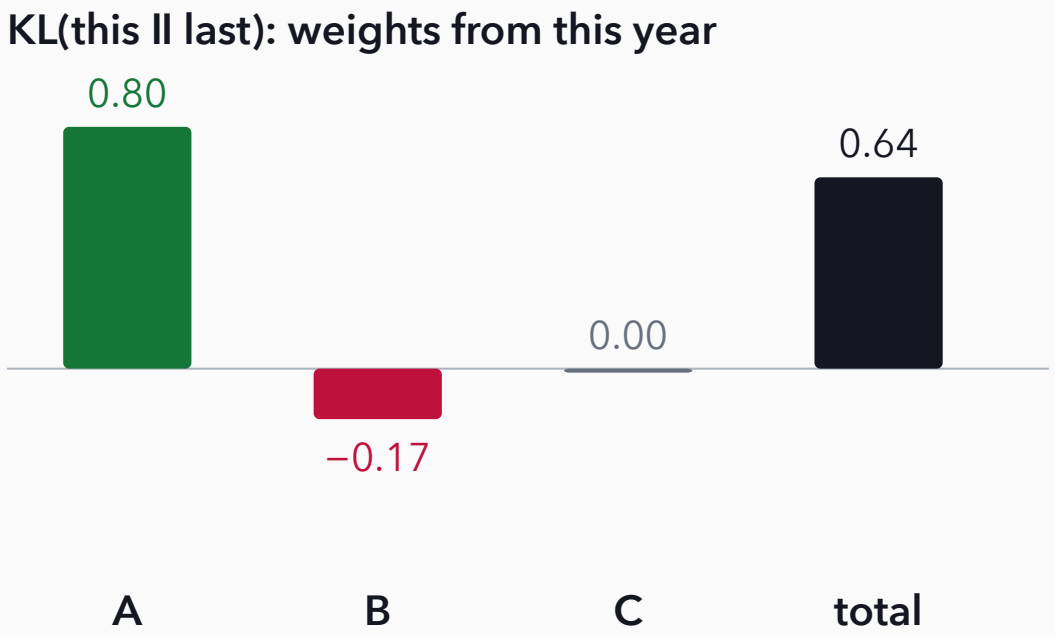
$$\mathrm{KL}(\text{last} \,\|\, \text{this}) = 0.30$$

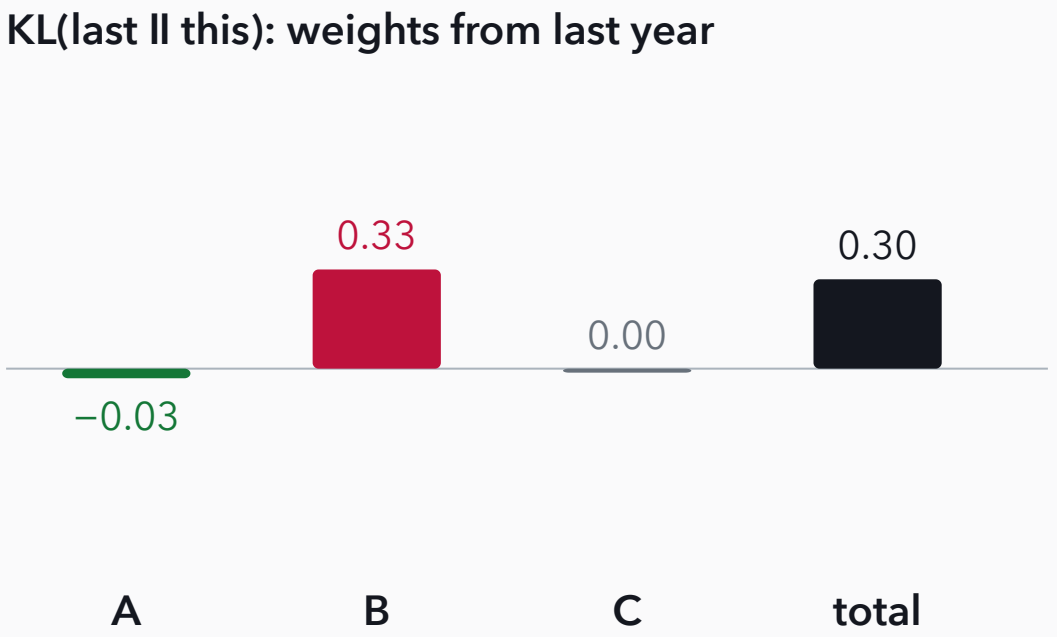
Which distribution comes first matters: KL is not symmetric.

> Measured from last year instead: 0.30 nats. Changing the reference changes the answer: KL is not symmetric.

▶ Notebook

Why the reference matters





The first distribution supplies the weights, so it decides which changes count.

> From last year's view A was rare, so its change barely counts (−0.03); the drop in B dominates instead.

▶ Notebook

Sample grades and watch the average find the KL

grades drawn from this year's p (latest 30)

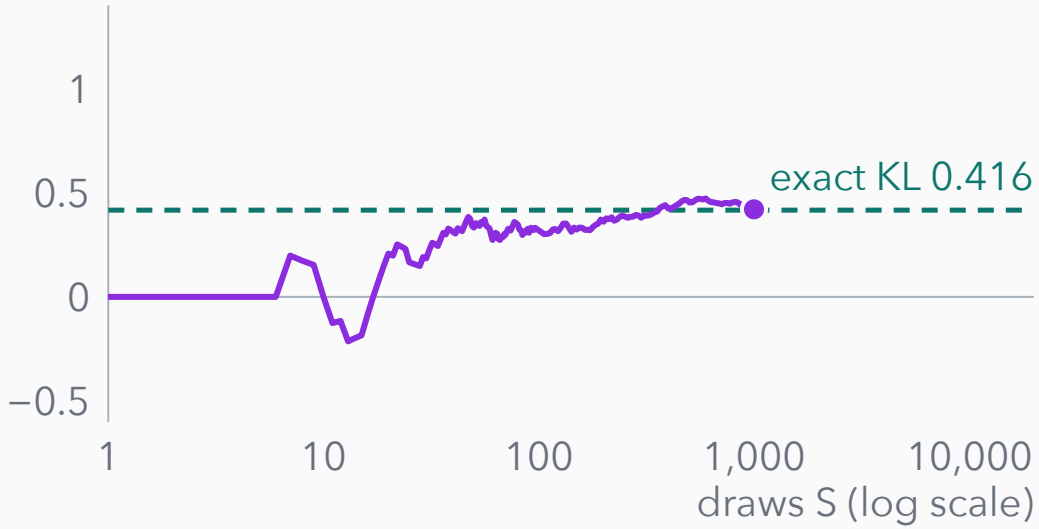
C	A	A	C	B	A	C	B	C	C
C	B	C	C	B	A	A	C	C	C
A	A	B	B	A	C	C	A	A	B

A: log ratio +1.39 — 411 draws, 41%

B: log ratio −1.39 — 108 draws, 11%

C: log ratio +0.00 — 481 draws, 48%

average of 1,000 log ratios: 0.420



> Draw grades from this year's distribution and average their log ratios. The counts approach 40%, 10%, 50%, and the average approaches the exact 0.42.

▶ Notebook

A KL estimator that is never negative

$$r = \frac{p(\theta)}{q(\theta)},\ \theta \sim q: \qquad \underbrace{-\log r}_{\text{plain}} \qquad \text{vs} \qquad \underbrace{r - 1 - \log r}_{\geq 0 \text{ for every draw}}$$

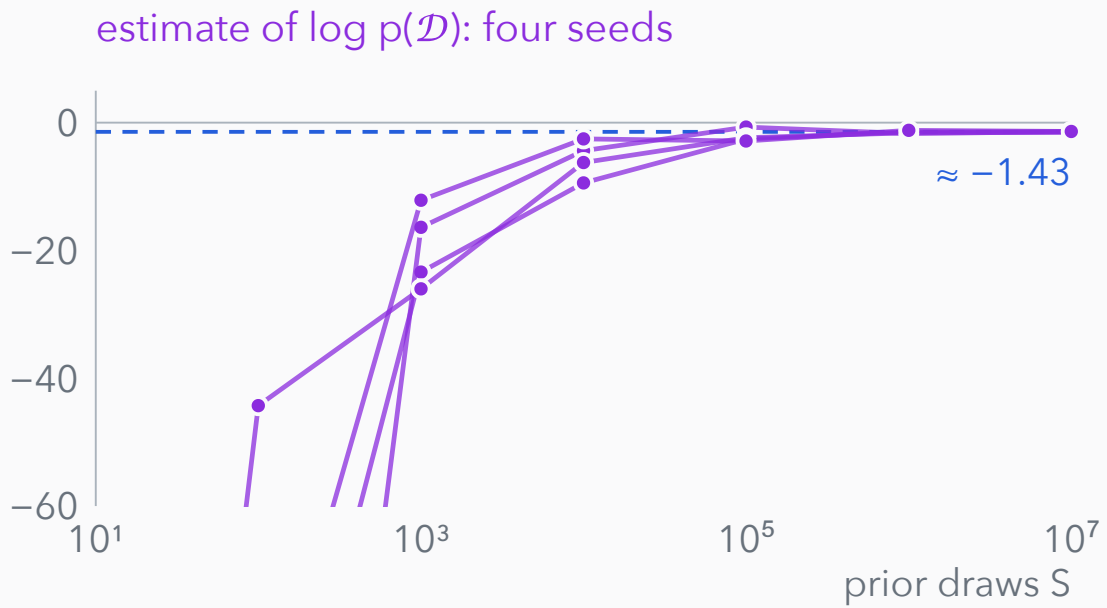
draws S	plain: spread	plain: negative	r – 1 – log r: spread	negative
5	0.299	34%	0.154	0%
10	0.219	24%	0.119	0%
100	0.072	0%	0.039	0%
1000	0.023	0%	0.013	0%

> When can the better estimator be worse?

After Jia-Bin Huang and John Schulman, "Approximating KL divergence"

▶ Notebook

Sampling from the prior: a few lucky draws carry everything



$$p(\mathcal{D}) \approx \frac{1}{S}\sum_{s=1}^{S} p(\mathcal{D} \mid \theta_s)$$

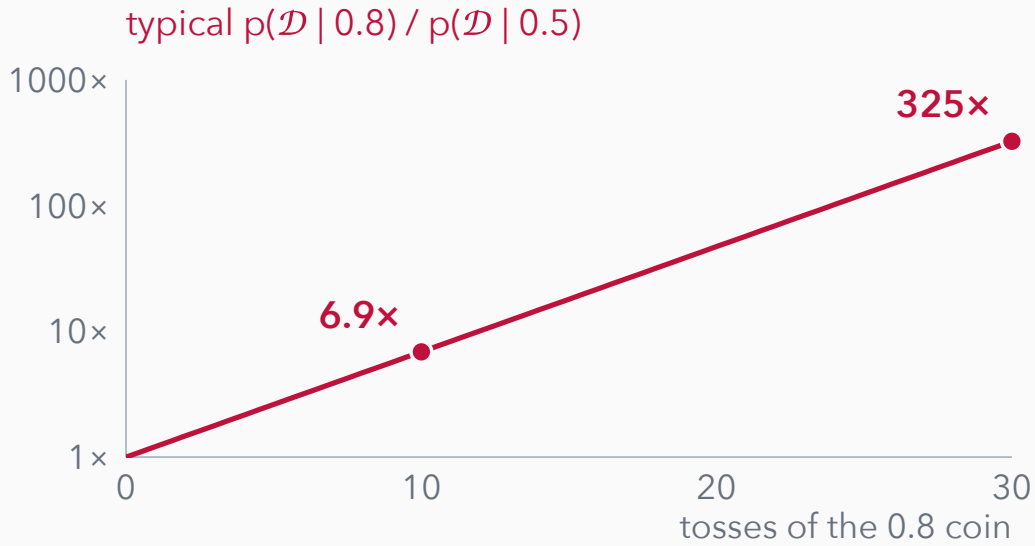
$$\theta_s \sim p(\theta)$$

Ten draws: off by about 1,000 nats. Ten million: about 103 draws carry the estimate, −1.43.

> Almost every prior draw explains the data terribly. Seven parameters just about work; more parameters or more data make it hopeless.

▶ Notebook

A KL value is how fast evidence piles up



$$\mathrm{KL}\big(\mathrm{Bern}(0.8) \,\|\, \mathrm{Bern}(0.5)\big) \approx 0.19 \text{ nats}$$

$$\frac{p(\mathcal{D} \mid 0.8)}{p(\mathcal{D} \mid 0.5)} \approx e^{0.19\,n}$$

The reverse direction, KL(0.5‖0.8) = 0.22, is a different number.

> About e^(30 × 0.19) ≈ 325. KL is the rate at which evidence piles up: 6.9× after 10 tosses, 325× after 30.

▶ Notebook

A sensor has an unknown constant bias

$$\theta \sim \mathcal{N}(0, 1), \qquad y_i \mid \theta \sim \mathcal{N}(\theta, 0.5^2)$$

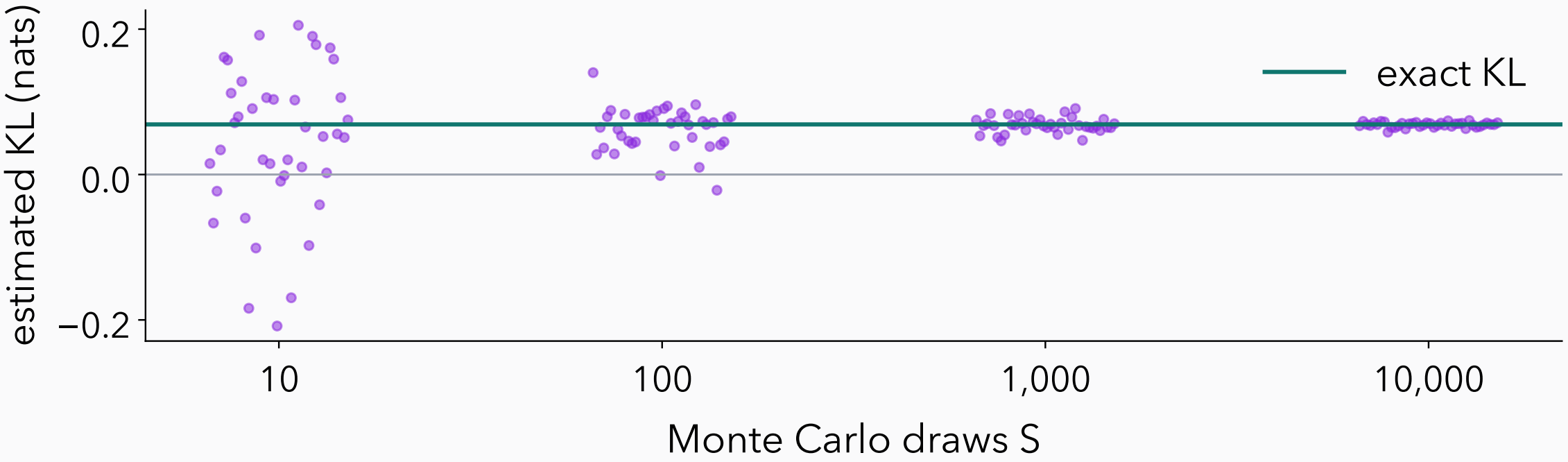
$$p(\mathcal{D}, \theta) = p(\theta) \prod_i p(y_i \mid \theta)$$

$$\max_{\psi} \mathbb{E}_{q_\psi(\theta)}[\log p(\mathcal{D}, \theta) - \log q_\psi(\theta)]$$

Maximise the ELBO over q's parameters. The same tools apply.

▶ Notebook

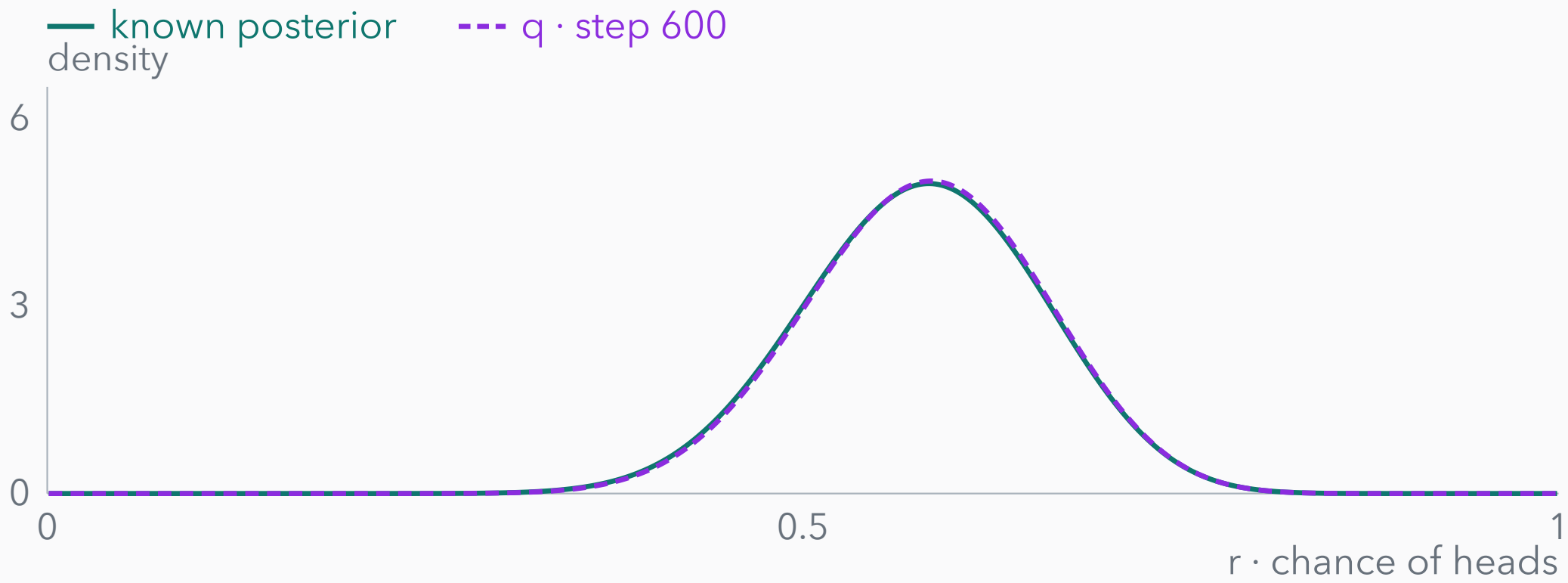
More samples, tighter estimates



Forty repeats at each sample size. The spread shrinks like $1/\sqrt{S}$; the exact value never moves.

▶ Notebook

A check with an answer key: the Beta coin



After 600 steps: Beta(22.4, 16.2), with KL ≈ 0.0002 to the true posterior.

▶ Notebook

One literal update of the mean

$$\sigma = 2 \text{ fixed}: \qquad L(\mu) = \text{const} + \frac{(\mu - 1)^2}{32}$$

$$\frac{\partial L}{\partial \mu} = \frac{\mu - 1}{16} = -0.0625 \ \text{ at } \mu = 0$$

$$\mu^{+} = 0 - 4(-0.0625) = 0.25: \quad \text{KL } 0.349 \to 0.336$$

Take one step with η = 4. What is the best KL with σ stuck at 2?

▶ Notebook

KL ≥ 0 by Jensen's inequality

$$\mathrm{KL}(q\|p) = -\mathbb{E}_q\left[\log \frac{p(\theta)}{q(\theta)}\right]$$

$$\geq -\log \mathbb{E}_q\left[\frac{p(\theta)}{q(\theta)}\right]$$

$$= -\log 1 = 0$$

What makes the final expectation one?

▶ Notebook

Five draws can give a negative KL estimate

θ_i	$\log q(\theta_i) - \log p(\theta_i)$
5.623	−0.232
0.120	0.269
−5.536	−0.751
2.705	0.217
−2.254	0.030

$$\widehat{\mathrm{KL}}_5 \approx -0.093, \qquad \mathrm{KL}(q\|p) \approx 0.069$$

> Does this contradict KL ≥ 0?

▶ Notebook

The two PML candidates, scored by Monte Carlo

candidate	MC estimate ± 1 s.e.	numerical integral
$N(3, 1^2)$	9.54 ± 0.03	9.49
$N(3, 4.5^2)$	45.02 ± 0.21	45.15

The narrow candidate scores far better. Both sit away from the mixture's mass, so both are poor.

> What role does the numerical integral play?

▶ Notebook

A fixed-noise finite difference checks the path

```
q = Normal(mu, sigma)
theta = q.rsample((S,))
loss = (q.log_prob(theta) - p.log_prob(theta)).mean()
```

derivative	autograd	finite difference
μ	−0.062466	−0.062466
σ	−0.372223	−0.372223

> What must stay fixed on both sides of the finite difference?

▶ Notebook

Pathwise gradients are one route, not the only one

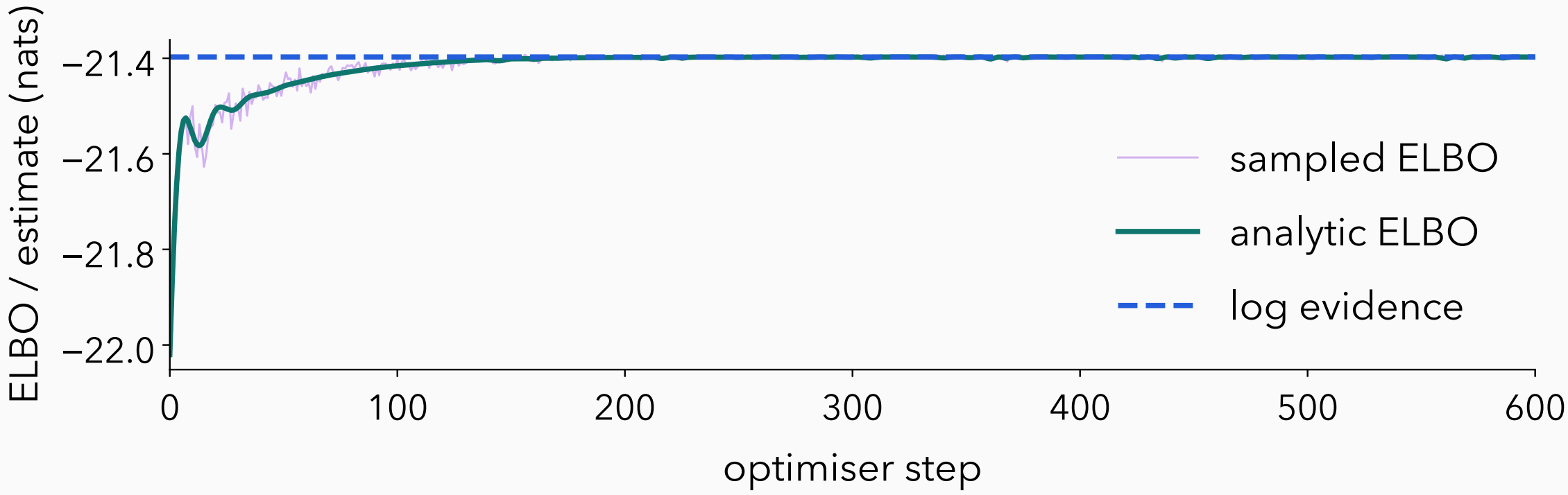
$$\nabla_\psi \mathbb{E}_{q_\psi}[f_\psi(\theta)] = \mathbb{E}_{q_\psi}[f_\psi(\theta)\nabla_\psi \log q_\psi(\theta) + \nabla_\psi f_\psi(\theta)]$$

A score-function estimator accounts explicitly for the changing sampling distribution.

> Does this identity require θ = μ + σε?

▶ Notebook

A noisy ELBO estimate can cross the evidence



162 of 600 sampled estimates lie above the known evidence in this run.

> Which object remains a lower bound?

▶ Notebook

A higher ELBO does not prove a zero gap

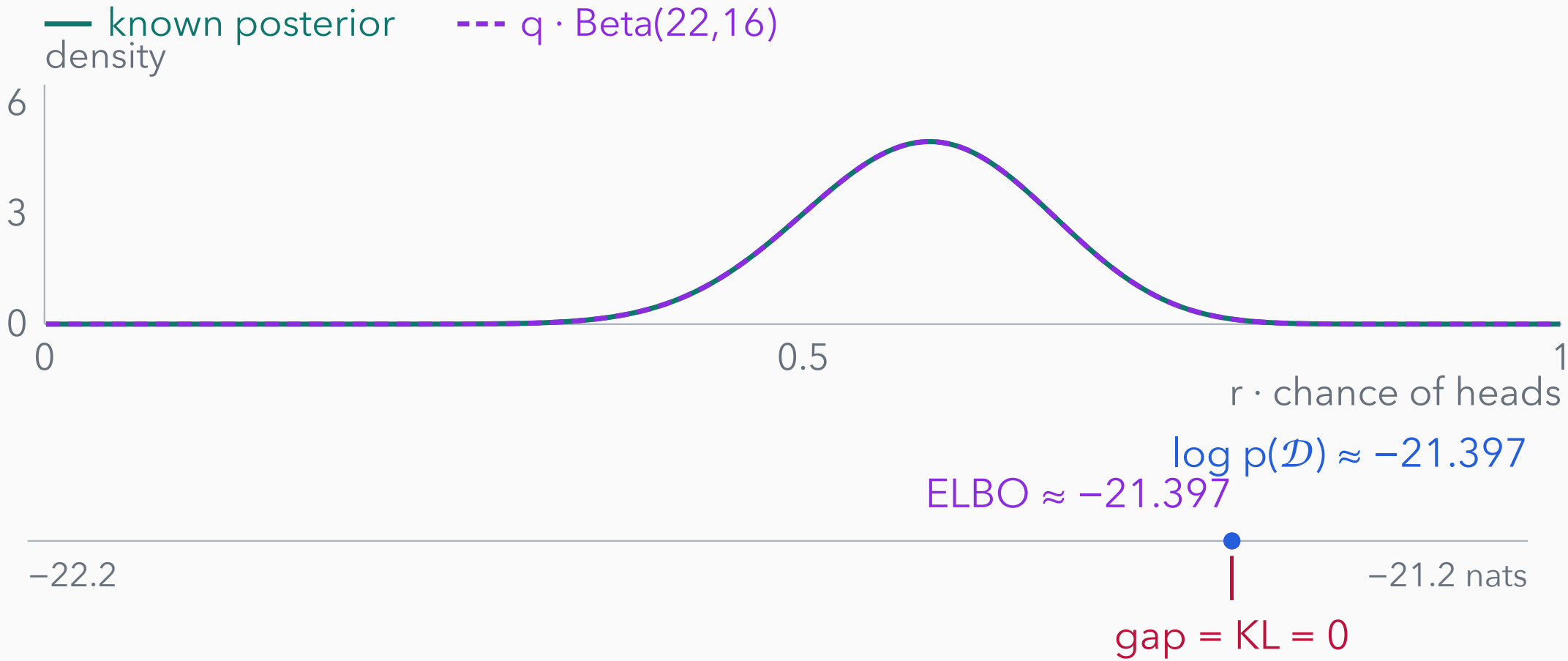
$$\mathrm{ELBO}(q_{\mathrm{new}}) > \mathrm{ELBO}(q_{\mathrm{old}})$$

The family may not contain the posterior, and optimisation may stop short.

> Does a stable loss establish q = p(θ | $\mathcal{D}$)?

▶ Notebook

Check the fixed total with three Beta candidates



What happens at the exact posterior?

▶ Notebook

A mean must say which dimension it averages

object	shape	correct reduction
S scalar Beta draws	[S]	mean over S
S d-dimensional joint log densities	[S]	mean over S
S factorised coordinate log densities	[S, d]	sum over d, then mean over S

MultivariateNormal.log_prob already sums the event dimension. Do not sum the sample axis as well.

> What goes wrong if you sum over S before averaging?

▶ Notebook

An ordered sequence and a count have different evidence

$$p(H = 17 \mid r) = \binom{30}{17} r^{17}(1-r)^{13}$$

observed object	log evidence
one ordered sequence	−21.397
only the head count	−2.796

> Does this constant change the posterior or its KL gap?

▶ Notebook

Check the sampled objective with analytic Beta moments

$$\mathbb{E}_q[\log r] = \text{digamma}(a) - \text{digamma}(a+b)$$

$$\mathbb{E}_q[\log(1-r)] = \text{digamma}(b) - \text{digamma}(a+b)$$

Insert these into expected log likelihood + expected log prior − expected log q.

> How was the identity checked non-circularly?